

Mahabharata



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF VYASA

The author of the *Mahabharata* is disputed, with many scholars believing it began as an oral tradition and so has multiple authors. Another tradition names the author as Vyasa, who appears in the poem as a character himself. One of the most widely read English-language editions of the poem is the abridged Penguin Classics version by John D. Smith, which condenses the sprawling poem into one large volume. Smith was a scholar of Sanskrit and Hindi who lectured at the University of London in the 1970s before becoming a professor at the University of Cambridge in 1984. His early work focused on the writing and traditions of Rajasthan, a northern state of India. In 1997, he began working on the *Mahabharata*, a task that took him until 2008—a full fifth of his life, as he once noted. Smith retired from Cambridge in 2007.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

As with the Bible and other holy texts, people have long debated how literally to interpret the version of history that the *Mahabharata* describes. By the time of the *Mahabharata*'s writing, India was still made up of several disparate kingdoms and empires, leading to power struggles similar to the Kurukshetra War in the epic poem. Buddhism and Jainism were both founded in India not too long before the first appearance of the full *Mahabharata*. The poem came out right around the same time as the "Hindu synthesis," when ideas from various traditions merged to become modern Hinduism, which has no single founder and remains a diverse religion with many local traditions and variations. Although few people ever read the complete unabridged *Mahabharata*, the events of the poem remain an enduring part of culture in India, even today. One of the poem's most famous followers was Mahatma Gandhi, who called the *Bhagavadgita* section of the poem the single greatest influence on his life and eventually created a Gujarati translation of it.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

As one of the foundational texts of Hinduism, the *Mahabharata* has several connections to other Hindu scriptures. The poem references the Vedas, a set of four volumes (with several subdivisions) that deal with philosophical and moral questions and are the oldest surviving Sanskrit holy writings. Tradition has it that the author of the *Mahabharata* (Vyasa) is also the one who compiled the Vedas. The *Mahabharata* sometimes earns comparisons to the *Ramayana* by Valmiki, another long Sanskrit

epic poem, which takes place before the events of the *Mahabharata* and features some of the same figures. The *Mahabharata* also shares characters with Sanskrit drama, perhaps most notably *Shakuntala*, a play by Kalidasa that expands on the story of king Dushshanta and Shakuntala. In the roughly two millennia since it was written, the *Mahabharata* has been adapted countless times, with a couple recent examples being Dharamvir Bharati's *Andha Yug*, V. S. Khandekar's *Yayati*, and Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni's *The Palace of Illusions*.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Mahabharata
- **Where Written:** Ancient India
- **When Published:** Between 300 B.C.E. and 300 C.E.
- **Literary Period:** Classical Sanskrit, Vedic/Post-Vedic Period
- **Genre:** Religious Scripture, Epic Poem
- **Setting:** The north of ancient India
- **Climax:** Yudhishtira regains his kingdom from the Kauravas.
- **Antagonist:** The Kauravas
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

An Epic Binge. One of the most popular adaptations of the *Mahabharata* is a television show produced in India in the 1980s. It received renewed attention during the COVID-19 pandemic after an Indian public broadcast company re-aired episodes of the show.

A Reading Odyssey. At over 200,000 verses, the *Mahabharata* is one of the longest texts in history, ten times the length of the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* combined.



PLOT SUMMARY

Ugrasravas the Suta begins telling a story to some Brahmin seers led by Śaunaka. He says it's called the *Mahabharata* and that it's full of heroes and seers performing amazing feats. Ugrasravas heard that a great seer named Vyasa first compiled the *Mahabharata*, and he begins narrating the story of what Vyasa's assistant, Vaiśampayana, told to Janamejaya while Janamejaya was in the middle of conducting a **snake** sacrifice. Vaiśampayana begins telling the story of the Kuru lineage, of which Janamejaya himself is a member. Some of the most important members of this lineage are the Pandavas, a group of five brothers who each achieve fame in their own way:

Yudhishtira, Arjuna, Bhima, and the twins Nakula and Sahadeva. Another major branch of the family is called the Kauravas, and it includes Dhritarashtra, who has 100 sons, the eldest and most notable of whom is Duryodhana.

A rivalry between the Pandavas and the Kauravas begins early in life, with Duryodhana at one point scheming to try to kill his cousins. Later, with the help of an advisor named Śakuni, Duryodhana gets the idea that since he can't defeat the Pandavas in battle, he'll steal the Pandava kingdom for himself by tricking Yudhishtira into a gambling match. Many of Dhritarashtra's other advisors, like Vidura, tell him that it isn't wise to let Duryodhana go through with this plan, but Dhritarashtra allows him to do so anyways.

Yudhishtira loses the gambling competition and has to give away everything, including his own freedom, his entire kingdom of Hastinapura, and his wife Draupadi (whom he shares with the other four Pandava brothers). Eventually, Duryodhana agrees to release the Pandavas and Draupadi from bondage, but they have to go into exile for 12 years and then spend a 13th year in disguise in a city.

After the end of the Pandava exile, tensions between them and the Kauravas flare up again, as the Pandavas resent the loss of their kingdom and the way that Duryodhana treated their wife, Draupadi, as a slave. Meanwhile, the Kauravas keep encroaching on Pandava territory. Ultimately, the Kauravas and the Pandavas fight a massive war for the succession of the Kuru lineage that results in the deaths of over 1.6 trillion people. During preparations for the war, Arjuna secures the help of Krishna, a strong and virtuous incarnation of the god Vishnu, who, despite vowing not to fight, seems to assure victory for whichever side he's on. Krishna agrees to be Arjuna's charioteer.

The actual fighting, which lasts 18 days, involves great heroes on each side performing amazing feats of military prowess, sometimes using powerful **celestial weapons** and killing many nameless soldiers and some famous heroes as well.

Duryodhana heads the Pandava forces, appointing a series of commanders that inevitably fall in battle to the Pandavas. Meanwhile, Yudhishtira leads the Pandavas and their allies with a steady hand. At the end of each day, the messenger Samajaya recounts what happened to the blind king Dhritarashtra, who laments the many losses his army suffers each day. Perhaps the most significant portion of the battle is the *Bhagavadgita*, a section of the poem where Arjuna has doubts about whether or not it's right to fight, and Krishna gives a famous speech that touches on many topics of morality and spirituality. Arjuna ultimately goes on to become perhaps the fiercest warrior on the battlefield with his trusty bow and with Krishna driving his chariot.

Near the end of the war, when the Pandavas have defeated almost all of their enemies, Aśvatthaman (son of the dead

Kaurava commander Drona) prays to Śiva and conducts a deadly night raid that kills most of the remaining Pandava army while the five brothers are away. Still, even this is not enough to change the outcome of the war, and the Pandavas take back their kingdom in Hastinapura, where Yudhishtira is reinstalled as king.

After the war, the survivors continue to live out the rest of their lives, with Dhritarashtra reconciling with the Pandavas before ultimately dying in a hermitage. To commemorate the occasion of regaining his kingdom, Yudhishtira conducts a **horse** ceremony, allowing a horse to roam across his entire kingdom under Arjuna's protection before finally sacrificing it.

Eventually, it comes time for the Pandavas and Draupadi to go on one last journey. As they walk, they each fall down dead, one by one. Yudhishtira, the last one standing, is allowed to enter the heaven of the god Indra while keeping his mortal body. When Yudhishtira arrives, he's shocked to find Duryodhana on a throne and his old allies all being tortured. He fears he's dreaming until, at last, Indra appears, dispelling the illusion and telling him that it's a king's fate to go to hell before reaching heaven and that in fact, he and his allies are allowed to live in heaven for their good deeds on earth.

The frame story ends with Ugrasravas repeating that the *Mahabharata* is a tale about victory and that just hearing it or telling it brings good luck. He offers a hymn that people can say every morning to try to get closer to perfection.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Yudhishtira – Yudhishtira is the eldest of the five Pandava brothers. His mother is Kunti, but his biological father is the god Dharma (because King Pandu can't have sex with his wife Kunti). As a result, Yudhishtira earns the title "lord of dharma." Because he is the oldest, Yudhishtira acts as king after Pandu's death, although he soon loses his throne and spends much of the poem trying to get it back. This is because, while Yudhishtira is known for his wise decision-making, he occasionally falters, particularly when he allows Duryodhana and Śakuni to goad him into gambling away everything he has, including his whole kingdom. Although Yudhishtira is a strong warrior and a capable leader in battle, he is reluctant to engage in violence, asking for his enemy Bhishma's permission to fight before the start of the Kurukshetra War and lamenting after the war that he should give up kingship for a life of asceticism. Despite his hardships and mistakes, however, Yudhishtira ultimately earns a place in Indra's heaven for him and his friends, dramatizing the benefits of living a life according to *dharma*.

Arjuna – Arjuna is the third oldest of the five Pandava brothers and arguably the best warrior among them, as well as perhaps

the best archer in the world. His biological father is Indra, and he also has a strong relationship with Krishna (an incarnation of the god Vishnu, who eventually becomes Arjuna's charioteer), showing how Arjuna has found favor with the gods. Due to his skill at defeating enemies (and later taking their treasure), Arjuna earns the title "the wealth-winner." Despite a couple close calls, he is more or less invincible during the Kurukshetra War, killing thousands of nameless enemies and several enemy heroes, including Bhishma, Jayadratha, and Karna. In addition to being a warrior, Arjuna also has a spiritual side and is the audience for Krishna during the famous *Bhagavadgita* section of the poem. Arjuna represents the power of the gods, with his many victories in battle representing the strength that a person gets from religious devotion.

Duryodhana – Duryodhana is one of the 100 sons of the king Dhritarashtra. He is the main antagonist of the *Mahabharata*, instigating and leading a war against five of his cousins: Yudhishtira, Arjuna, Bhima, Nakula, and Sahadeva. He is jealous of his cousins and their kingdom from an early age, and this jealousy soon turns violent, with Duryodhana devising a scheme to burn them alive. Later, with the help of his advisor Śakuni, he hatches a plan to take away his cousins' kingdom by taking advantage of Yudhishtira's gambling addiction. Although Duryodhana wins the kingdom, he begins a feud that leads to the deaths of over a trillion people in battle, with he himself being defeated in a duel of clubs by Bhima. Despite Duryodhana's strength and cunning, his defining feature is ultimately his ego. Duryodhana shows the dangers of jealousy and how it can lead to self-destruction. He also demonstrates the poisonous effects that arrogance has on others, as he convinces otherwise honorable characters like Dhritarashtra, Bhishma, and Drona to support his unjust war.

Krishna – Krishna is the mortal incarnation of the god Vishnu. He is one of the strongest and wisest characters in the poem. In the Kurukshetra War, he sides with the Pandavas, acting as Arjuna's charioteer, but due to a promise he made before the war, he refuses to personally kill any Kauravas in battle. Krishna is an expert in dharma, and he delivers the majority of the *Bhagavadgita*, a discourse on morality that is arguably the most famous part of the whole epic poem. Despite his reputation for dharma, however, Krishna remains a mysterious character, at times advising the Pandavas to go against *dharma* for the greater good, like when he tells Bhima to use a dishonorable trick and hit Duryodhana in the leg during a club duel. Krishna represents an ideal way of living life, and the *Mahabharata* is just one of many depictions of this important figure in Hinduism.

Bhima – Bhima is the second-oldest Pandava brother, the biological son of a wind god and Kunti. Bhima is famous for being the most brash and violent of all his brothers, and he is able to back up his words with his prowess on the battlefield. Perhaps more than any other brother, he is responsible for

instigating Duryodhana's rage at the Pandavas from a young age, and so it's fitting that he is ultimately the one who kills Duryodhana at the end of the Kurukshetra War in a duel of clubs. After the war, Bhima holds on to old grudges more than any of the other brothers and ultimately attracts the anger of Dhritarashtra. Although Bhima is a flawed character who occasionally goes too far, he represents the power and necessity of righteous violence.

Dhritarashtra – Dhritarashtra is the head of the Kauravas, and he has 100 sons with his wife Gandhari, with Duryodhana being the eldest and most notable. Dhritarashtra is born blind, which seems to be a symbol for his lack of judgement, as he allows himself to be swayed by the hot-headed Duryodhana rather than listening to wise advisers like Vidura. One of the central questions of the poem is whether Dhritarashtra caused the Kurukshetra war with his bad leadership or whether the war was always destined to happen. Although Dhritarashtra is not necessarily a malicious character, he nevertheless represents how weak leaders can be convinced into supporting unjust causes.

Vyasa – Vyasa is a great seer who is traditionally considered the author of the *Mahabharata* (even though in the text his assistant, Vaiśampayana, does the actual storytelling). He is known for compiling the Vedas (holy Hindu scriptures) and is also the biological father of Pandu, Dhritarashtra, and Vidura, making him the grandfather of many combatants on both the Kaurava and Pandava side of the Kurukshetra War. Vyasa embodies the qualities of knowledge and storytelling in the poem, showing how important they are. By providing a link between both the Pandavas and the Kauravas, he shows how enemies on the battlefield might not be so different from each other after all.

Bhishma – Bhishma is a son of the river spirit Ganga, an elder in the Kuru lineage, and one of the most formidable commanders of the Kaurava army. Although he allies himself with Duryodhana, he maintains respect for the Pandavas, and he grants Yudhishtira permission to fight him before the war starts. He is celibate and cares deeply about acting honorably, but he is also a fierce warrior who kills many of the Pandava warriors. Able to choose the date of his own death due to a boon, he lives in a state of near-death for many months after Arjuna fells him on the battlefield. During this time, he imparts his wisdom to Yudhishtira, discussing morality over the course of almost two full books of the poem. Bhishma represents the wisdom of elders and becomes a mouthpiece to explain some important religious tenets of Hinduism and Buddhism.

Aśvatthaman – Aśvatthaman is a warrior Brahmin and the son of Drona. He becomes one of the last commanders of the Kaurava army and is most famous for his deadly night raid against the Pandava army. During the night raid, Aśvatthaman asks Śiva for help, then almost single-handedly kills thousands of Pandava fighters, including Sikhandin, Dhrishtadyumna,

Prativindhya, Sutasoma, Śatanika, Śrutakirti, and Śrutasena. Aśvatthaman represents the power of Śiva, the god of destruction, while also more generally representing the carnage of warfare, which can be unfair.

Drona – Drona is a warrior Brahmin who instructs both the Kauravas and the Pandavas in the ways of war. He is also the father of Aśvatthaman. During the Kurukshetra war, he sides with Duryodhana, despite still having respect for the Pandavas. Although he's in his 80s, he remains a powerful fighter, and he takes command of the Kaurava army, where he kills great warriors like Drupada. Eventually, the Pandavas manage to trick Drona into believing his son Aśvatthaman is dead, and while Drona processes this news, Dhrishtadyumna kills him. Drona represents how knowledge and strength combine in battle, using his martial intelligence to fight at an advanced age but ultimately being undone by a trick.

Karna – Karna is the son of Kunti and a sun god, but his birth is kept secret and he is not considered one of the Pandavas, despite sharing a mother with some of them. He earns the nickname Karna the Cutter due to his decision to cut off the famous earrings and armor that once made him invincible (after being tricked by Indra). He is a noble warrior, a giant “walking mountain” of a man, who nevertheless sides with the arrogant Duryodhana against his half-brothers the Pandavas, showing how war can lead to complicated allegiances.

Draupadi – Draupadi is a princess who is the daughter of Drupada and who eventually becomes the co-wife of all five Pandava brothers. She is a famously dignified and loyal wife, and one of the inciting incidents for the Kurukshetra war is when Duryodhana wins Draupadi in a gambling competition and treats her like a slave. Although Draupadi is modest and well-mannered, she can also be vengeful, like when she urges the Pandavas to kill Aśvatthaman after his night raid. She represents an ideal version of womanhood, motivating the Pandavas to fight in her honor.

Janamejaya – Within Ugraśravas's retelling of the *Mahabharata*, the king Janamejaya listens to Vaiśampayana tell the story of the Kurukshetra War. He is particularly interested in the tale because it describes his ancestors (with Arjuna being his great-grandfather). Vaiśampayana tells his story while Janamejaya is in the middle of conducting a **snake** sacrifice (where he makes a sacrificial offering of snakes because his father, Parikshit, died of a snake bite). Janamejaya represents a contemporary India—someone who lived after most of the legendary figures but who is a direct descendant of them.

Abhimanyu – Abhimanyu is the son of Arjuna and Subhadra. Despite his youth, he is a powerful warrior, although during the Kurukshetra War, a group led by Drona manages to surround Abhimanyu and kill him. His death provides motivation for Arjuna, who in spite of all his skills in battle, is sometimes hesitant to kill his relatives on the Kaurava side. Abhimanyu

also helps continue the Kuru lineage even after his death, with his son Parikshit eventually becoming king.

Samjaya – Samjaya is the narrator for many of the scenes from the Kurukshetra battle, and he describes what happened each day to his blind king, Dhritarashtra. He constantly reminds Dhritarashtra that the Kaurava losses on the battlefield are not just bad luck but a direct result of Dhritarashtra's failure to rein in Duryodhana. Samjaya's ability to see practically everything during the battle reflects his clear ability to see what's just and moral, and it makes him the opposite of Dhritarashtra, whose literal blindness to the events can also leave him deluded.

Ugraśravas – Ugraśravas is the narrator for the frame story in the *Mahabharata*, telling all of the events to Śaunaka, although he is mostly just reporting information that originally comes from Vaiśampayana. He is a Suta, a “mixed” class with a Kshatriya father and Brahmin mother. Sutas were particularly famous for being bards and telling stories.

Vidura – Vidura is a half-brother to Dhritarashtra and one of his most prominent advisers. Known for his wisdom, Vidura favors the Pandavas and tries to persuade Dhritarashtra not to go to war against them, but Dhritarashtra and particularly Duryodhana refuse to listen. Vidura resigns and refuses to fight in the war, but afterwards, Yudhishtira restores him to his position.

Pandu – Pandu is the husband of Kunti and Madri, and his descendants are called the Pandavas. Technically, Pandu is not the biological father of any of his children due to a curse that he received: if he touched any of his wives to have sex, he would die. Eventually, his lust for Madri overcame him, and he died of the curse, leaving his children in Kunti's care.

Śakuni – Śakuni is an advisor to Duryodhana, helping him come up with and carry out his plan to rob the Pandavas of their kingdom by exploiting Yudhishtira's gambling addiction. Śakuni represents the dangers of pride and jealousy, since, while his scheme to take away the Pandavas' kingdom seems to work at first, it ultimately leads to the downfall of the Kauravas.

Ghatotkaca – Ghatotkaca is the half-Rakshasa son of Bhima and the sister of a Rakshasa named Hidimba. He is a bald giant who slays many warriors on the battlefield, sometimes using the power of illusions. His most important role in the story is to force Karna to use his **celestial weapon**, which kills Ghatotkaca but allows Arjuna to later defeat Karna.

Sikhandin – Sikhandin is the child of Drupada, originally female and named Sikhandini but eventually transforming into a new body and taking on a new male identity with the name Sikhandin. Sikhandin plays a role in the death of Bhishma (who refuses to attack Sikhandin because of Sikhandin's past as a woman). During the night raid, Aśvatthaman slices Sikhandin in half with his sword.

Amba, Ambika, and Ambalika – Amba, Ambika, and Ambalika are three sisters that Bhishma kidnaps and forces to have

children with Vyasa (since he himself is celibate). Amba closes her eyes during sex, giving birth to the blind Dhritarashtra; Ambika goes pale during sex, giving birth to the pale Pandu; and Ambalika doesn't recoil, giving birth to the wise Vidura.

Ganga – Ganga is a strikingly beautiful seer who is actually the goddess of the Ganges River in mortal form. When Pratipa encounters her one day, he is overcome by her beauty but ultimately decides that to sleep with her would go against his dharma, so he arranges for her to have children with Śamtanu—his son—when Śamtanu comes of age. When Śamtanu encounters Pratipa one day as a young man, she fulfills her promise. She ends up having eight of Śamtanu's children, though she drowns seven of them because they're actually gods who took mortal forms due to a curse. Śamtanu stops her before drowning their eighth son, whom Ganga spares before leaving Śamtanu. This sole surviving child is Bhishma.

Uttara – Uttara is Virata's son. When the Pandavas are living in Virata's city, Duryodhana mounts an attack. Because Virata has been drawn away from the city, Uttara is in charge, so he rushes into battle with Arjuna as his charioteer, though Arjuna is in disguise. Upon seeing Duryodhana's forces, Uttara tries to retreat, but Arjuna chases after him, reveals his true identity, and forces Uttara back into the battle—which they end up winning.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Kunti – Kunti is the mother of the five Pandavas and Karna. She raises the Pandava brothers after the death of her husband and their father, king Pandu, although, due to a curse on Pandu, he is not the biological father of any of Kunti's children.

Gandhari – Gandhari is the wife of Dhritarashtra and the mother of his 100 sons, including Duryodhana. In order to be more like her blind husband, she voluntarily wears a blindfold.

Indra – Indra is the king of the gods in Hinduism. He rules over a heaven where all the virtuous characters go at the end of the story, and he is the biological father of the Pandava brother Arjuna.

Nakula and Sahadeva – Nakula and Sahadeva are the youngest of the Pandava brothers. They are twins, the biological children of twin gods and Pandu's second wife Madri. Both prove themselves to be skilled swordsmen during the Kurukshetra War, although their elder brothers all play a more prominent role.

Brahma – A creator figure, Brahma is one of the supreme gods in Hinduism. While he is associated with learning and knowledge, he also created some of the most powerful **celestial weapons**.

Vishnu – Vishnu is one of the supreme gods of Hinduism. He often takes the form of a mortal avatar, and he spends the

majority of the *Mahabharata* as Krishna.

Śiva – Śiva is one of the supreme gods of Hinduism and often associated with destruction. Aśvatthaman prays to Śiva before his night raid and is able to kill almost an entire army by taking them by surprise.

Bharata – Bharata is the son of Dushshanta and Śakuntala. He founds the famous Bharata lineage, which includes both the Kauravas and the Pandavas and which gives the *Mahabharata* its name.

Vasu – Vasu is an ancient king and huntsman who accidentally impregnates a river spirit that gives birth to twins, one of whom is Satyawati.

Parikshit – Parikshit is a Kuru king and the father of Janamejaya. As a newborn, he gets killed by Brahma's Head, but Krishna revives him.

Rama Jamadagnya – Rama Jamadagnya is a warrior Brahmin who kills all of the Kshatriya warriors 21 times because he believes it will restore balance to the universe.

Madri – Madri is the second wife of Pandu and mother of Karna and also the twins Nakula and Sahadeva. After Pandu dies from touching her (due to a curse), she kills herself and leaves her children with Kunti.

Śaunaka – Śaunaka is the chief of a group of seers in the Naimisha Forest, and he listens to Ugraśravas's re-telling of the *Mahabharata*.

Kripa – Kripa is a Brahmin seer who assists Aśvatthaman on the night raid by guarding the entrance to the Pandava camp and killing people who tried to escape.

Takshka – Takshka is a deadly snake king who kills Parikshit, motivating Janamejaya to hold the snake sacrifice.

Śakuntala – Śakuntala is a beautiful woman who attracts the attention of King Dushshanta when he sees her in the forest. She is devastated when he seemingly forgets about her after marrying her, but eventually they get back together and have a son named Bharata, who founds the Bharata lineage.

Śamtanu – Śamtanu is an important ancestor of the Pandavas and Kauravas who marries Satyawati and gives birth to Bhishma as well as to eight sons with Ganga, whom she immediately drowns because they are a group of deities called the Vasus who need to return to their immortal forms.

Virata – Virata is the king of the city where the Pandavas spend their 13th year of exile in disguise in his court (following their gambling loss to Duryodhana).

Jayadratha – Jayadratha is an ally of Duryodhana who plays an important role in the death of Abhimanyu in battle, motivating Arjuna (Abhimanyu's father) to decapitate Jayadratha in revenge.

Dhrishtadyumna – Dhrishtadyumna kills Drona while he mistakenly believes that his son, Aśvatthaman, is dead. Later,

Aśvatthaman gets revenge on Dhrishtadyumna by ritualistically killing him without a weapon so that he is denied the glory of dying in battle.

Satyaki – Satyaki is an ally of Yudhishtira who ends up being one of the few survivors of the Kurukshetra war. He dies of a curse many years after the war that causes his allies to turn against each other.

Kali – Kali is the personification of evil and bad luck, whose name is associated with the Kali Age, a period of decline that begins after the events of the *Mahabharata*.

Uttanka – Uttanka is a great ascetic seer who is most famous for being one of the few people to see Krishna's true form while out in the desert.

Narada – Narada is a distinguished seer who tells stories with important moral lessons to Yudhishtira.

Duhshanta – Duhshanta is the king who falls in love with Śakuntala after seeing her in the forest. Their son is Bharata, head of the Bharata lineage.

Paraśara – Paraśara is a great seer who becomes the father of Vyasa.

Satyavati – Satyavati is the daughter of Vasu and the mother of Vyasa. (She is different from the Satyavati who marries Śamtanu.)

Drupada – Drupada is the father of Draupadi and an ally of the Pandavas. He gets killed in battle by Karna.

Balarama – Balarama is the brother of Krishna. He stays neutral during the Kurukshetra war and doesn't always approve of Krishna's actions. He is also the one who suggests a duel of clubs between Duryodhana and Bhima.

Kicaka – Kicaka is a general of Virata's who attempts to rape Draupadi. Bhima tricks and murders him.

Subhadra – Subhadra is a wife of Arjuna and the mother of Abhimanyu. She is also Krishna's sister, solidifying Arjuna's close connection with Krishna.

Yayati – Yayati is an ancient king who gives birth to Puru, an ancestor of the Kuru lineage.

Dharma – Dharma is a god who personifies dharma and gives birth to Yudhishtira with Kunti.

Savitri – Savitri is a princess named after a goddess who, through persistence, eventually gets the god of death (Yama) to revive her dead husband.

Devayani – Devayani is the wife of Yayati, and an ancestor to the Kuru lineage.

Puru – Puru is the youngest son of Yayati and an ancestor of the Kauravas and Pandavas.

Pratipa – Pratipa is an ancestor of the Kauravas and Pandavas who arranges for his son Śamtanu to have several sons with Ganga.

Yama – Yama is the god of death. Warriors who become particularly deadly in battle often get compared to Yama.

Salya – Salya is the commander of the Kaurava army for a brief time before Yudhishtira kills him.

Hidimba – Hidimba is a Rakshasa that Bhima slays.

Astika – Astika is the son of a **snake** goddess who intervenes in Janamejaya's snake ceremony to convince him to spare the life of Takshka.

Prativindhya, Sutasoma, Śrutakirti, Śatanika, and Śrutasena – Prativindhya, Sutasoma, Śrutakirti, Śatanika, and Śrutasena are the five sons of Draupadi, one with each of the five Pandava brothers. They all get killed during Aśvatthaman's night raid of the Pandava camp.

Vasishtha and Viśvamisra – Vasishtha and Viśvamisra are powerful seers with a fierce rivalry. Viśvamisra curses Vasishtha and forces him to eat his own sons.

Jarasandha – Jarasandha is a rival king that Yudhishtira kills relatively early in his reign.

Markandeya – Markandeya is a seer who tells stories to Yudhishtira about the power of asceticism.

Śisupala – Śisupala is the king of the Cedi kingdom who is born with extra eyes and arms and who eventually fulfills his destiny of being killed by Krishna.

Sudeshna – Sudeshna is the wife of Virata and queen of his kingdom.

Baka – Baka is a Rakshasa who terrorizes a town until Bhima kills him.

Kritavarma – Kritavarma is a Kaurava ally who assists Aśvatthaman during his night raid, guarding the camp exit with Kripa.

Śukra – Śukra is the father of Devayani and an ancestor of the Kuru lineage.

Riśyasringa – Riśyasringa is a seer who becomes part of a king's plot to get rainfall back to his dry kingdom.

Vaiśampayana – Vaiśampayana is Vyasa's pupil and the primary narrator of the *Mahabharata*. When Vyasa tells Janamejaya an abbreviated version of the epic tale during a snake sacrifice, Janamejaya declares that he wants to hear the entire thing, so Vyasa instructs Vaiśampayana to narrate all 100,000 verses

TERMS

Boon – A boon is a special gift from a god, usually to a mortal, similar to a wish or a miracle. Many figures in the *Mahabharata* receive boons that affect the plot, like **Bhishma's** boon that allows him to choose the date of his own death, prolonging it for months after he falls in battle.

Brahman – Brahman (not to be confused with Brahmin or

Brahma) refers to the state of reality and the infinite nature of the universe.

Brahmin – Brahmins are one of the four main classes in society. They are priests and generally considered the most desirable class. Although nonviolence is important to many Brahmins, there are also warrior Brahmins who use their holy power in battle.

Dharma – *Dharma* is a Sanskrit word without a simple English translation that means something like “duty,” “obligation,” or even “fate.” In general, the virtuous characters in the *Mahabharata* try to act according to *dharma* while the evil characters break *dharma*, but because *dharma* varies based on a person’s social class, it can be difficult to determine what is *dharma* in any given situation.

Kshatriya – Kshatriyas are one of the four main classes in society. Generally ranked second in importance, they are warriors, and their dharma involves performing valiantly on the battlefield.

Rakshasha – A Rakshasha is a type of demon. Most harass humans and even feed on the corpses of the dead, but some, like the half-Rakshasa **Ghatotkaca**, are noble.

Sudra – Sudras are one of the four main classes in society. Typically ranked least important, they are common workers.

Suta – Sutas are the children of a Kshatriya father and a Brahmin mother. They have a reputation as storytellers, and the narrator **Ugrasravas** is a prominent example of a Suta in the poem.

Vaiśyas – Vaiśyas are one of the four main classes in society. Typically ranked third, they include merchants and farmers.

Vedas – Vedas are a large body of religious texts and the oldest surviving Hindu scriptures. According to tradition, **Vyasa**, who appears in the *Mahabharata*, compiled these writings, and other figures in the poem sometimes make reference to the wisdom of the Vedas (since those texts pre-date the *Mahabharata*).

Śraddha – A ritual in the Hindu religion, *śraddha* is a way for people to honor, thank, and remember their deceased ancestors.

book with just one word: *dharma*. *Dharma* is a Sanskrit word that embodies several concepts, including “duty,” “justice,” or even “fate.” All of the figures in the *Mahabharata* have their own individual *dharma*, and each of them struggles to live out their destiny and avoid doing things that are “*adharma*” (against *dharma*). Yudhishtira, for instance, is a king who earns the title “lord of *dharma*” on account of his wise judgment, and yet even he struggles with accepting his fate and with fulfilling his sacred duties. His biggest moment of doubt comes after the end of the Kurukshetra War, which is the result of the conflict between the Pandavas (Yudhishtira and his brothers) and the Kauravas. After the death of so many friends and family members (since even the enemy Kauravas were Yudhishtira’s relatives in the Kuru lineage), Yudhishtira wants to give up his kingship and become an ascetic in the forest. But Yudhishtira’s allies, particularly Krishna, help convince Yudhishtira that, while it might be *dharma* for some to live an austere life in the woods, it is still Yudhishtira’s *dharma*—that is, his duty and purpose as king—to be a leader for his people.

But while *dharma* offers a guide for living life, it doesn’t always deal in clear-cut morality, and the *dharma* of someone from the Brahmin priest class can be very different from the *dharma* of someone in the Kshatriya warrior class. During one of the most climactic battles of the story, the supposedly heroic Bhima follows Krishna’s advice and uses a dirty trick to defeat Duryodhana, striking him in the thigh (which is dishonorable). Many, including Krishna’s brother Balarama, feel that Bhima’s victory is against *dharma* because of his tricky tactics, but Krishna explains that in the grand scheme of things, Bhima’s actions are justified due to the many wrongs the Pandavas have suffered at the hands of the Kauravas. And so, while the *Mahabharata* and—more broadly—the concept of *dharma* provide a guide for how humans should live their lives, they don’t offer easy answers, suggesting instead that in order to make moral decisions, a person must consider their own specific circumstances.



PURSUIING ENLIGHTENMENT

The *Mahabharata* is not just an epic narrative poem but also a holy text in Hinduism, and so it makes sense that religious enlightenment plays a large role in it. During the most famous segment of the poem—the *Bhagavadgita*—the great warrior Arjuna struggles with many moral questions and asks his friend Krishna (a mortal incarnation of the god Vishnu) for advice. While many of Arjuna’s questions deal specifically with the upcoming battle (in which Arjuna is hesitant to fight because he sees so many family members among the enemies), the questions also relate more generally to the human condition and to the process of attaining enlightenment, thus serving as a thematic encapsulation of the poem as a whole. Among Krishna’s many pieces of advice, one recurring theme is a focus on the self and



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



DHARMA

The full *Mahabharata* contains almost two million words, but it’s possible to summarize much of the

on introspection as a way of better understanding the universe. Still, despite the role that meditation and contemplation play in the *Mahabharata*, the *Bhagavadgita* makes it clear that the pursuit of enlightenment also requires taking action. According to Krishna, this action requires a careful balance: a person must perform the duties of their dharma (which can vary depending on a person's class and stage of life), but an individual should also strive to maintain a sense of detachment from worldly things. It's only by achieving total detachment, Krishna advises, that a person can escape the cycle of birth and rebirth. Krishna himself lives out his own advice over the course of the Kurukshetra War and its aftermath, accepting that it's his own *dharma* not to kill anyone in that war (despite his frequent desire to do so) and eventually accepting death at the hands of the hunter Jara when it's his time to ascend back to heaven. Ultimately, enlightenment in the *Mahabharata* involves searching for wisdom from a variety of sources, listening to experts and sacred texts, but also using introspection and self-knowledge as a way to transcend earthly affairs.



HEROISM AND WARFARE

At the center of the *Mahabharata* is a war in which Yudhishtira estimates over 1.6 trillion people die. This war features larger-than-life heroes and

villains who can fill the horizon with arrows, survive for months after receiving a mortal blow, and slay tens of thousands of enemies with powerful **celestial weapons** or even just a regular club. In the poem, there is a huge difference between the common soldiers, who die anonymous deaths, and the great warriors like Arjuna, who perform astonishing deeds that get recorded in great detail. The major combatants follow an elaborate code of conduct, with one of the most famous scenes being when Pandava leader Yudhishtira puts aside his weapons and asks his enemy Bhishma for permission to fight the war—because even though Bhishma is his enemy, he is nevertheless still an elder in Yudhishtira's family and thus deserves respect. By focusing on the deeds of mighty warriors, the poem presents a glorious version of warfare, where even many “villains” like Bhishma, Drona, and Karna are noble fighters who deserve praise for their honorable conduct and skill with weapons. It also highlights how the present era—the so-called Kali Age—is less glorious than the days of the Kurukshetra War, when these heroes walked the earth.

Still, despite the glorious nature of war in the *Mahabharata*, war also frequently leads to tragedy. In one of the poem's most harrowing moments, the Kaurava warrior Aśvatthaman offers a tribute to Śiva, the god of destruction, and then conducts a deadly night raid in which he almost single-handedly slaughters most of the remaining Pandava warriors (including the sons of the five Pandava brothers)—right when it seems like the Pandavas are on the verge of victory. Because of actions like the night-raid, by the end of the war, the death toll includes not

just anonymous soldiers but also many of the named heroes as well. The overwhelming scale and immense detail of the battles in the *Mahabharata* help convey the glorious nature of a past era while also depicting the tragic consequences of violence, even for epic heroes who can slay thousands of enemies but still can't escape their own fates—which, of course, is that they too will eventually die.



GRIEF, LOSS, AND MOURNING

Due to both its focus on war and the long time period it covers, the *Mahabharata* is full of death, and it also deals with the grief survivors feel in the wake of death. Perhaps no character in the story has more cause for grief than Dhritarashtra, who loses 100 sons as well as many other trusted relatives, warriors, and advisors. At the end of each day of battle, the blind king Dhritarashtra laments to hear from Samjaya how many brave fighters died in battle that day. Many characters, however—particularly Samjaya and also Dhritarashtra's wise advisor Vidura—tell Dhritarashtra not to grieve because he is simply experiencing the logical consequences of his own actions (after he allowed Duryodhana to gamble against Yudhishtira, starting the feud between the Kauravas and the Pandavas). Even Dhritarashtra's own wife Gandhari advises him not to mourn too much, because the many Kaurava deaths that occurred during the war all happened according to fate. As Vyasa explains at one point, grief is often just a waste of time because death is simply part of a cycle of rebirth.

And yet, while the wisest figures in the poem often advise against grief, other events in the poem complicate this idea. For example, in his pursuit of dharma, Yudhishtira follows Bhishma's advice and holds elaborate śraddha ceremonies after the Kurukshetra War to honor those who fell in battle, including even enemies who fought on the opposing side. Others in the poem go even further in their expressions of grief. Take, for instance, the wives of the dead Kaurava warriors, who throw themselves into the Ganga River to be reunited with their husbands. Similarly, Krishna's four wives throw themselves onto his funeral pyre after his death. Ultimately, everything comes back to the idea of *dharma*, and how what is full of dharma for one individual may not apply for another. The *Mahabharata* contains several arguments and strategies for attempting to overcome grief, arguing that death is a natural part of existence, but it nevertheless also emphasizes the importance of honor and respect for the dead by the living.



STORIES AND STORYTELLING

The *Mahabharata* is a long story that contains many smaller stories. Technically, almost the entire poem is a monologue that Ugrasravas narrates to Śaunaka, but Ugrasravas essentially disappears for most of the

poem. Instead, the poem centers on a conversation between Vaiṣampayana and Janamejaya at the **snake** ceremony, a nested story within Ugraśravas's monologue. The most famous sections of the text involve an even more deeply nested story, with Vaiṣampayana describing a series of conversation between Dhritarashtra and Samjaya. This complicated structure of stories within stories reflects the *Mahabharata*'s own likely origins as an oral tradition passed down by people retelling the story in person, and it raises the question of why people tell stories like the *Mahabharata* in the first place.

The answer to that question is that stories have power, and in the case of the *Mahabharata*, this power is arguably quite literal, with Ugraśravas saying that whoever recites the whole *Mahabharata* will achieve victory themselves. Stories also frequently serve instructional or illustrative purposes, with wise characters like Krishna using stories from history or about the gods in order to help teach his audience a lesson. The poem concludes with the declaration that anyone who studies the stories of the *Mahabharata* will purify themselves as fully as if they've bathed in the waters of a holy lake. As a story about stories, the *Mahabharata* questions its own reason for existing, ultimately coming to the conclusion that stories benefit both the teller and the audience by imparting knowledge and giving moral instruction.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



SNAKES

Snakes carry a lot of religious significance (not just in Hinduism but in other religions, too), and in the

Mahabharata they specifically symbolize death. The most famous snake in the poem is the serpent king Takshaka, who kills the king Parikshit, motivating his son Janamejaya to hold a snake sacrifice (where Vaiṣampayana tells Janamejaya the story of his ancestors, including the Kurukshetra war). By holding the snake ceremony, Janamejaya seems to be trying to overcome death itself, killing many snakes to punish them for what they did to his father. The snake goddess Astika, however, intervenes to save some of the snakes, including Takshaka.

The interruption of the snake sacrifice suggests that it is futile and perhaps against dharma to oppose death. This theme aligns with Vaiṣampayana's story of the Kurukshetra War, which also suggests that death—while tragic—is inevitable and perhaps even a necessary force to balance the universe. Fittingly, then, when Krishna sees a snake coming out of the mouth of his dead brother Balarama, he doesn't recoil or grieve but simply accepts it and continues on his journey. The setting of the poem at a snake sacrifice foregrounds the theme of mortality,

representing the fact that death is always lurking somewhere—even for great heroes—while also hinting that death is simply a part of nature.



CELESTIAL WEAPONS

A celestial weapon (*astra* in Sanskrit) is a type of powerful weapon that the gods bestow upon some of the mortal heroes of the *Mahabharata*, and these weapons represent the power of the gods—and, more broadly, the benefits of living a religious life. In general, the characters who get to use the celestial weapons are among the most devout in the story. The most prolific user of celestial weapons is Arjuna, who has a close relationship with the gods: in addition to being the biological son of Indra, he is a close friend of Krishna (an incarnation of Vishnu). Arjuna carefully considers the moral and religious implications of fighting, most notably during a conversation he has with Krishna called the *Bhagavadgita*. As a reward for his devout behavior, the gods gift Arjuna their weapons and protection, making him an even more formidable warrior than he already is.

But while the gods generally favor the Pandavas, some of the opposing Kauravas also unleash celestial weapons during battle. Karna, for example, is allied with the Kauravas but uses his celestial weapon to kill Ghatotkaca (Bhima's son). The moment is a mixed success for Karna, since he stops the powerful warrior Ghatotkaca but loses his ability to use his weapon against Arjuna, who eventually kills him. The occasional support of the gods to the Kauravas in the form of celestial weapons shows how morality in war isn't black and white and sometimes noble people can exist on both sides. Nevertheless, the ultimate failure of the Kauravas in battle reaffirms how the stronger faith of the Pandavas, embodied by the celestial weapons, makes them better able to confront whatever challenges come their way.



HORSES

Horses play an important role in the battle scenes of *Mahabharata*, giving soldiers extra mobility by allowing them to move around in chariots, and so they represent the relationship between humanity and nature. The most important horse in the poem is the one that Yudhishtira sacrifices in a horse ceremony after the Kurukshetra War to reaffirm his control over his kingdom. Before killing the horse, Yudhishtira lets it free to wander the entire span of his kingdom (with Arjuna's protection). The horse's long journey demonstrates how fully Yudhishtira controls both humanity and nature in his domain after the war.

On the one hand, humans work in tandem with horses in chariots on the battlefield, showing humanity's harmonious connection to nature. But ultimately, many horses die over the

course of the war, and Yudhishtira's sacrifice of the horse at the end symbolizes humanity's power over nature. But in spite of the sacrifice, this does not necessarily mean that humanity must have a violent relationship with nature. Other parts of the poem praise nonviolence, and at one point Krishna advises against eating meat, at least for certain situations and certain classes of people. In the end, humanity's role as a leader over nature is a way for humans to show respect and devotion to the gods who created nature, and with the horse sacrifice, Yudhishtira demonstrates his understanding of this balance between humanity, nature, and the gods.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Penguin edition of *Mahabharata* published in 2009.

Chapter 1. Beginnings Quotes

●● Ugraśravas the Suta, teller of ancient tales, son of Lomaharshana the Suta, once approached the Brahmin seers assembled in the Naimisha forest to attend the twelve-year sacrifice of Śaunaka their chief, bowing politely to those keepers of keen vows.

Related Characters: Karna, Ugraśravas, Śaunaka

Related Themes:

Page Number: 1

Explanation and Analysis

This quote appears at the very beginning of the *Mahabharata*, and it describes the primary narrator, Ugraśravas the Suta, who relates the poem to Śaunaka, a chief of a group of forest seers. Despite narrating the whole thing, Ugraśravas is not necessarily a major character in the story—he is more of a vessel for conveying the words and deeds of other characters.

One of Ugraśravas's most important characteristics is that he is a Suta (the child of a "mixed" relationship between a Brahmin mother and a Kshatriya father). Sutas do not have a high place in the society this poem is set in—later, many characters insult the mighty warrior Karna because his adoptive father is a Suta. It's perhaps surprising, then, that the main narrator of the poem is a Suta and not a Brahmin, given that Brahmins have the highest status and are known for their wisdom. But as the poem explores, while there is a hierarchy of classes, what's even more important is that people live up to the duties and obligations of their class: their dharma. Sutas may not be the most distinguished

members of society, but it is their dharma to be storytellers, and so Ugraśravas makes a fitting narrator because being a storyteller allows him to fulfill the function of his Suta class. By having a narrator who is not involved with the main events of the poem, the *Mahabharata* foregrounds the act of storytelling itself, showing how the events of history get shaped by the people who tell stories about them.

●● But even as the priests talked, some saying one thing, some another, Arjuna stood next to the bow, unmoving as a mountain. The afflicter of his enemies walked around it in respectful circumambulation, bowed to it with his head, then took hold of it in joyful excitement. In the time it takes to blink, he strung it; and he took up five arrows and swiftly pierced the target through the opening. It fell to the ground.

Related Characters: Ugraśravas (speaker), Yudhishtira, Arjuna, Bhima, Draupadi, Nakula and Sahadeva

Related Themes:

Page Number: 71

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the moment when Arjuna finally proves himself as a warrior, easily using a bow that seems impossible to use and, in the process, winning Draupadi as a wife for himself and his brothers. The first book (or "parvan") of the *Mahabharata* is the most sprawling, going through a lineage of characters who mostly live before the main events of the poem, all culminating with the birth of the Pandavas—the five brothers Yudhishtira, Bhima, Arjuna, Nakula, and Sahadeva—who become the main heroes of the poem.

The symbolic test of strength appears in epics from around the world, with two of the most famous examples being when King Arthur proves his worth by removing a sword from a stone and when Odysseus proves his true identity in the *Odyssey* by firing a bow only he can wield. Similarly, in his feat with the arrows, Arjuna proves not just that he deserves Draupadi as a wife but also that he and his brothers are the rightful rulers of the land. Even though Arjuna completes the feat alone, he fires five arrows, one for himself and each of his brothers, indicating how all of their destinies are linked.

Chapter 2. The Hall Quotes

☞ Once, in the middle of the hall, Dhritarashtra's royal son came upon a crystal floor; fooled into thinking it water, King Duryodhana drew up his garments. After this he walked about the hall with angry heart and averted gaze. Next, seeing a pond of crystalline water adorned with crystal lotuses, he thought it was a floor, and fell, fully clothed, headlong into the water; when the servants saw that he had fallen in the pond, they laughed uproariously, before giving him clean clothes at the king's command. Then mighty Bhima and Arjuna and the twins saw him in this state, and they too all burst out laughing.

Related Characters: Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Yudhishtira, Arjuna, Duryodhana, Bhima, Dhritarashtra, Nakula and Sahadeva

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 121

Explanation and Analysis

This passage describes when Duryodhana goes to visit the grand hall of his cousin Yudhishtira and gets so caught up in awe and jealousy that he makes a foolish error, first mistaking crystal for water, then doing the opposite and looking even more foolish. While this might seem like a humorous passage, ultimately, it ends up provoking a war that kills more than 1.5 trillion people.

Like his father Dhritarashtra, who is literally blind, Duryodhana struggles with his sense of sight in this passage, being so distracted by external appearances that he fails to realize the true nature of what he's walking on. His harmless mistakes in this passage foreshadow the much more costly mistakes he'll make throughout the rest of the poem, all due to his inability to see the truth. It is perhaps particularly significant that Duryodhana struggles to recognize water: water has holy properties in the poem, with holy bathing areas being sites that pilgrims visit and with water often playing a cleansing, purifying role. Duryodhana himself goes to a lake near the end of the poem, once he finally realizes the error of his ways. And so, this passage demonstrates the dangers of not seeing things as they are, which might seem insignificant at first but can ultimately have major consequences in the long run.

Chapter 3. The Forest Quotes

☞ 'I choose fame in the world, O Sun, even over life itself; for he that has fame gains heaven, whilst he that has none perishes.'

Related Characters: Karna, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Arjuna, Duryodhana, Kunti, Indra

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 235

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes a pivotal moment when Karna (who shares a mother, Kunti, with three of the five Pandava brothers) allows himself to be tricked by Indra into giving away his armor and earrings that make him invincible. Although Karna has been warned not to fall for Indra's trick, he freely gives away his armor and earrings, believing that fame in battle is so important that it is worth it to give up his invincible status just to get it.

Karna is one of the most complicated figures in the poem, equal in almost every way to the Pandavas but motivated by a longstanding jealousy of them (and especially Arjuna), which is why he follows the misguided leadership of Duryodhana. Although he is technically one of the poem's villains, he is an honorable warrior, and rather than suggesting ego or vanity, Karna's desire for fame suggests that he has reached peace with the inevitability of his own death.

Chapter 4. Virata Quotes

☞ 'Prince of men,' replied Arjuna, 'here on this peak is a huge, dense śami tree. It has awesome branches, so it is hard to climb, and it stands next to the burning-ground; no one comes here, lord for it is growing off the path, in forest frequented by beasts and savage creatures. Let us stow our weapons in it and then set out for the city; in this way we shall be able to pass our days here free from worry, heir of Bharata.'

Related Characters: Arjuna, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Yudhishtira, Duryodhana, Virata

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 248

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the beginning of the final year that the Pandavas spend in exile, when after 12 years of wandering in the forest (due to Yudhishtira's loss in a gambling match to Duryodhana), they must spend a 13th year living in anonymity in a city. By using the tree to stash their weapons, which are such an important part of their identity as warriors, the Pandavas symbolically put away their past

selves and start from scratch in a new environment.

The time that the Pandavas spend in Virata's city allows them to prove that, even without their famous names and reputations, they impress the people around them with their strength and honor. The new identities that the Pandavas take on while incognito represent a figurative rebirth, echoing the many literal rebirths that occur over the course of the poem. Ultimately, the time that the five Pandavas spend in Virata's city is a learning experience for them, and it helps prove that for all their prowess in battle, the true strength of the Pandavas is their virtue, and this allows them to succeed even in cases where they are separated from their famous weapons and sterling reputations.

term gain, even if that gain involves a full 100 million soldiers.

☞ Anyone seeking pleasure and wealth should also practice dharma from the outset, for neither wealth nor pleasure is ever found away from dharma.

Related Characters: Krishna , Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Duryodhana

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 322

Explanation and Analysis

This quote from Krishna comes when he and other characters make their last-minute attempts to prevent Duryodhana from starting a disastrous war with the Pandavas. The quote deals with dharma, arguably the central concept of the poem. Dharma is a multifaceted idea that incorporates several different meanings, like “duty,” “obligation,” or “lot in life,” and because it can mean so many different things, figures in the poem often provide definitions and explanations for it.

While some sections in the poem warn against the dangers of seeking pleasure or being greedy, this quote doesn't quite do that. Krishna advises Duryodhana that pleasure and wealth aren't universally bad—they're only bad when they don't stem from dharma and thus lead away from it. As Krishna's quote implies, it is in fact possible to achieve pleasure and wealth through dharma, as, for example, a king might need to keep a full treasury for the benefit of his subjects. And so, ultimately, Krishna advises Duryodhana that a person must have self-knowledge, in order to know when an action like seeking wealth or pleasure is dharma and when it is merely a distraction.

Chapter 5. Perseverance Quotes

☞ When Kunti's son the wealth-winner heard Krishna's words, he chose Krishna Keśava, though he would not fight in battle.

Related Characters: Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Arjuna , Duryodhana , Krishna , Vishnu

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 295

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the moment after Krishna offers Arjuna a choice: to have 100 million soldiers fight on his side in battle or to have Krishna on his side, with Krishna pledging not to actually raise a weapon in battle. When Arjuna chooses Krishna, leaving the 100 million soldiers to Duryodhana, the choice seems to shock everyone—even Krishna. But Arjuna believes that whoever has Krishna on his side will prosper, even if Krishna doesn't do any actual fighting.

Because Krishna is an incarnation of the mighty god Vishnu, he is an expert on matters of spirituality, and Arjuna correctly realizes that having Krishna on his side means having the full power of religion and faith on his side. Although many wise figures in the poem praise the value of nonviolence, other figures who are fighting for a righteous cause draw strength from their religious faith, with Arjuna eventually becoming one of the most prominent examples, due to his close relationship with Krishna. Arjuna's choice of Krishna shows that he can think in the long term, prioritizing his relationship with the gods over any short-

Chapter 6. Bhishma Quotes

☞ Hear, lord of the earth, how those heroes, the Kauravas, Pandavas and Somakas, fought on Kurukshetra, that place of asceticism. The mighty Pandavas came to Kurukshetra with the Somakas and advanced against the Kauravas, for they were eager for victory. Accomplished Vedic scholars all, they revelled in warfare, hoping for victory in combat but prepared for death on the battlefield.

Related Characters: Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker),

Yudhishtira , Arjuna , Duryodhana , Bhima , Janamejaya , Nakula and Sahadeva

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 348

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Vaiśampayana, who is at the snake ceremony talking to Janamejaya, prepares to tell the story of the Kurukshetra War, which makes up the centerpiece of the *Mahabharata*. Vaiśampayana addresses Janamejaya respectfully (as “lord of the earth”) and emphasizes the glory of the war in part because he’s telling Janamejaya the story of his ancestors. The quote emphasizes yet again how warfare isn’t just about physical might but also has a spiritual dimension, noting that Kurukshetra is a place associated with asceticism and how the combatants in the war are “Vedic scholars all.”

Although the following books do indeed portray a glorious war full of larger-than-life battles, they also explore the complex morality of war in a way that this quote doesn’t suggest. Far from “reveling” in warfare, as this quote implies, the combatants in the war often face doubts or perform certain duties reluctantly. Ultimately, however, despite these gray areas, the story of the Kurukshetra War has survived through the ages, and while Vaiśampayana’s glorious introduction to the war might not tell the whole story, it nevertheless captures how combatants on both sides put aside concern for their own lives in pursuit of achieving fame on the battlefield.

☞ The blessed lord replied, ‘I am Time, the destroyer of worlds, fully developed, and I have set out here to bring the worlds to their end.’

Related Characters: Krishna , Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Arjuna

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 363

Explanation and Analysis

Krishna says these words to Arjuna in the *Bhagavad Gita*, a subsection of the sixth book in which Krishna discusses important religious issues and tries to convince a reluctant Arjuna to participate in the fighting. Today, the quote is

often associated with J. Robert Oppenheimer, who remembers thinking it after the testing of the first atomic bomb. In this quote, Krishna argues that every single warrior on the battlefield will die at some point, due to the nature of time—even if Arjuna doesn’t participate. For this reason, Krishna argues that Arjuna must do his duty and fight, in order to claim the glory for these inevitable deaths and ultimately follow his dharma.

The *Bhagavadgita* often gets read in isolation from the rest of the *Mahabharata*, not just because of its importance in Hinduism, but for its universal themes about how to lead a moral life. While Krishna strongly urges Arjuna to take action, he simultaneously advises Arjuna to maintain a sense of detachment as he performs his actions, refusing to let passion overcome him. This pivotal conversation between Arjuna and Krishna helps set up the rest of the Kurukshetra War, showing how all the combatants are subject to fate and how that means the best option is to greet their fates with decisive but detached action.

Chapter 7. Drona Quotes

☞ The hero who had laid waste the entire Kuru army, like an elephant in a lotus pond, now lay resplendent in death, like a wild elephant slain by hunters.

Related Characters: Samjaya, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Arjuna , Drona, Abhimanyu , Jayadratha

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 428

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the death of Abhimanyu (Arjuna’s son), which is the most significant casualty on the Pandavas side at this point in the war. On the day of his death, Abhimanyu fights fiercely despite his young age, taking down countless enemies, but under Drona’s leadership, the Kauravas manage to kill him by overwhelming him with numbers, all while Jayadratha holds off the other Pandavas to stop them from intervening.

Abhimanyu’s death captures many of the contradictions of the Kurukshetra War as a whole. On the one hand, his death causes mourning among the Pandavas, with many witnesses to the killing saying it was against dharma because Abhimanyu was surrounded by too many enemies for it to be a fair fight. At the same time, however, quotes like this one emphasize the glory of Abhimanyu’s death, depicting

how he fought bravely and ultimately earned a warrior's death by fighting up until the very end despite the odds. In this way, Abhimanyu's death captures the tragedy of war, where soldiers can die at a young age, but it also portrays the idea that it is heroic for people like Abhimanyu to accept the possibility of their own death and keep fighting regardless.

And he performed this last find and astonishing foe-slaying feat: at the time he was pierced in the heart by the Spear, he appeared, O king, huge as a cloud, or a mountain; then that Rakshasa prince fell headlong to earth from on high, body torn, limbs stilled, lifeless and speechless, but gigantic in form. Bhima's son Ghatotkaca, doer of fearful deeds, fell with the terrifying, fearful form he had assumed; and thus even in death he smashed on whole section of your army, bringing terror to the Kauravas.

Related Characters: Samjaya, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Arjuna, Krishna, Bhima, Karna, Abhimanyu, Ghatotkaca

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 469

Explanation and Analysis

Not long after the death of Abhimanyu, the Pandavas lose another important ally in Ghatotkaca (son of Bhima), and this quote describes the moment when Karna kills him. While on the one hand it's tragic for a strong soldier to fall in battle and for Bhima to lose a son, this quote emphasizes the glorious nature of Ghatotkaca's final moments. Ghatotkaca is so devoted to fighting bravely that even his death becomes an attack on his enemies, with him using his dead body to take down some of the Kauravas with him.

Whereas Abhimanyu's death is a setback for the Pandavas, Ghatotkaca's death might actually be a strategic gain, since, as Krishna later points out, Karna had to use up his celestial weapon against Ghatotkaca, leaving him without anything to defeat Arjuna when the two of them eventually meet in battle. Krishna sent Ghatotkaca to attack Karna, knowing full well what would happen. The whole episode of Ghatotkaca's death emphasizes the necessity of sacrifice in war, and Ghatotkaca proves his valor by accepting this sacrifice, using even his last breath as a way to try to help his side win.

Chapter 8. Karna Quotes

“Karna, if you challenge Arjuna to battle, you are a hare challenging a mighty elephant with tusks like plough-shafts, its temporal glands bursting with rut. If you want to fight the son of Kunti, you are a silly child poking with a stick a deadly poisonous king cobra in its hole, its hood expanded.”

Related Characters: Samjaya, Ugraśravas, Salya, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Arjuna, Duryodhana, Karna, Abhimanyu, Kunti, Ghatotkaca

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 496

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, the mighty Kaurava warrior and charioteer Salya tries to convince Karna not to challenge Arjuna in battle. Particularly since Karna has just used up his powerful celestial weapon against Ghatotkaca, Salya advises Karna that to fight Arjuna will only lead to death. To illustrate the point, Salya invokes the imagery of the snake—a common symbol for death throughout the poem—saying that Karna is like a child playing with a poisonous cobra. The comparison of Arjuna to a mighty elephant recalls previous descriptions of his son Abhimanyu, which also referenced elephants, thus hinting at a family resemblance.

In this quote, Salya sums up the issue not just with Karna challenging Arjuna but with the whole Kaurava army challenging the stronger Pandavas. Duryodhana led the Kauravas into war without thinking, just like the hare challenging the elephant or the child poking the cobra in this quote. And yet, in spite of realizing the hopelessness of the Kaurava cause, Salya continues to keep fighting out of a sense of duty. This quote conveys the dangers of failing to respect an opponent, and it is also yet another quote that explores the inevitability of death.

“The glorious standard of Karna the mighty chariot-fighter was now destroyed by the noble wearer of the diadem with a razor-edged, gold-shafted arrow that he shot with the greatest of care; and with the fall of that standard there fell too the Kurus' fame and dharma, and their hopes of victory, sir, and all that they held dear, and their very hearts.”

Related Characters: Samjaya, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Arjuna, Karna, Salya

Related Themes:**Related Symbols:****Page Number:** 523**Explanation and Analysis**

This quote describes the moment shortly before Karna's death when Arjuna destroys his standard with a golden arrow. A standard is a flag that armies bring in to battle that has great symbolic value, and so by destroying Karna's standard, Arjuna indicates his intention to destroy everything that Karna stands for. Early in the poem, Arjuna earns the name "wealth winner" because he is so good at defeating his enemies and taking their wealth. It's fitting, then, that one of the "wealth winner's" signature weapons is a golden arrow that destroys the enemy standard.

Just as Salya predicted, without his celestial weapon, Karna is no match in battle for Arjuna. While Karna perhaps hoped to at least die in a glorious battle with Arjuna, Arjuna reduces the glory of Karna's death by destroying his standard first, sending the Kauravas around him into disarray. This whole passage helps convey how symbolism in the poem, like that of a battle standard, is not just a literary device but something that has meaning to the figures in the poem themselves, showing how omens, stories, and symbols help them understand the world around them.

Perhaps more than any other moment in the poem, this passage raises the question of what tactics it's permissible to use in war and whether there are ever situations where a person should act against their dharma. On the one hand, Bhima's success in this passage seems to suggest that the ends justify the means (since ultimately Duryodhana was the one who instigated the whole unjust Kurukshetra war), and Krishna later reassures Bhima that he did the right thing. However, Bhima's unceremonious defeat of Duryodhana stirs up bad feelings amongst the Kauravas, leading to a revenge attack on the Pandavas in the next book that demonstrates the potential dangers of dishonorable actions. As is often the case, the poem depicts a complicated view of morality, showing how actions that might be immoral in one situation can become acceptable in a different context.

☛ Seeing these most wonderful happenings, and the honour paid to Duryodhana, the Pandavas felt ashamed; they grieved mightily to hear it said that Bhishma, Drona, Karna, and Buriśravas had been killed unfairly. But Krishna, seeing them anxious and downcast, proclaimed in a voice sounding like thunder or drums, 'Duryodhana here with his swift weapons, and those other valiant chariot-fighters, could not have been slain by you on the battlefield in a fair fight. That is why I devised these stratagems, lords of men—otherwise the victory of the Pandavas could never have happened.'

Chapter 9. Salya Quotes

☛ Bhima of fearful deeds brought down that club with an impact like that of a thunderbolt, and it smashed Duryodhana's two handsome thighs.

Related Characters: Samjaya, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Duryodhana, Krishna, Bhima

Related Themes:**Page Number:** 553**Explanation and Analysis**

This passage describes the pivotal moment where, following Krishna's advice, Bhima does a dishonorable thing and attacks Duryodhana below the waist, breaking both of his thighs. This underhanded move may be against dharma, but it ultimately allows Bhima to prevail in a fight where he might have otherwise lost to Duryodhana's superior skill with a club.

Related Characters: Krishna, Samjaya, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Duryodhana, Bhishma, Drona, Karna

Related Themes:**Page Number:** 560**Explanation and Analysis**

When the Pandavas are accused of cheating to defeat the Kauravas in battle, Krishna steps up and offers some words in defense of their actions. While the Pandavas are right to mourn the dead on the Kaurava side (particularly the noble warriors like Bhishma, Drona, and Karna, who were their own relatives), Krishna advises them against getting too sentimental. His words touch on an idea that dominates much of the latter half of the poem: that respect for the dead is good but that it's important to avoid indulging too much in grief.

Krishna's words on grief relate back to his overall philosophy of acting with detachment. Krishna acknowledges that the Pandavas had to kill many "valiant"

fighters in their war effort, but because Krishna sees Pandava's victory as a worthwhile cause, he believes it is even worth using tricks to achieve it. Krishna is an important figure in the poem, offering invaluable guidance to many of the heroic characters, and this passage sheds light on Krishna's own worldview, showing how even he is willing to put aside his emphasis on dharma when he feels it's justified.

Chapter 10. The Night-Raid Quotes

👁️ Drona's son Aśvatthaman watched that owl carry out its guileful attack at night. The bird's behaviour filled him with new resolve, and he said to himself, 'This bird has given me good advice in warfare!'

Related Characters: Aśvatthaman , Samjaya, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Drona, Śiva

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 564

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is a prelude to Aśvatthaman's deadly night raid, when he takes revenge on many sleeping Pandava allies and kills a whole army virtually by himself while the Pandava brothers and Krishna are away from the camp. On the one hand, the night raid is an injustice, with Aśvatthaman slaughtering sleeping enemy soldiers after his own Kaurava army no longer has any hope of actually winning. But as this passage shows, there is also something natural about it: Aśvatthaman got inspiration for the raid by watching an owl in nature, and in many ways, the night raid is simply a natural response to the increasingly deceptive tactics that the Pandavas themselves have been using in war, as well as a way for Aśvatthaman to get revenge for the death of his father, Drona.

Before conducting his night-raid, Aśvatthaman prays to Śiva. Śiva is known for his changing moods and is often associated with destruction. And so, the night-raid demonstrates the power of the gods and offers a warning against complacency by showing that, in spite of how the Pandavas earned the favor of the gods with their conduct, even they remained vulnerable to the whims of Śiva and the inevitability of death.

👁️ 'Here is the jewel, and here am I.'

Related Characters: Aśvatthaman , Samjaya, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Krishna, Bhima, Drona, Draupadi, Śiva

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 578

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the moment after the Pandavas manage to convince Aśvatthaman to willingly part with the jewel he keeps in his head. Draupadi has requested this jewel as a way to avenge all of the deaths Aśvatthaman caused during his night raid, with the implication being that the Pandavas will have to kill Aśvatthaman in order to get his jewel, since it is so important to him.

Aśvatthaman's jewel offers him protection, but even more than that, it seems to play a role in defining his identity, causing him to value it more than money. Because death in the *Mahabharata* can be a release and a chance for rebirth, Krishna curses Aśvatthaman to receive a penalty worse than death—after losing his precious gem, he must wander the world in anonymity for 3,000 years. Just as the night raid was the terrible cost that the Pandavas had to pay for winning the war, Aśvatthaman has to pay his own cost for carrying out the night raid, and in the process, he loses his very self, as embodied by the precious jewel from his forehead.

Chapter 11. The Women Quotes

👁️ 'Do not grieve, Dhritarashtra. You have not slain Bhima. This was an iron effigy, king that you laid low.'

Related Characters: Krishna, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Yudhishtira, Duryodhana, Bhima, Dhritarashtra

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 584

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes during the aftermath of the Kurukshetra War, when the few surviving Pandavas and Kauravas meet to reconcile. All of a sudden, the old blind king, Dhritarashtra, lashes out to stab Bhima as revenge for Bhima's killing of Dhritarashtra's 100 sons, including Duryodhana. Dhritarashtra immediately regrets his actions, but Krishna soon informs him that he didn't actually kill

Bhima—Krishna anticipated this deception and sent an effigy of Bhima instead.

This passage, as well as many others in the aftermath of the war, explores the nature of grief and how it can lead people to act out in unpredictable ways, which is exactly what happens when Dhritarashtra tries to kill Bhima. Krishna argues that it isn't dharma to indulge in grief, particularly not for a king who has the responsibility to provide for his subjects. In this passage, Krishna helps Dhritarashtra overcome his grief by showing him the consequences of letting grief drive his actions. What's more, Krishna will play a similar role in helping some of the war's other survivors come to terms with what they lost in the fighting.

☞ Thus Yudhishtira lord of dharma lamented again and again; then, weeping softly, O king, the lord of men made an offering of water to his brother.

Related Characters: Ugrasravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Yudhishtira, Arjuna, Bhima, Dhritarashtra, Karna, Kunti

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 596

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the moment when Yudhishtira learns that Karna, whom Arjuna killed, was actually his biological brother, with the five Pandava brothers and Karna all sharing Kunti as a mother. Yudhishtira didn't know all this when fighting Karna, and so he grieves that his army had to kill a man who under different circumstances might have been a true brother to him.

More than any other Pandava, Yudhishtira suffers from grief after the Kurukshetra War, perhaps because as king he feels a sense of responsibility for everything that occurred. On the one hand, the honor that Yudhishtira pays to his dead brother is admirable, but as the earlier quote with Dhritarashtra and Bhima showed, too much grief can warp a person's thinking and cause them to do things they wouldn't otherwise do. Much of the next couple books deals with Yudhishtira's attempts to come to terms with his grief, showing how grief can paralyze a person but also how it can lay the groundwork for growth.

Chapter 12. Tranquility Quotes

☞ *Bhishma agrees to expound his knowledge, but insists that it must be Yudhishtira who questions him. Krishna explains that Yudhishtira is filled with shame and fears Bhishma's curse, but Bhishma insists that the killing even of relatives and elders is in accord with the Kshatriya dharma.*

Related Characters: Ugrasravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Yudhishtira, Krishna, Bhishma

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 606

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the moment after the Kurukshetra War when Yudhishtira meets Bhishma (who has managed to survive after being defeated in battle due to a boon), and Bhishma offers to give him all of the knowledge that he's acquired over his many years of living. Due to the long length of both this book and the next one, translator John D. Smith summarizes Bhishma's words instead of translating them verbatim, which he indicates in the book by rendering the text in all italics.

The conversation between Bhishma and Yudhishtira is significant because it shows how two men who fought as enemies on the battlefield can come together in peace afterwards with the intention of exchanging wisdom. Bhishma goes off on sprawling speeches that cover just about every aspect of living a moral life. While not all of Bhishma's various conversational threads tie together, one of the recurring concepts is that, despite all its destruction, the Kurukshetra War was necessary and justified. Bhishma introduces this idea by reassuring Yudhishtira that he holds no grudge for all of his relatives that Yudhishtira killed—that it is, in fact, even dharma in some cases to kill family members. And so, while earlier sections of the poem highlighted the immense toll of the Kurukshetra War, later passages like this one put that toll into context and attempt to justify it.

Chapter 13. Instruction Quotes

☞ *Bhishma replies that nothing can grow if no seed is sown: one should practice austerities, give gifts, abstain from violence and live virtuously, for this is what will determine one's future condition.*

Related Characters: Ugrasravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Yudhishtira, Krishna, Bhishma

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 701

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes Bhishma's long conversation on his deathbed with Yudhishtira, which takes up nearly two full books of the poem. In this section, Bhishma echoes the advice of Krishna in the *Bhagavadgita*, suggesting that it is important to take action, sowing the metaphorical seeds for the future, instead of simply passively avoiding evil. Also, like Krishna, Bhishma frames seemingly passive actions in an active way: for example, instead of telling Yudhishtira to avoid greed, he instead advises him to practice austerities, a subtle difference that puts the emphasis on action.

Ultimately, Bhishma advises Yudhishtira to take action because actions are what determine the quality of a person's future rebirth. At a time when Yudhishtira often feels frozen by grief, Bhishma's advice offers an antidote, reminding Yudhishtira that he must always be thinking of his next life. Bhishma's prominent speeches in the book help highlight the wisdom a person gains with age as well as perhaps the clarity they receive from being near death and being unafraid to face it.

Chapter 14. The Horse Sacrifice Quotes

☞ 'Perform the horse sacrifice in due form, with gifts to all the Brahmins; for the horse sacrifice purifies one of all sins, lord of kings, and after sacrificing with that rite you will be sinless, make no doubt.'

Related Characters: Vyasa , Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Yudhishtira , Arjuna

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 714

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Vyasa advises Yudhishtira to conduct a horse sacrifice for the purpose of putting the destruction of the Kurukshetra War behind him and also as a way to honor the return of the Pandavas to their rightful position in control of Hastinapura. Vyasa is one of the wisest figures in the poem—in fact, he is also traditionally the author of the *Mahabharata*, having instructed his assistant, Vaiśampayana, in how to narrate the story—and so Yudhishtira knows to

follow his advice.

The horse sacrifice involves allowing a horse to wander the whole expanse of the Pandavas' kingdom, with only Arjuna following it to protect it. This highly symbolic ritual serves as a test to prove how strong the Pandavas reign is, and the horse's eventual successful journey (with Arjuna's help) confirms that Yudhishtira is the legitimate king in control of his land. Yudhishtira then ends the ceremony by killing the horse and offering lavish gifts to Vyasa and to the priests in attendance—another symbolic gesture that shows how generous Yudhishtira is as a leader, both to the gods and to his subjects. The horse ceremony offers a parallel to the consecration ceremony Yudhishtira conducted when he first became king, and it represents both a restoration of the old status quo as well as a new, auspicious beginning.

Chapter 15. The Hermitage Quotes

☞ So, like a cloud sating the earth with rain, King Dhritarashtra sated those priests with the torrents of wealth he showered upon them; and when all was done, that lord of the earth then deluged his guests of every class with downpours of food and drink.

Related Characters: Vyasa , Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Yudhishtira , Duryodhana , Krishna , Dhritarashtra

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 738

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes Dhritarashtra 15 years after the Kurukshetra War, as he gives away his wealth in order to prepare to lead an ascetic life in the woods. Whereas previously Dhritarashtra faltered as a leader, too easily led astray by the passions of his son Duryodhana, Dhritarashtra's time to reflect on his mistakes seems to have changed him for the better. Generosity is one of the most important traits of a good leader in the poem, and Dhritarashtra demonstrates that he has learned this lesson by giving his wealth away freely, along with nourishing food and drink.

While Krishna advises Yudhishtira against prematurely retiring to an ascetic life, arguing that he must still be an active leader to fulfill his dharma as a king, the elderly Dhritarashtra is in a different phase of his life, and by choosing to go to the forest, he accepts the end of his life as a public figure and devotes himself to contemplation,

providing an example of how dharma differs from person to person as well as based on a person's stage of life.

Chapter 16. The Clubs Quotes

Thinking that he had committed a dreadful crime, he touched his head to Krishna's feet in distress; but noble Krishna reassured him, even as he soared aloft, filling all heaven and earth with his glory.

Related Characters: Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Krishna, Vishnu, Balarama

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 763

Explanation and Analysis

This quote describes the death of Krishna, who gets accidentally shot by an old hunter named Jara (whose name in Sanskrit means "old age"). Although Jara fears that he's made a terrible mistake, Krishna's glorious ascent suggests that Jara did nothing wrong after all. What could have been a tragic occasion instead becomes joyous, as Krishna accepts the end of his mortal life and moves on to whatever comes next.

Krishna's acceptance in the face of his death offers a model for how others should behave. The hunting accident that kills Krishna represents how the forces of old age (embodied by Jara) can come for a person at the most unexpected times. Despite being a glorious figure—an incarnation of the powerful god Vishnu—Krishna has a relatively mundane death. This illustrates how death inevitably comes for even the greatest mortals in unexpected ways, which means that a person must always be ready to accept when their time is up.

Chapter 17. The Great Journey Quotes

'Great Indra,' said Yudhishtira, 'abandoning one who is devoted is considered an extreme sin in the world, equal to that of killing a Brahmin. Therefore for my own well-being today I shall certainly not abandon him.'

Related Characters: Yudhishtira, Ugraśravas, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Arjuna, Bhima, Draupadi, Indra, Nakula and Sahadeva, Parikshit, Dharma

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 776

Explanation and Analysis

In this section, Yudhishtira's passes the kingship on to his successor Parikshit and goes on a long journey with Bhima, Arjuna, Nakula, Sahadeva, Draupadi, and a dog. After a long journey, all of Yudhishtira's traveling companions drop dead, leaving Yudhishtira alone with the dog, and it's at this point that Indra appears and asks Yudhishtira if he'll abandon the dog, since Indra claims that people with dogs can't get into heaven. Even though, as far as Yudhishtira knows, the dog is just a god, he refuses to abandon it, ignoring even the command of the great god Indra in order to remain loyal to the dog.

As it turns out, the dog is actually the god Dharma in disguise—fitting, given that Yudhishtira was the lord of dharma as a ruler, and so "dharma" has been his companion in some form for most of his life. This scene is one of many in the poem in which a person or animal turns out to be different than what they appear to be on the surface. This passage illustrates Yudhishtira's dedication to his principles, showing how even after giving up his position as king, he is willing to do whatever it takes to maintain his loyalty—even if that means giving up heaven itself.

Chapter 18. The Ascent to Heaven Quotes

'All kings shall see hell—this is inescapable, son. One's merits and demerits form two heaps, bull-like hero. He who first enjoys the merit of his good deeds goes afterwards to hell, whereas he who first endures hell goes afterwards to heaven.'

Related Characters: Ugraśravas, Indra, Vaiśampayana (speaker), Yudhishtira, Duryodhana

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 784

Explanation and Analysis

Indra speaks these words to Yudhishtira after Yudhishtira enters heaven in his mortal form. When Yudhishtira first arrives in heaven, he is shocked to see Duryodhana sitting on a throne and none of his old friends and allies around, only to be led to a new room where he hears those allies being tortured. But as Indra explains, this was just a temporary visit to hell, which is something that even the

greatest kings undergo.

While Indra's words about kings going to hell are quite literal, they also have a lot of symbolic meaning, suggesting that kings who are willing to endure "hellish" hardships early in their reign may be able to reap the rewards later on. Conversely, kings who take the easy way out and try to enjoy "heaven" too early may suffer the consequences of their choices later. By enduring hardships both during his mortal life and during his literal trip to hell, Yudhishtira proves his worth as a leader and his ability to act according to the dharma of kings.

☞ This *Bharata* that emerged from the lips of Krishna Dvaipayana Vyasa is without measure; holy purifying and auspicious, it drives away sin. If a man studies it as he hears it recited, what need has he to bathe in the waters of holy Lake Pushkara?

Related Characters: Ugraśravas (speaker), Vyasa

Related Themes:     

Page Number: 791

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is the final few lines of the *Mahabharata*, and the lines make up a short verse spoken by Ugraśravas. In these lines, Ugraśravas praises the *Mahabharata* itself, saying that studying the poem is as purifying as bathing in a holy lake. Like the first lines of the poem, Ugraśravas promises not only that the *Mahabharata* will educate people about how to lead better lives but also that it literally has the power to help people avoid sin or achieve victory.

The power of the *Mahabharata* is that it uses storytelling as a way to convey knowledge, encouraging both introspection as well as engaging with larger, universal questions about morality. The plot and structure of the *Mahabharata* all help to emphasize the power of storytelling, with the poem containing stories within stories within stories. Although the poem ultimately endorses action, suggesting that people should attempt to actively live out their dharma, it emphasizes how stories can lead people to acquire knowledge and learn which actions are best for a given situation.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1. BEGINNINGS

Ugrasravas the Suta approaches the Brahmin seers who live in the Naimisha Forest and who follow a chief named Śaunaka. One of the seers asks him where he came from. He replies that he has heard the amazing stories of the *Mahabharata* and has traveled around the world to many holy places. He asks if the seers want to hear stories of religion and the great deeds of heroes and seers.

The seers ask to hear a story from an old tale from a noble seer named Dvaipayana (also known as Vyasa), which includes the history of the Bharata war (also called the Kurukshetra War because it took place at Kurukshetra). They have heard this particular story is full of dharma. Ugrasravas says first he must bow to Vishnu. Then he agrees to tell them about Vyasa. Ugrasravas's story goes back to the origins of the universe and explains how the *Mahabharata* is holy and how studying it can help free people from evil.

LISTINGS OF THE BOOKS. Ugrasravas describes the organization of the *Mahabharata*, which has 18 main books (*parvans*) and hundreds of sub-books (*uparvans*).

PAUSHYA. Ugrasravas describes where he first heard the *Mahabharata*, which was during Janamejaya's **snake** sacrifice. The sacrifice is necessary because Janamejaya's brothers hurt a holy dog, and the dog cursed Janamejaya to suffer an accident.

Meanwhile, Uttanka visits King Paushya to obtain some earrings from the king's wife to give as a gift to the wife of his teacher. The **snake** king Takshka steals the earrings, but Uttanka recovers them. Uttanka goes to Janamejaya to help get revenge on Takshka.

The Mahabharata is a story about stories, and so it's fitting that it begins with a Suta—a group of people known for being storytellers. Although the Mahabharata is a holy text like the Bible or the Quran, dealing with matters of religious doctrine, it is also an epic poem with an overarching story that treats the figures in it as complex characters.



Dharma is perhaps the most important concept in the whole poem. It provides a guide for humans to live their lives, which differs depending on an individual's social class and stage in life. As its extreme length and scope both suggest, the Mahabharata aims to be a comprehensive guide for life.



Although the Mahabharata is a story, it also sometimes gets described as "encyclopedic" due to how much detail it provides. The poem's elaborate structure reflects this level of detail.



The poem deals with humanity's relationship with nature, which can be both harmonious and hostile. In this case, Janamejaya's brothers upset the natural balance, and so Janamejaya's sacrifice represents an attempt to restore order.



Many parts of the Mahabharata, particularly in the first couple books, feature self-contained stories that provide context for the central plot but only relate to it tangentially. This reflects the poem's aim to be comprehensive and emphasizes how rich and varied India's ancient history was.



PULOMAN. Ugraśravas asks the seers what more they want to hear. Śaunaka asks to hear about a lineage of Brahmins called Bhrigu, which begins with a man named Puloman. One of his descendants is a seer named Ruru, whose lover gets killed by a **snake**. Ruru voluntarily gives up half of his own life span to resurrect her and marry her, and from then on, he kills every snake he sees. One day, he almost kills a lizard, and the lizard stops to tell him he's not a snake—he's actually a seer who was cursed to become a lizard. Ruru learns not to commit violence, even against snakes.

ASTIKA. Now Ugraśravas returns to Janamejaya's **snake** sacrifice story. Janamejaya organizes a large sacrifice of many snakes because a snake named Takshka killed his father (Parikshit). A seer named Astika wants to stop the sacrifice. When he first comes to Janamejaya, he praises the sacrifice of snakes, and so Janamejaya offers him a boon. But then Astika takes his boon right before the sacrifice of Takshka—he says for his boon, he wants the ritual to stop, saving the life of Takshka. The happy surviving snakes say that anyone who tells this story will become invulnerable to snakes. Śaunaka now wants to hear the *Mahabharata*, which Ugraśravas heard from Vyasa at the snake sacrifice.

THE EARLIEST LINEAGES. Ugraśravas tells a story. Within that story, Vyasa (also known as Krishna Dvaipayana, who is famous for compiling the Vedas) goes to see Janamejaya at the **snake** sacrifice. At the sacrifice, he tells Janamejaya a brief version of the *Mahabharata*, but Janamejaya wants to hear the whole thing, all 100,000 verses full of heroic battles and dharma. Vyasa instructs his pupil, Vaiśampayana to tell it. Vaiśampayana calls the story a Tale of Victory that will help people who hear it conquer the earth. The tale also gives wealth to its hearers. The story has the name *Mahabharata* because it tells the tale of Bharata's heirs.

In Vaiśampayana's story, a king named Vasu is a huntsman who is full of dharma. The supreme god Indra tells him to conquer a region called Cedi. Indra takes favor on Vasu and gives him a flying chariot that can go through the sky and a victory garland that protects Vasu from all wounds. He also gives him a bamboo pole, and Vasu plants a new bamboo pole every year in Indra's honor.

In this story, a man learns that an animal he's about to kill is actually a human in disguise. Animals play a complicated role in the poem. While on the one hand, virtuous humans often offer up animal sacrifices to show deference to the gods, this does not mean that humans should act violently toward all animals. The disguised seer in this self-contained story demonstrates to Ruru how animals have hidden depth. In Hinduism, an animal could have been a person in a past life or vice versa, and this passage emphasizes how humans and animals are similar.



This story about sparing the life of Takshka has strong parallels to the story of the seer Ruru in the previous section. Just as Ruru learns not to kill snakes because they might be a seer in disguise, Janamejaya learns not to show mercy to Takshka, even after he kills his father. The surviving snakes offer immunity to anyone who retells this story, suggesting that, despite Takshka's killing of Parikshit, it's nevertheless possible for humans to have a harmonious relationship with snakes if they pay them the proper respect.



*When Vaiśampayana says that the *Mahabharata* gives wealth and victory to its hearers, he seems to mean that the story literally has the power to affect a person's life. But perhaps he also means this metaphorically, suggesting that the *Mahabharata* might not literally make gold appear but might help a person learn how to lead a better life. The first book of the poem is essentially an origin story, starting with the early descendants of a lineage, and going down through each generation until it reaches the people who will serve as the main characters for the majority of the poem: the Pandava brothers.*



This passage shows the first of many harmonious relationships between humans and gods. As one of the most powerful gods, Indra has the ability to sway human events to benefit people he favors. Importantly, Vasu doesn't abuse this favor and instead conducts a ritual to show gratitude toward the gods, showing how even the gods' favorite humans must nevertheless show deference to them.



King Vasu stays in Cedi and takes a mountain-girl named Girika as his wife. One day while he's off hunting in the forest, he is thinking of his wife when suddenly his "seed" spills out onto the leaf of a tree. He doesn't want to waste the "seed" because he believes it's his wife's "seasonal time" to conceive, so he gives it to a hawk to take back to her. But another hawk attacks, and Vasu's seed falls into a river, where an Apsara (a type of celestial spirit) has been cursed to become a fish.

Children get conceived in a wide variety of ways over the course of the Mahabharata. The persistent focus on the act of child-making (which can involve sex but doesn't always in this poem) relates to the poem's focus on heritage and lineages. The poem is full of power struggles for land, and as a result, kings and other leaders must constantly prove their own legitimacy. Lineage is one of the most important ways to do that, although a venerable lineage does not always guarantee that a person will be a good leader.



Nine months later, some fishermen catch a fish, and when they cut it open, two human children are inside, one male, one female. The fish is the Apsara, who resumes her celestial form and is free again. The boy from the fish becomes the king Matsya, while Vasu gives the daughter, Satyawati, to the fisherman who caught her.

The Mahabharata depicts a patriarchal society where men have more rights than women. Although some individual figures and events challenge this perception, this passage is a clear example of patriarchy, showing the different life paths of a boy and a girl born at the same time—where the boy grows up to become a king, the girl gets given away to the fisherman who found her.



One day, a great seer named Paraśara sees the beautiful Satyawati ferrying a boat. He says that if she "pleasures" him, he'll allow her to stay a virgin and give her a boon. She wishes to be the most fragrant person in the world, and so Paraśara has sex with her and grants her wish. Paraśara then gives birth that very same day to a son: Vyasa. This is the same famous Vyasa who goes on to compile the Vedas and compose the *Mahabharata*.

While lineage is important for kings trying to claim legitimacy, it can be important for other figures as well. Vyasa's birth is miraculous in many ways, signifying that he is an important person—and because Vyasa is the legendary author of the Mahabharata, this gives greater legitimacy to the poem itself.



At the **snake** sacrifice, Janamejaya tells Vaiśampayana that he wants to hear the full account of how the heroes of the *Mahabharata* were born. Vaiśampayana agrees to tell him. He tells the story of Rama Jamadagnya who annihilated all the Kshatriya warriors on earth 21 times. The surviving Kshatriya women went to see the Brahmins, who helped them conceive thousands of new Kshatriyas. It was the Krita Age, full of dharma, with people of all classes fulfilling their roles. But just when humans were living prosperously, demons—who had been defeated in battles with the gods—decided to be born on earth in royal lineages.

The Krita Age was a golden age—a period that the poem's narrative present (known as the Kali Age) can never live up to. This hints at how the events of the Mahabharata represent an ideal: it might not be possible or even desirable for Janamejaya and his successors to try to replicate the events of the Mahabharata in the present era. For an extreme example, Rama Jamadagnya's annihilation of the Kshatriyas should probably be taken as an example of how violence can lead to renewal and does not represent a literal instruction for modern readers to kill all Kshatriyas.



These demons oppressed all classes: Brahmins, Kshatriya, Vaiśyas, and Sudras. Troubled by the demons, Earth sought out Lord Brahma, creator of worlds, for help. Brahma promises to enlist all of heaven to help Earth with her problems. He tells his fellow gods that they must give up a part of themselves to be born on earth to oppose the demons. Many gods, including Indra, hear Brahma's command and agree to have a part of themselves take mortal form.

The various social classes of ancient India—a precursor to what would later be called the “caste system”—play an important role in the poem. While there is a hierarchy, with most of the major figures being either Brahmins or Kshatriya, one of the central themes of the poem is that everyone has their own role to play in society—their dharma. Similarly, all humans, even the highest Brahmins, must pay deference to a social order where gods are at the top above mortals. In return, the gods watch over the mortals, as Brahma does here by encouraging his fellow gods to take mortal forms.



At the **snake** sacrifice, Janamejaya asks Vaiśampayana to tell more about the deeds of the mortal incarnations of gods and demons, and Vaiśampayana does so. There is Drona, a tiger-like king who wasn't born from the womb. Then there's Aśvatthaman, the lotus-eyed destroyer, who is the son of Drona as well as a fusion of the god Śiva and Death. Bhishma is born in the Kuru kingdom at the command of Indra and fights against Rama Jamadagnya from the Bhṛigu kingdom.

This passage and the subsequent ones are a brief summary of the books that follow. This pattern recurs throughout the poem, where first a narrator tells the short version of a story, then the listener asks the narrator to give more details. These summaries help ensure that the audience understands the basic plot before moving on to the full version of the story.



Kripa is a Brahmin seer from Kuru. Śakuni is a mighty fighter in his chariot. Vidura is one of the wisest men in the world. King Duryodhana, however, is foolish and brings disgrace to the people of the Kuru line (also called Kauravas)—a part of him comes from the evil being known as Kali. Then there are the heroic five Pandavas brothers: Yudhishtira, Bhima, Arjuna, Nakula, and Sahadeva. Abhimanyu is Arjuna's son. Karna is a chariot-fighter and has part of a sun god in him.

All of the people listed in this passage become major figures later in the poem. In some ways, this passage is like the list of characters at the beginning of a play. By drawing attention to the poem's most important figures, the poem builds suspense for their eventual appearance in the story and helps the audience understand from the beginning which figures are noteworthy.



ORIGINS. ŚAKUNTULA. Vaiśampayana begins to tell Janamejaya about the lineage of Kuru. In the story, King Duhshanta was out hunting in the woods one day when he came to a hermitage. There, he sees a beautiful girl named Śakuntula. Duhshanta and Śakuntula conceive a son together, whom Duhshanta promises will one day be prince regent. Śakuntula's son grows up for his first six years in the hermitage, but after she takes him to Duhshanta's castle, Duhshanta claims to have no memory of Śakuntula or his son. Eventually, however, a heavenly voice tells Duhshanta to accept Śakuntula back. He does so, and his son becomes Bharata, a great monarch and the start of a lineage.

The story of Śakuntula is one of the most famous sections of the Mahabharata, and it has been adapted many times. While it functions as a self-contained story, it also acts as an origin for the rest of the poem, since Śakuntula's son Bharata is the head of the main familial lineage that the poem eventually focuses on. While men occupy the positions of power in the Mahabharata, this story somewhat challenges that notion, showing that the correct thing for King Duhshanta to do—his dharma—is to believe Śakuntula's words and accept her.



YAYATI. Vaiśampayana tells many more of the important lineages for the story. Then, after Janamejaya asks a question, Vaiśampayana stops to tell the story of how Yayati married Devayani. Devayani originally wants to marry a man named Kaca, who gets killed and revived several times. In one of these revivals, he gets turned to ashes that Devayani's father, Śukra, drinks with liquor, and then Kaca bursts from Śukra's stomach. Kaca then rejects Devayani because he says they're now siblings (since he came out of her father's stomach), and the two part ways.

Later, Yayati sees Devayani with her friend Śarmishtha when he's out hunting and wants to marry her. The problem is that he's a Kshatriya and she's a Brahmin. Yayati gets permission from Śukra, on the condition that Yayati never has sex with Śarmishtha. Yayati marries Devayani and has two sons with her, but he doesn't follow Śukra's condition and also has three sons with Śarmishtha.

When Devayani finds out about Yayati's other sons and tells her father, Śukra, he curses Yayati to either suffer old age himself or to pass old age on to one of his sons—and if he passes it on to a son, that son will become a great king. Yayati's youngest son, Puru, agrees to accept the curse. Yayati rules peacefully for 1,000 years while Puru endures old age. Finally, Yayati restores Puru's youth. The Paurava lineage then descends from Puru, creating a dynasty that eventually includes Janamejaya himself.

THE LATER STORY OF YAYATI. Vaiśampayana tells of Yayati's later years. After living peacefully for many years, Yayati goes to heaven, but his pride in his own ascetic lifestyle leads the god Indra to throw Yayati back to earth, where he meets a seer who asks what it's like to be reborn. Yayati explains how people get reborn as "higher or lower creatures" based on how well they lived their lives.

Janamejaya interrupts the story to ask about the kings that came after Puru. Vaiśampayana agrees to tell him about that lineage, starting with Puru, going six generations to Duhshanta, then eventually going down several more generations to Janamejaya himself. Vaiśampayana begins telling in more detail the story of King Pratipa from this line.

Proper marriage is another recurring theme in the Mahabharata, related to the theme of lineages and succession. This story gives an extreme example of an impediment to marriage—few people in the real world have to worry about being turned to ashes and eaten by a potential father-in-law. Nevertheless, the extreme example helps illustrate the care that people should take even in normal circumstances to ensure that they follow the proper customs of marriage.



Interestingly, Yayati's decision to break his promise to Śukra seems to be a positive choice—as the next passage reveals, it leads to the foundation of the illustrious Puru lineage. While dharma is important to the poem, following dharma is never as simple as just abiding by a list of rules.



The Mahabharata is full of both curses that aren't as bad as they seem and boons that don't quite live up to their potential. Here, the curse on Yayati ends up helping the formation of the whole Puru lineage. The poem emphasizes again and again that morality isn't black and white, and the prevalence of mixed curses and boons helps drive this point home.



The dangers of pride show up again and again throughout the poem. This passage provides a good example of how the poem combines a narrative with religious instruction, as Yayati's description of the concept of reincarnation gets integrated into his life story.



This passage, with its list of many names, doesn't advance the narrative, but it serves an important functional purpose, since the purpose of the Mahabharata is not just to entertain but to be informative. The list of kings shows once again the importance of succession and lineages.



Pratipa reigned in peace for many years when one day he sees the beautiful seer Ganga (a mortal form of the goddess of the sacred river Ganges). He fears she may already be married, but she replies that she belongs to no one. Pratipa still feels that to have sex with her would be against his dharma, so instead he wants her to marry his son, Śamtanu.

When Śamtanu grows up, Pratipa tells him about his arrangement with Ganga. Pratipa then makes Śamtanu the king of his own kingdom. One day, Śamtanu is out hunting when he sees the most beautiful woman he's ever seen. Although at first, he fears she's a demon, it turns out it's Ganga, who's ready to fulfill her promise. They have sex, and Śamtanu is so in love that he loses track of how much time passes. She bears eight sons but drowns each of them in the river. She says she does this to please Śamtanu—while Śamtanu isn't pleased, he doesn't say anything because he doesn't want to lose Ganga.

Before Ganga can kill their eighth son, Śamtanu begs her to stop. She explains that she had to kill the previous sons because they were the Vasus, eight gods that temporarily took mortal form due to a curse by the seer Vasishtha. Now the curse is broken, and Ganga must leave Śamtanu. She leaves, taking her son Devavrata (later called Bhishma) with her.

Śamtanu rules many more years in peace until one day he notices the river is running low. He goes to investigate and finds that a handsome young boy who seems to have a superhuman ability with the bow and arrow has dammed the river with his arrows. Śamtanu figures this boy must be his son, so he asks Ganga to show herself again. Ganga confirms that he is Śamtanu's son (Bhishma), and that he has spent many years studying both weapons and spirituality.

Śamtanu's son Devavrata (Bhishma) earns recognition across the land for his skills and good conduct. One day while he's traveling, Śamtanu happens across a fisherman's daughter (Satyawati), who has the most fragrant scent in the world. Her father says Śamtanu can marry her, but only if any son they bear inherits the role of king from Śamtanu. Śamtanu refuses these conditions. Still, he keeps thinking of the girl and wonders what would happen to his line if Devavrata ever had an accident. He and Śamtanu go back to see the fisher girl's father.

The goddess Ganga, who shares a name with the river Ganga (also known as the Ganges), emphasizes how important nature is to humans. Just as the physical river affected people's crops for the year, making farming possible, the goddess Ganga could choose to bless people.



The death of Śamtanu's eight sons foreshadows the many deaths that will come later in the poem. Notably, the goddess Ganga does not mourn these deaths, believing them to be necessary. This attitude toward death reflects the attitude that many of the gods in the poem share, and the wisest humans in the poem are the ones who are able to accept the inevitability of death and understand the purpose it can serve.



Once again, this passage highlights how the will of gods doesn't always make sense from a human perspective, and vice versa—Śamtanu begs Ganga not to drown their ninth son, but in fact, she never planned to do so and seems surprised by his grief for the previous sons.



Religion plays a complicated role in the poem—while some of the most devout figures are ascetics and pacifists, others, like Bhishma, seem to draw fighting strength from their devotion. Śamtanu's recognition of his son Bhishma recalls King Duhshanta's recognition of his son Bharata earlier in the poem, showing how the same events play out in different forms throughout the generations.



Śamtanu is so afraid of making sure he has a successor lined up that he doesn't want to trust everything to Bhishma, even though Bhishma is such a renowned warrior. Fish and rivers continue to play a vital role in the story, showing how humanity and nature intertwine and how water makes life possible. Satyawati's seemingly supernatural ability to entrance Śamtanu is due to the boon she received earlier that makes her the most fragrant-smelling person on earth.



To the fisherman, Devavrata promises he will give up his kingship, so that Śamtanu can marry Satyavati. He also promises to become celibate. The fisherman feels that this promise is full of dharma, so he agrees to give away his daughter in marriage to Śamtanu. A whole host of gods, Apsarases (nymphs), and seers shower Devavrata with flowers and proclaim that he is Bhishma. As a boon for his son, Śamtanu gives Bhishma the ability to choose the hour of his own (Bhishma's) death.

While the poem sometimes involves the literal rebirth of people who die, there are also many metaphorical rebirths in the poem, such as when Devavrata proclaims his new identity as Bhishma. Bhishma's ability to choose the time of his own death is one of the most powerful boons that any mortal in the poem receives. This reflects the significance of his sacrifice, since by choosing to be celibate he gives up the chance of continuing his own line.



Satyavati has two sons: Citrangada and Vicitravirya. Citrangada dies in battle, so Bhishma makes the child Vicitravirya king. When Vicitravirya is old enough, Bhishma abducts three sisters—Amba, Ambika, and Ambilika—and has Vicitravirya marry Ambika and Ambilika. Vicitravirya lives happily for seven years before dying of a lung disease. Satyavati wants to find someone to conceive a child with Ambika, wanting Ambilika to continue the lineage, and since Bhishma remains celibate, she decides to find a Brahmin and summons Vyasa.

To a modern reader, the gender politics in the Mahabharata can be jarring, such as in this passage, where the supposedly holy and heroic Bhishma abducts three young women to force them to conceive children. While some "abductions" in the poem are more like elopements (for example, in a later section, Arjuna "abducts" Krishna's sister in a seemingly consensual marriage), this passage seems more like a kidnapping and shows the lengths that Bhishma is willing to go to in order to protect his family's lineage.



Satyavati explains to Ambika that Vyasa is coming to her that night. They have sex, but Ambika has to close her eyes. Later, Vyasa promises that Ambika will have a son as strong as 10,000 elephants, but because Ambika closed her eyes, their son (Dhritarashtra) will also be blind. Satyavati feels that a blind man can't be a proper king, so she has Ambilika also conceive a son with Vyasa. When she has sex with Vyasa, she turns pale, and so she gives birth to a pale son they call Pandu.

Because Vyasa is such an esteemed sage, the kidnapped Ambika and Ambilika are supposed to want to have sex with him, despite his old age. It is possible to read this passage about coerced sex as misogynistic, implying that women should always bow to the will of men. Still, the passage does seem to sympathize with Ambika and Ambilika, recognizing the unpleasantness of their duty to have sex with Vyasa.



Finally, instead of sending Ambika again, Satyavati sends a maid dressed up as a princess to Vyasa. The maid delights Vyasa when they have sex, and so he gives her a son named Vidura, who will distinguish himself with his great wisdom.

In this passage, Vyasa, one of the wisest sages and the purported author of the Mahabharata itself, gets tricked by a maid. Interestingly, Vidura ends up being perhaps the wisest of Vyasa's children, even though his mother is a common maid, providing a rare challenge to the poem's connections between merit and lineage.



After the birth of Dhritarashtra, Pandu, and Vidura, the kingdom enters the Krita Age, where everything is prosperous and peaceful. Bhishma looks after the three princes like sons and plays his part to make sure dharma spreads through the whole kingdom. And so Śamtanu's lineage, which once seemed like it might die, now flourishes. Bhishma gets the idea to further strengthen the line by having the princes marry princesses from the land of Subala.

Although this passage describes a golden age of peace and harmony, it also lays the groundwork for the events of the Kurukshetra War, which involves fighting between the sons of Dhritarashtra and the sons of Pandu. Bhishma's focus on promoting dharma and finding suitable spouses for his children provides a model of good leadership that later kings in the poem will also follow.



When Bhishma arranges for Dhritarashtra to marry the princess Gandhari, her parents worry about their daughter marrying a blind man. But Gandhari ties cloth over her eyes to be more like her future husband. Meanwhile, Pandu marries Kunti (also known as Pritha). Before meeting Pandu, Kunti was a virgin until she had a child (Karna) with a sun god. Because of the unusual circumstances, she was allowed to keep her virginity but had to abandon her child to hide the evidence. Karna grows up under the care of Sutas and becomes a warrior called Karna the Cutter. Pandu has a second wife, Madri. Pandu can't have children himself due to a curse that prevents him from having sex with his wife—he received this curse one day while hunting when he mortally wounded a seer while the seer was having sex with his wife in the form of a deer.

As ruler, Pandu sets out on many successful military campaigns, while Dhritarashtra uses some of Pandu's new wealth for sacrifices to the gods. Bhishma also finds a wife for Vidura. Altogether, Dhritarashtra and Gandhari have 100 sons, a feat that is only possible due to a boon Gandhari receives from Vyasa. Among these many sons is the future king Duryodhana. There's also just one daughter: Duhśala.

Meanwhile, Kunti receives boon that she can have a son with any god she chooses, so she calls upon the god Dharma. She gives birth to Yudhishtira, who will go on to become a famous king. Kunti then calls upon a wind god, who helps her give birth to her next son, Bhima. Still, Pandu wants an even greater son to come from his wife Kunti, so he tries to win favor with the great god Indra. His wife calls on Indra, and Indra gives her the great warrior son Arjuna.

Pandu wants even more sons, but Kunti warns him that the children they have are sufficient, and he shouldn't be greedy. Still, Pandu's other wife Madri is sad that she doesn't have any children. Pandu takes this concern to Kunti, who agrees to call down a pair of twin gods so that Madri can have children. The gods give Madri two beautiful twin boys: Nakula and Sahadeva. All five of Pandu's sons—part of the Kuru lineage—earn great renown as mighty warriors.

Gandhari's decision to tie cloth over her own eyes to be like her blind husband emphasizes how a good wife—in the Mahabharata—is one who's willing to make extreme sacrifices for her husband. Virgin births like Kunti's birth of Karna with a sun god are common in religions from around the world. Kunti's unusual pregnancy suggests that the ideal woman (according to the poem) is both sexually pure and a mother—an impossible standard in the present era but one that was possible in the golden age the poem describes. But while avoiding sex is a blessing for Kunti, it is a curse for Pandu, as giving in to sexual temptation can literally lead to his death.



In a story where succession is so important, Dhritarashtra's 100 sons seem to be a tremendous boon that will ensure the survival of his lineage for many generations. But while Gandhari is a devoted wife, Dhritarashtra and particularly his son Duryodhana will prove themselves unworthy of this blessing and essentially undo all its benefits by starting a costly war, showing how boons come with responsibilities.



Kunti's choice to have her first son with Dharma (the god) shows that she is full of respect for dharma (the concept), and so fittingly, her son Yudhishtira grows up to be the lord of Dharma. Meanwhile, Bhima, son of a wind god, ends up having a temper that changes as quickly as the wind. Finally, Arjuna, conceived with one of the most powerful gods, becomes the most powerful warrior of the group. And so, the lives of children in the poem continue to be determined by their parentage.



Although Nakula and Sahadeva are brave warriors, their feats can't compete with those of Kunti's sons, reflecting Kunti's exalted status among women. The fact that Nakula and Sahadeva are considered part of the Pandavas while Karna generally is not (even though he shares Kunti as a mother with Yudhishtira, Bhima, and Arjuna) shows how the concept of family can sometimes be malleable.



Eventually, Pandu can't resist his temptation to try to have sex with Madri, but he dies immediately due to his curse. Madri then kills herself by jumping onto Pandu's funeral pyre, and Kunti raises all five children, who become known as the Pandavas. Out of the five, Bhima in particular forms a rivalry with his cousins, the many sons of Dhritarashtra. Duryodhana, who is one of Dhritarashtra's sons and full of evil energy, begins plotting ways to kill Bhima. He tries drowning Bhima in his sleep and poisoning him, but each time, Bhima's phenomenal strength allows him to survive.

Bhishma is looking for a tutor for the five Pandavas, and he finds one in Drona. Drona accepts the position on the condition that once the five princes have learned how to wield their weapons, they will carry out a special task for him. Drona also instructs Karna, who looks down on the Pandavas (who are secretly his half-brothers). For a short period of time, another one of Drona's students named Ekalavya is better at archery than Arjuna (the best archer of the Pandavas), but then, as a payment for his instruction, Drona asks Ekalavya to give him his right thumb, making Arjuna the best again.

THE BURNING OF THE HOUSE OF LAC. Drona arranges for the five Pandavas to put on a public display of their new weaponry prowess. All of a sudden Karna, a "walking mountain" of a man, interrupts the festivities. Karna lays down a challenge to Arjuna, saying he will best him, performing the same feats. Duryodhana is there and welcomes Karna as a fellow ally against the Pandavas. Still, Karna isn't satisfied—he wants to face Arjuna in single combat.

Arjuna agrees to the fight. He goes to one side with the fellow Pandavas, while Karna goes to the other side with Duryodhana and the other sons of Dhritarashtra. When Karna's adoptive Suta father enters the arena, Bhima laughs at Karna, saying that as a Suta he is not high enough rank to participate in the fight. Duryodhana comes to Karna's defense, praising his many worthy qualities and winning over the crowd. The sun begins to set, and so the crowd has to disperse.

Although Pandu was a capable leader, this passage shows that he was still mortal and vulnerable to temptation, even knowing the consequences. This shocking passage in which Madri throws herself onto the fire shows how much a wife's dharma is connected to her husband's welfare. Historically, some followers of Hinduism took passages like this as an argument for the literal suicide of widows, but such practices were always controversial and are outlawed today.



This passage sets up an extended family dynamic, showing how the various descendants of Vyasa interact with each other. The story of the skilled archer Ekalavya, who has to cut off his thumb to make Arjuna the best, is strange and might seem unfair to Ekalavya. Really, Ekalavya's only fault is that he tried to oppose destiny: Arjuna is destined to be the greatest archer in the world, and Drona is willing to do whatever it takes to make that happen. This foreshadows some of the pragmatic but underhanded tactics the heroes will use in the Kurukshetra War.



This passage shows the beginning of the growing divide between the Kauravas (Dhritarashtra's descendants and allies) and the Pandavas (Pandu's sons and allies). Karna's status as an illegitimate child prevents him from earning the same accolades as the Pandavas, even though he is every bit as skillful. His unfair situation makes him sympathetic in spite of his opposition to the heroic Pandavas.



Bhima's contempt for Karna based on his birth shows how seriously people took class status (which relates to the larger issue of lineage). While Sutas often receive contempt in the story, in fact, this whole passage is being narrated by the Suta Ugrasravas, complicating the question of whether Sutas are really as lowly as some figures in the poem treat them. In any case, Karna is not actually a Suta, just adopted by one.



Drona finally asks the five Pandavas for his fee for acting as a tutor: to capture a king named Drupada. The five princes do so, but at Drona's request, they leave Drupada alive to keep ruling a small part of his old kingdom. Meanwhile, Duryodhana schemes to try to stop the eldest Pandava, Yudhishtira, from becoming king. He arranges an excuse for the five Pandavas to go to a remote area and stay in a house. But then Duryodhana secretly orders the construction of a house made of highly flammable materials, including a resinous substance called lac. He wants to burn them alive in their sleep.

Yudhishtira catches onto Duryodhana's scheme and warns his brothers to be vigilant. Bhima comes up with a scheme to burn one of Duryodhana's aides and some drunken strangers. People witness the remains of the burned house and believe that the Pandavas are dead, but in fact, the Pandavas use the confusion to secretly escape.

THE KILLING OF HIDIMBA. Hidimba, a Rakshasa (demon), orders his sister to kill the Pandavas. She, however, falls in love with Bhima, and so Hidimba himself attacks. Bhima manages to kill him.

THE KILLING OF BAKA. The surviving sister of Hidimba has sex with Bhima many times and gives birth to a half-Rakshasa son they call Ghatotkaca, who is "bald as a pot" and loves his Pandava brothers. It is Ghatotkaca's fate to eventually defeat Karna.

The Pandavas keep traveling, and eventually Vyasa gives them shelter for a while. They move on to a town full of Brahmins who are grieving. A Rakshasa called Baka is terrorizing them. The Rakshasa demands a donation of food, and Bhima agrees to take it to him on behalf of the village, but instead, Bhima manages to slay the Rakshasa after a fierce battle.

CITRARATHA. The Pandavas continue traveling and come across a king named Citraratha who is with his women by the Ganga. Annoyed at being interrupted, Citraratha attacks, but Arjuna fights back, just barely sparing his opponent's life. In return, Citraratha gives up his titles and grants Arjuna the boon to see everything everywhere.

Duryodhana's decision to try to kill his cousins in a burning house is highly symbolic, since a house is a symbol of family and Duryodhana is essentially "burning" his relationship with the Pandavas through this attempted murder. Duryodhana's extreme actions shows how jealous his character is—he can't stand the idea of Yudhishtira becoming king instead of him—and this jealousy lays the groundwork for tragic events later in the narrative.



Bhima begins earning his reputation as the most violent brother, sacrificing an aide for the sake of his own scheme. The seeming death of the Pandavas when they're still very much alive perhaps connects to fire's dual role as both a destroyer and a source for creation and renewal.



The brothers begin to prove themselves through a series of adventures—naturally, the headstrong Bhima is the first to do so by taking on a demon.



Once again, the poem provides a small moment that challenges the issue of heredity, showing how even a half-demon can become a righteous warrior.



The Rakshasa that demands food from the villagers is perhaps a symbol for unjust or tyrannical rule. By slaying this unjust leader, Bhima shows how the Pandavas hope to bring order to their kingdom and secure a more harmonious relationship between ruler and subject.



Although the poem doesn't shy away from violence, sometimes acts of mercy get rewarded, as Arjuna's does here. Arjuna's adventure in this passage contrasts with Bhima's more violent adventures, establishing Arjuna as a more reasoned brother.



TAPATI. After being defeated, Citraratha refers to Arjuna as the “son of Tapati,” which confuses him, because as far as he knows, his mother is Kunti. Citraratha explains that Tapati is a daughter of the sun. She gave birth to Kuru, Arjuna’s ancestor.

VASISHTHA. Arjuna asks Citraratha more about the seer Vasishtha, who plays a minor role in the story of Tapati and who has a famous rivalry with fellow seer Viśvamitra. Viśvamitra is originally a Kshatriya, but he lives an ascetic lifestyle to become a more powerful Brahmin like his rival Vasishtha. Viśvamitra then curses a king to become a cannibal and eat all of Vasishtha’s 100 sons. Vasishtha tries to kill himself but can’t, even after leaping off a mountain and trying to feed himself to river crocodiles. Vasishtha realizes he can’t die, and so he saves the king from his cannibal curse and takes a new queen for himself.

AURVA. Vasishtha has a grandson called Paraśara. Paraśara becomes a great seer and wants to destroy the world, but Vasishtha tells him a story to convince him not to. In the story, a child named Aurva, who is born from a woman’s thigh, sees a massacre and believes the world deserves to be destroyed. His ancestors appear and manage to convince Aurva that violence can be a way to regulate the length of mortal lives without requiring suicide. Aurva puts aside his anger, and after hearing the story of Aurva from Vasishtha, Paraśara does the same.

DRAUPADI’S SVAYAMVARA. The Pandavas continue traveling until they come across a *svayamvara* (a ceremony where a young woman chooses a husband). Many have gathered to try to win a Kshatriya princess named Draupadi, with illustrious heroes and kings in the crowd. But there is a bow that none of them can string to fire an arrow from. At last, however, Arjuna approaches the bow and quickly fires five arrows off right at the target. He receives a victory garland and Draupadi as his wife.

At first the Kshatriya are angry that a Brahmin like Arjuna has won Draupadi, but he fights them off and wins their respect. Back with his brothers, Arjuna feels guilty about marrying before the eldest Yudhishtira. Indeed, all of the brothers fall in love with the beautiful Draupadi. To avoid any argument, Yudhishtira decrees that Draupadi will be a shared wife among all five brothers. Krishna comes to congratulate them all.

The poem includes yet another tangent about lineages, both to help establish a historical record and to show the worthiness of the main figures.



The 100 sons of Vasishtha, who die to cannibalism, provide an ominous portent for Dhritarashtra, who also has 100 sons that he risks “cannibalizing” through his own failures of leadership and his inability to quash the growing feud with the Pandavas. Although Vasishtha suffers a terrible fate, he seems to move on at the end of his story, providing a model for how to deal with grief that will return again and again in the poem.



This self-contained tale provides yet another example of the power of stories, as a story literally saves the world by showing Paraśara the consequences of destruction. The idea that violence serves a purpose—and that mortal lives have an appointed time to end—is central to the poem and helps justify why the heroic figures in the poem kill enemies by the thousands and lead allies to their deaths in battle.



The five arrows that Arjuna fires off from the impossible bow represent him and his five brothers, who will all marry Draupadi. Arrows often have a sexual connotation (see Cupid in Roman mythology), and eventually, Arjuna and his brothers each have a son with Draupadi. Notably, Draupadi’s status as a Kshatriya—the warrior class—emphasizes how the Pandavas are also “married” to the ways of warfare.



Yudhishtira’s decision to have all five brothers marry the same woman is unusual not only in this poem but in other literature and in the actual practice of Hinduism. The strange nature of this marriage emphasizes how the Pandavas are exceptional and how this means they don’t always follow the norms of human behavior.



THE FIVE INDRAS. Drupada, an ally of Yudhishtira, opposes the five-way wedding, but Vyasa explains to him how the five Pandavas are like the great god Indra, and this convinces Drupada to put aside his objections. **THE WEDDING.** The five Pandavas marry Draupadi. **THE COMING OF VIDURA.** Duryodhana and Karna hear about the wedding from Vidura. While Duryodhana and Karna argue to Dhritarashtra that the Pandavas should be killed before they make even more powerful alliances, ultimately, Dhritarashtra listens to Vidura and Bhishma, welcoming the Pandavas back to his kingdom.

Drupada's objections to the Pandavas five-way wedding emphasize how unprecedented it is, but the wise Vyasa (who himself had children through unusual means) gives approval to the marriage, lending it legitimacy. This legitimacy is a threat to Duryodhana, who hasn't given up on his plan to take the Pandavas' kingdom as his own. At this point in the story, Dhritarashtra is still listening to his advisors Vidura and Bhishma, but this passage provides an early example of how Dhritarashtra's opinions are mostly shaped by the people around him.



THE GAINING OF THE KINGDOM. The five Pandavas return home with Draupadi, where Dhritarashtra greets them. The five brothers settle with Dhritarashtra in the city of Bhogavati. **ARJUNA'S EXILE IN THE FOREST.** Janamejaya interrupts the story to ask Vaiśampayana how the five Pandavas avoided arguments over their shared wife. Vaiśampayana explains that the next part of the story addresses this. In the story, the great seer Narada warns the brothers to avoid arguments about Draupadi, telling them a story about the demon brothers Sunda and Upasunda.

The five Pandava brothers each have distinct personalities, and this passage explores some of the ways that they cooperate and avoid conflict in their unusual marriage. Their solution, described in more detail in the next passage, is to always respect when another brother is alone with Draupadi. The Pandavas and particularly Yudhishtira are famous for their role as leaders, and so this passage provides an early example of how they implement a "law" to manage their own family.



SUNDA AND UPASUNDA. Narada tells his story. The two demon brothers Sunda and Upasunda both fall in love with the same woman and fight over her, killing each other with clubs. Hearing this story, the Pandavas agree that, to avoid jealousy, if any brother sees another alone in a room with Draupadi, he must pledge himself to 12 years of celibacy in the forest.

Clubs often come up during personal disputes in the poem, and they often get used during fights between family members or allies, perhaps due to the up-close-and-personal nature of a club battle compared to a long-distance fight with bow and arrow.



One day, Arjuna needs to stop some robbers, but his bow is in a room where Draupadi is with Yudhishtira. He grabs the bow to stop the robbers and later accepts the 12 years of celibacy, believing it is dharma. He leaves to travel and along the way gets tempted by many beautiful women. He visits sacred places and helps people in need.

Arjuna's decision to stop some robbers at the risk of 12 years of celibacy shows how devoted he is to protecting his people. The poem's complicated stance on sex might seem contradictory, praising both celibacy and fertility, but in fact, this just gets at the core idea that dharma varies depending on both the individual person and the person's stage in life.



THE ABDUCTION OF SUBHADRA. Arjuna sees Krishna's sister Subhadra and falls in love with her. He asks Krishna for advice, and Krishna says the best option is to abduct her. Arjuna goes ahead and does so. **THE WEDDING GIFT.** Krishna assures his angry relatives that Arjuna did the right thing. Arjuna marries Subhadra and completes his exile. Draupadi is jealous of Arjuna's new wife. With Subhadra, Arjuna has the son Abhimanyu. Meanwhile, Draupadi has five sons: Prativindhya (with Yudhishtira) Sutasoma (with Bhima), Śrutakirti (with Arjuna), Śatanika (with Nakula), and Śrutasena (with Sahadeva).

Arjuna's abduction of Subhadra seems to be a technicality to get around the objections of Subhadra's family rather than a true kidnapping, although it does have echoes of the abduction that led to Vyasa giving birth to Dhritarashtra, Pandu, and Vidura. This passage shows how the Pandavas live up to their responsibility as leaders by each providing at least one son to succeed them.



THE BURNING OF THE KHANDAVA FOREST. The Pandavas live happily for a while. One day while Arjuna and Krishna are out in the woods, they meet a Brahmin who says that he's Fire. Fire wants to destroy the whole forest to kill the serpent Takshka, but Indra is a friend of Takshka and always rains down on the forest. Arjuna and Krishna help Fire burn down the whole forest, killing many creatures, and even Indra can't stop them, but Takshka manages to get away. Some of the only survivors in the forest are four *śarngaka* (a species of bird).

This passage shows nature in conflict, with fire and rain each seemingly competing with each other over the fate of the forest. This battle of elemental forces foreshadows the human war that will come later in the poem. Notably in this passage, the mortals Arjuna and Krishna manage to fight back against Indra, one of the most powerful gods (though Krishna is an incarnation of the god Vishnu, and Indra ultimately succeeds in his goal of protecting Takshka).



THE ŚARNGAKA BIRDS. Four recently hatched *śarngaka* birds—the children of a female bird and a male seer disguised as a bird—survive the fire because they praised Fire (believing it offers a better death than any other option). Eventually, when the fire recedes, Indra offers Arjuna and Krishna boons. Arjuna asks for **celestial weapons**, while Krishna requests Indra's friendship.

This passage provides the strange example of birds who avoid death specifically because they are willing to accept it. This passage praises an accepting attitude toward death, foreshadowing how Krishna himself will later give this advice in the context of the Kurukshetra War.



CHAPTER 2. THE HALL

THE HALL. Vaiśampayana continues his story, telling of how the demon Maya acquires great wealth and builds a lavish hall with trees made of gold. He gives gifts to the Pandavas, including a club for Bhima and a conch for Arjuna. The hall has 8,000 Rakshasa guards. Maya then gives the great hall to Yudhishtira, who holds a great feast to celebrate. Seers from around the world come, and some play music.

While Rakshasas most often attack humans in the poem, this passage shows yet again how good and evil aren't always straightforward. Conches play an important role in ancient warfare, with warriors blowing them to announce the start of battle. The club that Bhima receives foreshadows the duel of clubs he'll engage in near the climax of the poem.



Narada visits Yudhishtira. Yudhishtira asks Narada if he's ever seen such a magnificent hall. Narada describes some of the splendid halls he's seen. They discuss what it means to be a good leader. Narada says Yudhishtira needs to perform an extreme sacrifice—a royal consecration.

Narada's suggestion that Yudhishtira perform a sacrificial ceremony symbolizes how a good leader must be willing to make sacrifices for their subjects. The many ritual sacrifices in the poem have both practical purposes (to win the favor of the gods) as well as symbolic ones.



CONSULTATIONS. After Narada leaves, Yudhishtira contemplates the matter of a royal consecration. He continues to rule successfully, earning a reputation for having no enemies. He asks advisors for advice about a consecration, summoning Krishna. Krishna warns Yudhishtira of his enemies around the world. In particular, there is Jarasamdha, a king who has captured many other kings and wants to sacrifice them to increase his own standing. Krishna believes it isn't possible to have a royal consecration while the powerful Jarasamdha lives. At first, Yudhishtira thinks it's too risky to try to kill Jarasamdha.

Jarasamdha, who captures other kings with the intention of sacrificing them, shows how the kings in this era were constantly struggling against one another for power. As Krishna advises Yudhishtira, Yudhishtira's authority rests not just on his capability as a leader but also on the absence of others who might pose a threat to his rule. And so, this passage sets up one of the first tests of Yudhishtira, as he has to prove his own ability by dealing with a rival to his throne.



THE KILLING OF JARASAMDHA. Krishna agrees to join Bhima and Arjuna in attacking Jarasamdha. This plan finally pleases Yudhishtira. Krishna, Bhima and Arjuna all travel together to the city of Magadha, which they enter in disguise as unarmed common people. They manage to make their way right to Jarasamdha himself. The king sees through their disguises and asks who they really are. Krishna gives a vague answer and says they've come on hostile terms. Jarasamdha asks how he could possibly be enemies with them, since they're strangers.

Krishna accuses Jarasamdha of being willing to sacrifice other kings because he is arrogant and views himself above all other Kshatriyas. Krishna finally reveals his identity, as well as the identities of Arjuna and Bhima. Jarasamdha protests that he only imprisons kings he has fairly defeated. He asks to fight Krishna however he likes, either one-on-one or with whole armies. Krishna knows Jarasamdha is fated to be killed but not by Krishna himself. He asks Jarasamdha which one of them he wants to fight. Jarasamdha chooses Bhima.

Bhima and Jarasamdha begin a fierce battle that lasts 13 days straight. Bhima learns about Jarasamdha's weaknesses from Krishna. Finally, Bhima manages to catch Jarasamdha in a wrestling hold, spin him around 100 times in the air, then bring him down and break his back, killing him. Krishna, who is unhurt after the battle, mounts his flying chariot with Bhima and Arjuna and rides around the city to everyone's awe. Krishna frees the grateful kings that Jarasamdha captured.

Krishna pardons Jarasamdha's son and makes him the new king. Krishna, Bhima, and Arjuna all go back to Yudhishtira, who greets them joyfully. Yudhishtira asks Krishna's permission to finally perform a royal consecration. Yudhishtira prepares a great feast, inviting illustrious Brahmins and Kshatriyas from across the land, then gives them lavish accommodations. Nakula invites Bhishma and Dhritarashtra, who come gladly. Noble guests keep coming and offering Yudhishtira gifts, believing he is full of dharma. At last, Yudhishtira conducts a sacrifice, and the gods are pleased by his rich gifts.

In order to overcome Jarasamdha, Yudhishtira and the others use cunning at first, disguising themselves as common people in order to get closer to Jarasamdha. This embodies Yudhishtira's leadership strategy as a whole—while he believes in dharma and doing things the proper way, he also isn't afraid to use tricky tactics, particularly in a situation where he believes the ends justify the means.



This passage shows how, particularly for a Kshatriya, a ruler's legitimacy comes from constantly proving oneself in battle. Although Krishna is one of the most powerful figures in the poem, as the incarnation of Vishnu, he deliberately seems to avoid meddling in earthly affairs too much, trying to help the Pandavas achieve their goals rather than actually fighting their battles for them.



Bhima's killing of Jarasamdha, with his 100 spins in the air, is a little over the top, reflecting how battles in this poem are often heightened conflicts between figures who loom larger than life. The battles don't aim for realism in the modern sense, perhaps to convey yet again how most of the poem's action takes place in a past age of heroes that is remote from the more mundane present era.



By pardoning Jarasamdha's son, Krishna shows reason and mercy, perhaps as a way to restore balance after Bhima's violent actions in the previous passage. One of the ways that Yudhishtira proves his leadership abilities is by providing lavish hospitality for his guests. This shows how generosity is an essential part of the dharma for leaders, and while good leaders must constantly watch out for threats to their power, they must also be willing to share the fruits of their power with their subjects.



THE PRESENTATION OF THE GUEST-OFFERINGS. Brahmin seers led by Narada come to the sacrificial ground to pay tribute to Yudhishtira. When it comes time to make guest-offerings, Yudhishtira asks Bhishma who should receive the first offering. Almost everyone agrees that Krishna deserves this honor, except for the king of Cedi, who is called Śisupala. Śisupala accuses Yudhishtira of being biased toward Krishna. He leaves the sacrificial grounds, but Yudhishtira follows him. Yudhishtira accuses Śisupala of having ignored dharma with his insults to Krishna. Bhishma also speaks on Krishna's behalf. Śisupala gets angry and prepares to disrupt the sacrifice.

THE KILLING OF ŚISUPALA. Śisupala continues to cause trouble for Yudhishtira. Bhishma tells Bhima Śisupala's backstory: Śisupala is born with three eyes and four arms, but a voice tells his parents that these extra features will vanish when he sits in the lap of the person who is going to kill him. He sits on many kings' laps, until finally his extra eye and arms disappear when he sits on Krishna's lap. His parents beg Krishna for a boon, hoping Krishna will forgive their son's sins, and he agrees.

Later, at the sacrificial ceremony, Śisupala challenges Krishna to a fight. Krishna gives a speech about how Śisupala is evil and has a deathwish. As Śisupala replies, Krishna decapitates him with a discus. Immediately, it begins to rain. Yudhishtira holds observances for Śisupala, then anoints Śisupala's son as the new king of Cedi. Eventually, the sacrificial ceremony concludes, and everyone disperses. Before leaving, Krishna tells Kunti that her sons have become true rulers.

THE GAMBLING MATCH. Duryodhana and Śakuni linger in Yudhishtira's great hall. Duryodhana sees a crystal floor in the hall and thinks it's water, so he pulls up his clothes to cross it. This leads him to make the opposite mistake later, falling headlong into water and causing everyone around him to laugh. Duryodhana is angry and jealous, and so he begins plotting with Śakuni as he leaves the hall. Śakuni tries to convince him that he has no cause for anger at the Pandavas, but he nevertheless assures Duryodhana that he has many allies of his own, like Drona and Karna.

Śisupala provides a new test to Yudhishtira as he begins to take on his role as a leader. Like many villains of the poem, Śisupala does have a point—Yudhishtira does favor Krishna. Still, what Śisupala fails to realize is that Krishna deserves the honors he receives, and so the real issue is simply that Śisupala is jealous. Because Krishna is such a noble and honorable person, Yudhishtira takes Śisupala's insults toward Krishna very seriously.



Śisupala's origin story provides some explanation for why Śisupala dislikes Krishna so much (because he believes one day Krishna is going to kill him). Krishna is both a blessing and a curse for Śisupala—he removes Śisupala's extra features and offers to forgive his sins, but this comes at the cost of killing him. Accepting death is a major part of the poem, and so perhaps Śisupala's flaw is that he gets angry at Krishna for one day killing him rather than accepting death as inevitable.



Although Krishna often refrains from violence, passages like this show that, when he believes it's right for him to act, Krishna can stop his enemies quickly and decisively. Crucially, despite his disagreements with Śisupala, Yudhishtira still holds observances for his fallen enemy and anoints his son as the new king, showing how a good leader's dharma involves showing respect even for enemies.



The gambling match is an interesting episode in the poem because, while gambling is traditionally about luck and randomness, the match ends up being an agent of fate, causing preordained events to happen. As this passage shows, Duryodhana's fragile ego is his downfall, and this small moment of embarrassment (when he mistakes glass for water) ends up having major consequences that reverberate throughout the rest of the poem.



Śakuni advises Duryodhana that Yudhishtira can't be defeated in battle, so the best option is to try to challenge him in gambling, particularly since Śakuni himself is an expert gambler. Duryodhana approves of this plan but says they need to seek permission from his (Duryodhana's) father, Dhritarashtra. They present their plan to Dhritarashtra who is skeptical at first but slowly becomes convinced. He says he'll make a decision after hearing from his advisor Vidura.

Vidura disapproves of anything involving gambling, believing it causes discord. Nevertheless, Dhritarashtra ignores his advice and gives Duryodhana permission to proceed with the gambling scheme. Against his will, Vidura goes to find Yudhishtira and try to start a gambling competition. Yudhishtira fears there may be cheaters at the gambling match but accepts anyway. He rides off to the dwelling of Dhritarashtra for the competition, taking Draupadi and other companions with him.

Yudhishtira arrives at Dhritarashtra's palace. He meets with Śakuni, who invites him to throw dice with him. Yudhishtira has misgivings about whether gambling is a noble thing to do, but Śakuni argues that gambling is an art that requires intelligence. At last, Yudhishtira says he'll never back down from a challenge and agrees.

Śakuni proceeds to win many of Yudhishtira's valuable possessions from him through using deceit and gambling. Śakuni racks up an enormous amount of wealth before Vidura intervenes to warn Dhritarashtra about Duryodhana's grudge against the Pandavas. He suggests that the king disavow the evil Duryodhana and instead embrace the noble Pandavas. Vidura says that even though it seems like Duryodhana is winning now, he is placing himself in a very dangerous position. Duryodhana, however, defends himself, saying Vidura has always sneered at him. He accuses Vidura of being a meddler. The two argue back and forth.

Meanwhile, Śakuni continues gambling, telling Yudhishtira that he'll keep going if Yudhishtira still has wealth left to lose. Yudhishtira continues to wager everything he has left, using deceit to win. He runs out of things to wager and decides to wager Nakula next, then Sahadeva. Although Yudhishtira believes he's already gone beyond dharma, he keeps going, wagering and losing Arjuna, then Bhima.

Dhritarashtra is one of the most morally complicated figures in the poem—while he doesn't have the same malice as Duryodhana, in some ways he is even more responsible for the Kauravas' growing conflict with the Pandavas, since Dhritarashtra has the power to stop it but chooses not to. Dhritarashtra's decision to consult the wise Vidura shows that he has some good instincts as a leader, but in the very next passage, he betrays these instincts by ignoring Vidura's advice.



Vidura disapproves of Dhritarashtra's order, but he nevertheless feels duty-bound to follow it and go bring Yudhishtira to the gambling match. The poem does not necessarily provide an answer about the morality of such actions—whether it is better to fulfill one's duty even if it means carrying out an unjust order or whether it is better to defy the order. The concept of dharma is flexible enough that morality can depend on the specific situation, and in later parts of the poem, the wise Vidura chooses not to ally himself with Dhritarashtra.



Śakuni tempts Yudhishtira to gamble by using one of Yudhishtira's strengths—his intelligence—against him. Although Yudhishtira is ultimately a righteous leader, in this scene he demonstrates that even he is capable of being overcome by pride in a way that's not so different from Duryodhana.



Vidura's wisdom comes from the fact that he can see the long-term outcome of actions, unlike Śakuni and Duryodhana, who are preoccupied with short-term victories. This passage shows how seeking wisdom and ultimately enlightenment is about seeing the bigger picture. This passage shows how Duryodhana has ample opportunity to change his ways and yet at every turn continues to ignore Vidura's warnings.



Although even heroic figures sometimes use deception in the Mahabharata, Śakuni goes much further, using cheats to take everything Yudhishtira has. The fact that Yudhishtira keeps going without ever challenging Śakuni or accusing him of cheating shows how honorable Yudhishtira is, perhaps even to a fault.



Finally, the only thing Yudhishtira has left to wager is himself. He wagers himself and still loses to Śakuni. Now, Śakuni asks for one last throw: for Draupadi. Yudhishtira loses again, and Duryodhana prepares to enslave Draupadi as a maid. Meanwhile, Vidura warns everyone not to celebrate too much because they don't realize the consequences of their actions. Duryodhana doesn't listen and sends a page to fetch Draupadi.

Yudhishtira's gambling addiction shows that even the lord of dharma can be led into making bad decisions. Still, just as Duryodhana was premature to celebrate his victory in an earlier passage, Yudhishtira's short-term losses here may seem great but end up being not so significant in the long term, where Yudhishtira's righteous leadership helps him prosper.



Draupadi refuses to go with Duryodhana's page, not believing that Yudhishtira really wagered her. Then, Yudhishtira sends a messenger she trusts, and she comes into Duryodhana's hall. Duryodhana drags Draupadi around by the hair and says he'll be her new master. One of Dhritarashtra's other sons, Vikarna, speaks up, asking if everyone really approves of Duryodhana's behavior and how he took advantage of Yudhishtira's gambling vice. He begins to gather support, so Karna speaks up in defense of Duryodhana.

This passage shows how, particularly at this early stage, Duryodhana's grip on his allies was not absolute and many were willing to challenge him about his decisions. Karna's support is crucial because he is a half-brother of the Pandavas and has a similarly noble status, yet he resents them because he never receives the same recognition as them. Although Karna is nobler than Duryodhana, he similarly falls prey to his own vanity.



Karna orders one of his brothers to strip the Pandavas and Draupadi. The Pandavas take off their own garments, but when Karna's brother tries to strip Draupadi, identical new garments keep appearing below her old ones. Many people disapprove of what they see, but because Yudhishtira has such a reputation for dharma, they don't dispute the results of the gambling match. Yudhishtira regretfully says that he, the other Pandavas, and Draupadi must follow the "dharma of slaves."

Yudhishtira's belief in dharma is so strong that he is even willing to accept slavery for himself and his family if it means fulfilling dharma. He is so influential and has built such a reputation for following dharma that his brothers go along with everything, demonstrating how dharma can lay the foundation for trusted leadership.



Dhritarashtra, who has sympathy for the Pandavas, offers Draupadi a boon. She asks to rescue Yudhishtira from slavery. He gives her a second boon, and she asks to also free Nakula, Arjuna, Bhima, and Sahadeva. Finally, Dhritarashtra says Draupadi is so worthy that she deserves a third boon, but she refuses, saying she believes greed is against dharma.

Although Dhritarashtra's approval of Duryodhana's actions led to the enslavement of the Pandavas in the first place, here he changes his mind and recognizes the virtues of Draupadi and the Pandavas. Rather than representing pride, like many of the Kauravas, Dhritarashtra instead represents the dangers of focusing too much on the moment and being swayed by others.



Bhima is angry about being saved by a woman and wants to fight with Duryodhana's people. But Yudhishtira advises moderation. Dhritarashtra praises Yudhishtira's peaceful attitude and tells him this whole gambling competition was a test and that he is free to leave and go back to ruling his kingdom. Yudhishtira and the other Pandavas depart with Draupadi.

Although the poem generally favors Yudhishtira and his moderate attitude, it does not necessarily portray Bhima's rash temper in a bad light. Instead, the events of the poem seem to suggest that Bhima and Yudhishtira each have a different dharma, and that each (mostly) succeeds in achieving his individual duty.



THE SECOND GAMBLING MATCH. Disappointed at Dhritarashtra's decision to let Yudhishtira go, Duryodhana devises more plots against the Pandavas, hoping to use their own pride against them. He tells Dhritarashtra that the Pandavas are surely angry after the previous gambling match, and this makes them dangerous. As a solution, he proposes a new gambling competition, where if the Pandavas lose, they have to go into exile in the forest for 12 years. Dhritarashtra approves of this idea and says they should call the Pandavas back, even if they're already halfway home.

Gandhari warns her husband Dhritarashtra about a prophecy that a chamberlain (officer of a royal household) gave them when Duryodhana was born: that it would be better to kill him immediately rather than let him grow up. But Dhritarashtra is determined to let his sons do as they please, even if it means the end of the Kuru line.

Yudhishtira hears the new challenge and can't reject it, so he and his brothers head back to Dhritarashtra's hall, even though Yudhishtira fears the worst. At the hall, Śakuni explains the new competition and how it involves risking 12 years of exile in the forest and a 13th year in disguise in a more populated place. Yudhishtira throws dice with Śakuni and once again loses.

One of Dhritarashtra's other sons insults the Pandavas after their loss and gloats about their impending exile. Bhima in particular takes offense. All five of the brothers vow to eventually defeat Dhritarashtra's many sons. Dhritarashtra himself laments the outcome, believing that in 14 years, the Pandavas will come back to destroy him and the other Kauravas.

CHAPTER 3. THE FOREST

THE FOREST. Vaiśampayana continues his story of the Pandavas, who head into the forest to begin their exile. Vidura continues to advise Dhritarashtra to end the exile of the Pandavas, so Dhritarashtra eventually dismisses him, and Vidura goes off to join the five brothers. But he soon regrets his actions and invites Vidura back, and so Vidura returns.

The passage gives one of the most prominent examples of Dhritarashtra's weak-willed nature. After finally coming to the right decision about the Pandavas, Dhritarashtra changes his mind almost immediately after the next time he talks to Duryodhana. By allowing a new gambling competition, Dhritarashtra shows that he learned nothing from the previous competition, even though he saw with his own eyes how wrong it was to have the Pandavas in slavery.



Dhritarashtra refuses to do what's necessary, unable to face the death of his son Duryodhana. By trying to avoid death, Dhritarashtra ironically sets in motion a series of events that will lead to many, many more deaths, showing the consequences of trying to hide from fate.



The 12 years of exile that Śakuni wagers are similar to the 12 years that Arjuna spent in the forest. Although it perhaps isn't prudent for Yudhishtira to accept the new challenge, his willingness to come back proves both his bravery and his ability to think in the long term, believing that it's worth keeping his honor even if it means trading away 13 years of his life.



Dhritarashtra may grieve the outcome of upsetting the Pandavas, but the poem has already made it clear that Dhritarashtra had many opportunities to stop this outcome. He straddles the line between tragic hero and villain, constantly making the wrong choice and regretting it soon afterwards.



Once again, Dhritarashtra makes a decision and then immediately regrets it. At this early stage, he is still able to reverse many of his decisions, but as the poem goes on, this will stop being the case, showing the dangers of prioritizing short-term emotional considerations over dharma.



THE KILLING OF KIRMIRA. Dhritarashtra hears a story about how Bhima killed a Rakshasa called Kirmira. He asks Vidura to tell him the story. Kirmira wanted to kill Bhima for killing his brother Baka, but Bhima defeated him and killed him in a wrestling match.

THE MAN OF THE MOUNTAINS. The Pandavas' allies, including Krishna, come to visit them in the forest. **THE KILLING OF THE LORD SAUBHA.** Krishna has been away for a while. When Yudhishtira asks why, Krishna explains he had to go destroy the city of Saubha. The city was ruled by a demonic lord, but after a long battle, Krishna managed to defeat him.

The Pandavas keep traveling. Draupadi scolds Yudhishtira for letting the Pandavas fall into such a miserable state while the Kauravas are back celebrating. Bhima joins Draupadi's side in the argument, but Yudhishtira keeps insisting that it's best to be patient and avoid anger.

One day, Arjuna travels to the summit of Himalaya, where he performs ascetic rituals and meets Śiva. Śiva stakes the form of a mountain man and starts a bow-and-arrow battle with Arjuna. After a tough battle, Śiva wins, but he praises Arjuna's efforts and offers him a **celestial weapon**: the Paśupata. Śiva warns Arjuna that if he's irresponsible with the weapon, he could destroy the entire world.

THE JOURNEY TO INDRA'S WORLD. One day, Indra's charioteer comes to Arjuna and takes him to Indra's city. Indra gifts Arjuna a thunderbolt, and Arjuna stays in his city for five years. Meanwhile, the other Pandavas live peacefully in the forest, while Dhritarashtra hears of Arjuna's trip to Indra and fears he's becoming invincible. Yudhishtira feels that he's the unluckiest man in the world, but a seer begins to tell him of a man who was even more unlucky.

Bhima continues to establish his violent personality. What is dharma for Bhima would not necessarily be dharma for the more reserved Yudhishtira, and so Bhima's dharma takes into consideration how he balances out the personalities of his brothers.



Krishna is both one of the most important figures in the entire narrative, but he's also a supporting character, going off on his own adventures and destroying whole cities while the Pandavas are occupied with their own matters. This reflects how Krishna is the incarnation of the god and how the gods have their own motivations that don't always make sense to mortals.



Draupadi's dharma involves maintaining dignity at all times, and this is what causes her conflict with Yudhishtira during the Pandavas' lowly time in exile. Unlike Duryodhana, who commits an error by failing to recognize Yudhishtira's judgment, Draupadi provides a necessary counterbalance, particularly since in the end she still listens to her husband.



Śiva entrusts Arjuna with a weapon powerful enough to destroy the entire world, showing how much faith he has in Arjuna's judgment. Perhaps more than any other figure in the poem, Arjuna shows the connection between religion and warfare, demonstrating how faith both physically and spiritually makes him powerful.



Indra is Arjuna's biological father, which is part of why he and the other gods show such favor to Arjuna. Arjuna's separation from his brothers demonstrates how the search for enlightenment sometimes requires leaving the familiar behind. The seer at the end of this passage provides another example of how stories have the power both to comfort and to instruct.



NALA. The seer begins his story to Yudhishtira. Nala is a distinguished king. He wants to marry a young woman named Damayanti, but Damayanti's father instead holds a *svayamvara* ceremony to choose Damayanti's husband. At the *svayamvara*, Nala manages to win over Damayanti. This angers the god Kali, who possesses Nala and forces him to lose in gambling against his brother. Ruined, Nala decides to leave Damayanti in the night. When Damayanti wakes up to find Nala gone, she wanders around, trying to find him again.

Nala travels widely until finally one day he manages to get Kali out of him. From afar, Damayanti hears news that Nala is finally free. Nala comes back and challenges his brother to another gambling match, but this time he wins on the first throw. He forgives his brother and returns to living happily with Damayanti. After finishing the story, the seer tells Yudhishtira that just hearing about Nala gives the listener good luck.

THE PILGRIMAGE. Narada comes to the Pandavas in the forest and tells Yudhishtira of the benefits of going on a pilgrimage. Yudhishtira also hears about Arjuna's recent acquisition of a **celestial weapon**.

AGASTYA. Beginning their pilgrimage, the Pandavas travel to the hermitage of Agastya. There, they hear a story about how Agastya killed a demon. The story includes the origin of demons and how, in an earlier age, they were once powerful enough to harass even the gods. The gods asked Agastya for help, and so he drank the ocean dry so that the gods could kill the demons that were hiding there. After hearing this story, Yudhishtira and the others travel onward, arriving at a new holy site near a river.

RIŚYASRINGA. Near the river, Yudhishtira hears the story of Riśyasringa, a great ascetic and the son of an apsara cursed to take the form of a doe. In doe form, she got pregnant after drinking from a river where a (human) man ejaculated. As a result, Riśyasringa has a single deer horn on his head. Meanwhile, a kingdom suffers from lack of rain, so its king decides that perhaps he can make it rain by luring Riśyasringa to his kingdom. He sends women to try to tempt Riśyasringa. One woman in particular succeeds in driving Riśyasringa mad.

The seer tells this story to Yudhishtira because it clearly has parallels to Yudhishtira's own misfortune, particularly when it comes to the lost gambling match. Notably, Kali forces Nala to lose at dice by possessing him, suggesting that the gambling was never truly random but an event with a predetermined outcome. This could be the seer's way of suggesting to Yudhishtira that he should accept his own fate as a predetermined outcome.



Although the seer told Yudhishtira initially that he would tell a story about a man with worse luck than him, Nala ends up having good luck. This suggests that it would be wise for Yudhishtira to look at the long-term and to see how his own recent gambling loss might nevertheless lead to a happy outcome.



Much of the Pandavas' exile takes the form of a journey—a sort of pilgrimage—and this coincides with the fact that it is a time of self-discovery for them.



Over the course of their pilgrimage, the Pandavas hear many self-contained stories at the various places they stop. In John D. Smith's translation, these stories are often summarized only briefly because they are tangential to the main plot, but they nevertheless help the Mahabharata achieve its goal of being an encyclopedic text and often represent moments of character growth for the Pandavas.



Riśyasringa provides a strange example of how humanity and nature can intersect, as he has a human body and a deer horn on his head. Riśyasringa's story is yet another one that focuses on the concept of sexual purity. A king tries to manipulate Riśyasringa with sex, showing that, for an ascetic like Riśyasringa, sex can be a distraction that leads away from dharma.



Riśyasringa tells his father about the beautiful woman he saw. His father explains that the woman was probably a Rakshasa. But Riśyasringa doesn't heed his father, and when the woman returns, she tricks him onto a boat. She takes him back to her king's kingdom, and it finally starts to rain. In exchange, the king offers one of his daughters to Riśyasringa in marriage, and she serves him faithfully. With the story concluded, Yudhishtira and the other Pandavas travel on to an altar in a forest.

The story of Riśyasringa shows how even great sages can face temptation—this perhaps parallels how Yudhishtira himself gave in to his gambling addiction. Once again, however, Riśyasringa's story has a happy ending, suggesting that Yudhishtira's current troubles may nevertheless have a way of working out in the end.



KARTAVIRYA. Yudhishtira learns that Rama Jamadagnya is coming by soon. He hears a story about how Rama Jamadagnya accidentally decapitated his mother but how a boon from his father allowed him to revive her. Later, King Kartavirya attacked Rama Jamadagnya's hermitage, wiping it out, and this led Rama Jamadagnya to declare war on all Kshatriya, leading him to wipe out their whole population on 21 separate occasions. After hearing this story, Yudhishtira and the Pandavas travel to a new holy location to continue their pilgrimage.

Rama Jamadagnya's annihilation of the Kshatriya on 21 different occasions may seem excessive, but this story presents it as justified revenge and a necessary way to bring balance back to the universe. The poem has a complicated relationship with violence, praising nonviolence for some people but also portraying heroic figures who commit seemingly unimaginable acts of violence. Once again, this shows how dharma differs for different individuals.



SUKANYA. Yudhishtira hears a new story about a man from the Bhrigu line named Cyavana who leads such an ascetic lifestyle that he turns into an anthill. One day, he sees a beautiful woman named Sukanya, but she sees only eyes in an anthill, so she pokes him with a thorn. The ascetic responds by causing trouble for the king, and so the king decrees Sukanya must marry Cyavana. Cyavana regains human form and also his youth, becoming so powerful that he keeps even Indra at bay with a demon called Intoxication. After besting Indra, Cyavana splits Intoxication up into several parts: "liquor, women, dicing, and hunting."

This story is yet another digression that relates back to Yudhishtira's current situation, since Yudhishtira's gambling addiction seems to be a part of the "Intoxication" that Cyavana releases into the world. Cyavana's Intoxication is one of the few things that can compete with even the powerful god Indra, showing how powerful these temptations are and how they can control human lives.



MANDHATR. Yudhishtira hears the story of Mandhatri, a child who stays in the womb for 100 years and then suckles from Indra's pointer finger. JANTU. Yudhishtira hears the story of a man who has 100 wives but just one son, who is named Jantu. The man sacrifices Jantu, and suddenly all his wives become pregnant at the same time.

Fertility and heirs continue to be a major theme in the poem. The story of Jantu involves yet another occurrence in the story of 100 sons—and the fact that this motif resurfaces perhaps gestures toward the Hindu concept of reincarnation, as the Mahabharata itself uses recurring elements.



THE HAWK AND THE DOVE. Yudhishtira hears the story of a man who has to cut off part of his own flesh equal to the weight of a dove. He keeps cutting, but it is never enough, so at last he puts his whole body on the scale, finally pleasing Indra. ASHTAVAKRA. Yudhishtira hears the story of Ashtavakra, a clever man who excels at riddles.

The story of the man and the dove shows the lengths that humans should be willing to go to in order to please the gods. By putting his whole body on the scale, the man indicates a willingness to sacrifice even his own life for Indra.



YAVAKRITA. Yudhishtira arrives at the hermitage where Yavakrita died and hears his story. Yavakrita is too proud and gets chased by a Rakshasa. He tries to hide in water, but everything is dry, and so he is caught and killed. After hearing the end of that story, the Pandavas continue their journey, traveling through dangerous, stormy lands where supernatural creatures live. Draupadi begins to tire from so much traveling. Bhima goes to fetch her flowers to cheer her up, but he finds the flowers guarded by Rakshasas.

THE KILLING OF JATASURA. While Bhima is away, a Rakshasa named Jatasura kidnaps the Pandavas one day. Bhima finally makes it back and kills Jatasura, freeing his brothers.

THE BATTLE AGAINST THE YAKSHAS. The Pandavas return to a hermitage they've been to before and settle down there. In the fifth year of Arjuna's absence while they're staying at the hermitage, Bhima provokes a war with the Yakshas (a type of celestial being), but when their leader sees how well the Pandavas fight, he gives up the battle and congratulates them. Arjuna finally returns, and he tells his story. In Arjuna's retelling, Indra gives Arjuna a task—to kill many demons with his new weapons. Arjuna succeeds in wiping out a whole army of demons, pleasing Indra. Indra then gives Arjuna invincible armor and a conch, allowing him to stay in his city for five years.

THE CONSTRICTOR. With all the Pandavas back together, they spend four more years in the forest, making it a total of 10 years in exile. At one point, Bhima gets captured by a **snake**, but Yudhishtira saves him by asking the snake questions about the nature of consciousness, which the snake answers correctly, freeing itself from a curse and letting Bhima go.

THE MEETING WITH MARKANDEYA. The Pandavas travel through the rainy season, and Yudhishtira meets an ascetic named Markandeya. Yudhishtira asks about what happens after death, and Markandeya explains reincarnation. He tells other parables to Yudhishtira to show the power of asceticism.

THE FISH. Markandeya then tells Yudhishtira the story of an ascetic named Manu who suddenly hears a little fish talking to him. The fish asks to be put into increasingly large bodies of water. Finally, the fish reveals that it is Brahma, and he gives Manu instructions for how to create all creatures. Having finished this story, Markandeya explains the different ages and the creation and destruction of worlds.

Yavakrita's story shows the danger of pride—he literally gets chased by demons, but the message is that perhaps pride can also cause a person's figurative demons to get the better of them. The Pandavas continue to move across the land, and their progress symbolizes how each story they hear helps bring them a step closer to enlightenment by teaching them a new message.



Bhima once again acts violently, suggesting that violence—at least in the world of the Mahabharata—is sometimes necessary, particularly against demons like Jatasura.



The battle against the Yakshas is a sort of coronation moment for the Pandavas, as they prove that they've reached the point where their skills in battle go beyond those of a regular mortal. The poem has already related Arjuna's time with Indra in brief, but this section recounts those events, allowing Arjuna to tell everything to his brothers in his own words. The Mahabharata's status as a holy text helps explain why it includes so many details, since figures like Arjuna are so important that almost everything they do takes on significance.



This passage provides an example of an episode where Bhima's violence fails, and so instead Yudhishtira has to use his reasoning to save the day. This passage also gives yet another example of a morally ambiguous snake, which seems evil at first but is only acting aggressively due to a curse.



While some stories in the poem have indirect religious implications, others, like this one, address the issue more directly. This helps the Mahabharata fulfill its didactic purpose of teaching people how to better reach enlightenment.



Animals that turn out to be more than they first seem is a common theme in the poem. This suggests that people should treat all animals with respect because they can never know if an animal is something more. Water is necessary for life, and so it makes sense that the creator god Brahma would appear in the form of a fish.



THE FROG. Markandeya tells Yudhishtira another story, this one about a king who meets and takes home a beautiful young woman. One day, she disappears into a pool of water. The king drains the pool and finds only a frog. He threatens to kill all frogs, but the frog king comes and reveals that the frog in the water is actually his lover. The king takes her back, and she resumes human form, but the frog king warns them that all her children will be hostile to Brahmins.

The woman who gets turned into a frog is a natural follow-up to the previous story about Brahma disguising himself as a fish. Frog princes and princesses are a common theme in folk tales around the world, and this is one of the earliest recorded versions of that type of tale. The king's threat to kill all frogs shows a violent attitude toward nature and is perhaps why his children are cursed to be hostile toward Brahmins.



INDRADYUMNA. Markandeya tells of Indradyumna, an old man who falls from heaven after his fame runs out but who is able to go back to heaven after an old turtle on earth recognizes him.

This short tale demonstrates that it isn't enough to do one good deed—being virtuous involves constantly taking action.



DHUNDHUMARA. Markandeya tells Yudhishtira the story of Dhundhumara ("killer of Dhundu"), a king who finds a trick to kill a demon named Dhundu that seemed to be invulnerable to even the gods. **THE FAITHFUL WIFE.** Yudhishtira and Markandeya discuss how women can achieve dharma by being faithful wives.

Makandeya's story about killing a demon with trickery foreshadows techniques the Pandavas will use in the Kurukshetra War. Meanwhile, the passage about dharma shows how a woman's devotion to her family becomes a religious issue connected to her dharma.



THE BRAHMIN'S CONVERSATION WITH THE HUNTER.

Markandeya tells the story of Kauśika, a Brahmin who meets a hunter who used to be a Brahmin in his previous life but who accidentally shot an ascetic with an arrow and so was cursed to be reborn as a hunter. The ascetic showed mercy and allowed the hunter to at least be a virtuous hunter.

This passage provides a demonstration of how reincarnation works and how mistakes in one life—even accidents—can lead to penalties in the next. Kauśika's punishment has a poetic justice to it: because he made a bad shot in one life, he has to spend his next life constantly taking shots in order to improve.



ANGIRAS. Yudhishtira asks Markandeya to tell him about the origin of fire, which involves the sage Angiras and the fire god Agni. During a time when Agni is absent, Angiras takes on his role, and from then on, all future fires descend from Angiras.

Fire is so important to human civilization that most religions have their own origin story for it. In this version, fire is associated with a great sage, showing how the power of fire must be used with wisdom.



DRAUPADI'S CONVERSATIONS WITH SATYABHAMA. Draupadi gives advice to Krishna's chief queen, Satyabhama, saying she should please her husband not with potions or tricks but with faithful attention.

As a wife to five husbands, Draupadi has a lot of experience in marriage and, thus, a lot of advice to give. This passage again points to a gender divide, since deception and tricks can be praiseworthy when men do them on the battlefield, but deceptive women rarely get positive depictions.



THE TOUR OF THE CATTLE-STATIONS. Duryodhana contemplates what to do while his enemies, the Pandavas, are still away. He decides to throw a party, then goes out to inspect his cattle as an excuse to get away from Dhritarashtra. But while he's out, he gets attacked by a rival army. The Pandavas, led by Yudhishtira, have to come save him. Duryodhana goes home more determined than ever to kill the Pandavas.

While Duryodhana's jealousy of the Pandavas stretches back a long time, one of the biggest turning points is when he embarrasses himself in Yudhishtira's hall by mistaking glass for water. This passage describes yet another instance of Duryodhana looking foolish in front of the Pandavas (at least in his mind), and so of course it increases his motivation to kill them.



THE DREAM DEER. Yudhishtira has a mysterious dream about a crying deer. **THE BUSHEL OF RICE.** Vyasa visits the Pandavas and sees them suffering, so he encourages them not to lose hope by telling a story of a man who lived off nothing but scavenged grains of rice.

Not all of the stories in the poem have clear moral lessons. While it might be possible to draw lessons from the dream of the crying deer or the story of the man who scavenged rice, part of the reason for these stories is that they force the audience to contemplate unusual imagery, perhaps leading them to see the world from a different perspective.



THE ABDUCTION OF DRAUPADI. One day, King Jayadratha passes by the Pandava camp, becomes infatuated with Draupadi, and tries to convince her to join him. Jayadratha tries to abduct her, but the Pandavas chase him down, kill his followers, and shave his head, leaving behind just five tufts of hair. They let Jayadratha go. He prays to Śiva to be able to defeat the Pandavas, but Śiva says this wish is impossible to grant.

As with Duryodhana and Karna, Jayadratha is someone who holds on to grudges for a long time, and he will play a more important role later in the story. His conversation with Śiva is shocking—even the great destroyer god can't take down the Pandavas, although perhaps the issue isn't that Śiva lacks power but simply that exercising this power against the Pandavas would go against fate.



RAMA. Yudhishtira asks Markandeya if anyone else ever suffered such bad luck as him. Markandeya replies that Rama did. Rama is married to Sita. Rama is a brave warrior, but he suffers many setbacks, including the abduction of his wife, Sita, by the demon-king Ravana. After struggling heroically, including a battle where his only allies are monkeys, he finally defeats Ravana and brings Sita back.

The Rama in this passage isn't Rama Jamadagnya who killed the Kshatriyas 21 times, but he may still be familiar to many reading the Mahabharata because he is the protagonist of the Ramayana, the other major Sanskrit epic poem of Hinduism. By including this brief mention of Rama (whose own epic poem is much longer than this brief summary), the Mahabharata connects to earlier texts and helps provide the foundation for a unified religious tradition.



SAVITRI. Yudhishtira asks Markandeya if there's ever been a woman as noble as Draupadi. He replies that yes, there was a goddess named Savitri. A king showed great loyalty to her, so she rewarded him with a boon. He asks for offspring with the highest dharma. She agrees, and when the king gives birth to a daughter, his priests name the daughter Savitri.

Because only men can inherit property, most boons in the story that provide children give people sons who then serve as potential heirs. The fact that Savitri originates from a boon suggests that she must be an exceptional woman indeed.



Eventually, Savitri (the daughter) is old enough for a husband. The king thinks he finds a suitable match, a prince named Satyavat, but the seer Narada advises him against it—because her potential future husband will die within a year. Savitri remains committed to her choice. The wedding plans go ahead. Savitri marries Satyavat and lives happily with her husband in a hermitage but can't forget the prophecy of Narada.

The day before Satyavat's predicted death, Savitri decides to fast until evening and doesn't leave her husband's side. She follows him out into the woods while he splits logs, until all of a sudden, the god of death—Yama—comes and ends Satyavat's life. Savitri tries to follow him, but Yama urges her to stay away and remain among the living.

Moved by Savitri's words, Yama offers her several boons, with the stipulation that she can't ask for the resurrection of Satyavat. She asks for help for her father-in-law and father to expand where they rule and to help them act according to dharma. Yama keeps offering boons, so she asks for a hundred heroic sons. Finally, on his fifth boon, Yama doesn't add the stipulation about resurrecting Satyavat. Savitri asks for Satyavat to be revived. Yama brings him back and promises he'll live with Savitri for 400 years.

Satyavat awakens with a headache—Savitri promises to explain everything to him later. It's getting late, and Satyavat wants to go back to see his parents. He goes back to the hermitage, and all the Brahmins are shocked to see him still alive. When Savitri gets back, she explains to everyone how she revived Satyavat with one of Yama's boons. Savitri and Satyavat live together happily and eventually have their 100 sons, all because of what Savitri did—and Markandeya says that Draupadi is like Savitri.

THE TAKING OF THE EARRINGS. Janamejaya asks to hear more about Karna, so Vaiśampayana tells more about him. It's been 13 years of exile for the Pandavas. Indra wants to get Karna's earrings (which protect him) on behalf of the Pandavas. The Sun, however, disguises himself as a handsome Brahmin and goes to Karna to warn him that Indra is coming for his earrings and that if he gives away the earrings, he'll die.

Earlier passages state that a woman's dharma involves being loyal to her husband, and here, Savitri demonstrates the highest level of loyalty by marrying a man even though she knows he'll soon die. Savitri is such a noble woman in the poem because her dharma requires a difficult sacrifice, and she accepts it gladly.



Just as Savitri makes a sacrifice by marrying a man doomed to die, she increases her sacrifice by fasting and increasing her diligence. The fact that Yama, the god of death, makes a personal appearance emphasizes the fact that Satyavat's death is fated. Savitri walks a careful line, staying faithful to her husband and advocating for him without disrespecting Yama's authority.



In this passage, Savitri proves that her most important virtue is her faithfulness, which allows her to remain persistent throughout her conversation with Yama, never asking him for a boon that's too great until finally Yama relents and offers to revive her husband. Her story shows how, while it's impossible to stop fate, sometimes prophecies get fulfilled in unusual ways, showing again how the logic of the gods doesn't always make sense to mortals.



This story provides yet another example of the boon of 100 sons. Although Markandeya begins the story of Savitri by saying that she is even more devoted than Draupadi, he concludes it by saying that Draupadi and Savitri are very similar. The courage that Savitri faces during extreme hardships—such as the literal death of her husband—show the depths of her devotion and, by extension, her commitment to living out her dharma.



The Hindu gods do not always get along with each other, and in this case, the Sun and Indra clash over the fate of Karna. The fact that each of the gods has different goals connects back to the larger issue of dharma and how it varies for each individual.



Karna tells the Sun that he will hand over his earrings and armor to Indra anyway—because it will bring him fame, and fame is more important to him than life itself. The Sun pleads with Karna, saying he'll never beat Arjuna in battle without his earrings. Karna remains stubborn, so the Sun says that if he's going to hand over the earrings, he should at least try to get a **celestial weapon**: a special Spear that will kill all his enemies.

This passage has an ambiguous outcome for Karna. On the one hand, Karna makes himself vulnerable by giving away his special armor and earrings. While it is possible to view Karna's decision as arrogant or impulsive, Karna recognizes that fame can last longer than any mortal life, and his willingness to face his own death is a trait he shares with many of the poem's most noble figures.



Indra takes the form of a Brahmin and approaches Karna. He asks for Karna's earrings and armor, but Karna refuses, telling Indra he knows his identity and has heard all about him from the Sun. Indra seems to have expected this, and he says he'll give Karna a boon in exchange for the earrings. He offers Karna a **celestial weapon**: a Spear that can kill hundreds of enemies and then return to his hand in a single throw. Karna only wants to kill one hero (Arjuna), but he accepts the Spear.

Karna's decision to take a spear to kill Arjuna hints at how everyone is preparing for an upcoming war, even though the Pandavas are still away in exile. Karna accepts fate—that Duryodhana's insults have caused a permanent rift with the Pandavas—making him one of the most righteous of the Kauravas, but his jealousy toward the Pandavas continues to cloud his judgment.



Indra warns Karna that he must only use his Spear in times of need, or else it will attack Karna himself. Karna cuts off his armor and earrings, and this is where he earns his title of "Karna the Cutter." News of Karna's loss of his earring brings joy to the Pandavas but sadness to the Kauravas.

Indra repeats a common theme in the poem: that the mortals chosen to wield powerful celestial weapons must use them responsibly or else suffer the consequences. The other Kauravas are sad because they don't have the same sense of perspective as Karna.



THE FIRESTICKS. A Brahmin whose firesticks have been stolen by a deer, tangled in its antlers, comes up to Yudhishtira. All the Pandavas try to find the deer with no luck. Yudhishtira then sends Nakula out to look for water. Nakula finds a pool, but a voice warns him to answer some questions before drinking. Nakula just drinks right away, and he falls down dead. One by one, the other Pandavas do the same, until only Yudhishtira is left alive.

Many of the stories in the Mahabharata deal with the theme of temptation and how it's important to resist it, and yet even the strongest and bravest people sometimes succumb to it. This strange scene where the brothers—except Yudhishtira—drop one by one has strong parallels to a similar scene in the second-to-last book of the poem.



When Yudhishtira gets to the pond, he agrees to listen to the voice and answer questions. The speaker ends up being a Yaksha (type of nature spirit). The Yaksha revives the other four Pandavas and then reveals that it is Dharma, Yudhishtira's biological father. Dharma gives Yudhishtira three boons: he gets the firesticks back for the Brahmin, the Pandavas will remain unrecognizable in their 13th year of exile, and finally Yudhishtira wishes for a more virtuous character for himself.

The fate of the Pandavas—who come back to life shortly after dying—recalls the story about Savitri and her husband who was fated to die but got revived. By surviving this temporary death, the Yudhishtira's gain boons that allow them to keep moving forward, and this theme of improving through suffering is a microcosm for the events of the Pandavas' exile as a whole.



CHAPTER 4. VIRATA

VIRATA. Janamejaya asks Vaiśampayana how his ancestors managed to live unrecognized in the city of Virata for so long. Vaiśampayana answers. After receiving their boons from Dharma, the Pandavas debate where to spend their 13th year of exile. Yudhishtira proposes the city where King Virata rules. There, he plans to disguise himself as a Brahmin who's skilled at gambling and become a courtier of the king. Bhima plans to be a cook (because he's good at kitchen work), Arjuna plans to be a eunuch (because he can tell stories and dance like a woman), Nakula plans to be a **horse** master (because he's skilled at training them), and Sahadeva plans to be a cattle overseer (because he enjoys herding).

Draupadi says she'll join them, pretending to be a maidservant skilled in hairdressing who attends to the queen: Sudeshna. The Pandavas all head out toward Virata's city. As it gets late, Draupadi wants to rest, but Arjuna carries her the rest of the way. Before entering the city, they stow away their weapons in a tree, so as not to appear suspicious. They enter the city.

Yudhishtira approaches Virata first. Virata can't believe at first that the man he sees is a Brahmin, believing that the figure before him seems too splendid. Yudhishtira introduces himself as a friend of Yudhishtira and tells his story about being a gifted Brahmin gambler. Virata is pleased to welcome him into his court.

Similarly, no one believes that the beautiful Draupadi is really a maid—they wonder if perhaps she's even a goddess—but Sudeshna sees no one around to protect the lovely Draupadi, and so she welcomes her into the royal household. Sudeshna warns Draupadi that men will be after her for her beauty, but Draupadi says she already has five husbands who are all Gandharvas (a type of celestial musician).

The other Pandavas each introduce themselves to Virata and give their new fake identities. Each time, Virata suspects that the stranger he sees is of higher status than he lets on. But he nevertheless gladly accepts all of the Pandavas into his court.

Each of the Pandavas picks a new identity that exemplifies some aspect of their personality. The Pandava disguises aren't perfect—in fact, a running theme of this book is that the Pandavas nearly get caught because they are so glorious that it's hard for them to pose as mere mortals (although they do have help from the boon they received at the end of the previous book). While the various books of the Mahabharata all connect in order to tell one continuous story, each also has its own focus, and the opening section of this book helps set up a new premise of the Pandavas in their 13th year of exile.



This passage where the Pandavas put aside their weapons symbolizes how they will have to spend the upcoming year relying on deception and their wits rather than their strength. And so, like their pilgrimage in the woods, this year in the city also helps prepare the brothers for the challenges they have ahead.



Yudhishtira's choice to disguise himself as a skilled gambler is perhaps humorous, given that his poor gambling decisions are part of why the brothers ended up in exile in the first place. Virata establishes himself as a virtuous person early by recognizing the value of the Pandavas without even knowing their identity.



As this passage shows, the people in Virata's city protect the Pandavas not because they fit their disguises convincingly but because people seem to naturally have sympathy for them. Sudeshna's concern for Draupadi around men in the city foreshadows potential conflict, since she will be separated from her five husbands, who don't have their weapons on them.



Virata proves that he is a good leader due to the hospitality he provides to his guests, mirroring what Yudhishtira himself did in his hall in the second book. This passage shows why it's important to offer hospitality to all guests—because you never know who the guests might really be.



For a long time, the Pandavas simply go about daily life and try to both win favor with Virata and stay incognito. Yudhishtira shares his gambling winnings with his brothers to help them all survive, and each other brother makes his own contribution to the group based on his new role.

After four months, there's a great festival for Brahma in the city, with one of the main events being a wrestling competition. Bhima shocks the crowd by taking on a champion wrestler and spinning him in the air 100 times until he passes out. Virata watches everything and is pleased.

THE KILLING OF KICAKA. Now, 10 months have passed, and Draupadi suffers the most because she isn't suited to be a servant. A general of Virata's named Kicaka lusts after Draupadi and asks Sudeshna about her. Kicaka then sends Sudeshna away and approaches Draupadi herself, saying that her beauty is wasted in her current role as a maid. Draupadi, however, says it isn't dharma for him to love a lowly woman like her, plus she already has her Ghandarva husbands.

Kicaka can't let go of his lust for Draupadi, so he speaks to Sudeshna again, begging her to arrange things so he can "lie with" Draupadi. Sudeshna takes pity on him and arranges an opportunity for him to see Draupadi by sending her to his house to pick up some liquor. Draupadi initially refuses Sudeshna's request to get the liquor, fearing what Kicaka might do to her, but Sudeshna reassures her that Kicaka won't hurt her if Sudeshna has sent her.

Kicaka welcomes Draupadi when he sees her approach his dwelling. He says he has a bed ready and grabs her, but she fights back and tries to flee. He then grabs her by the hair, throws her down, and kicks her. Bhima and Yudhishtira also witness the kicking, but they fear that if they attack Kicaka, they'll reveal their true identities.

Draupadi gives a speech to Virata, repeating many times how "the son of a Suta has kicked me" (Kicaka). She tells Virata it isn't dharma of him to condone Kicaka's behavior, but Virata doesn't want to get involved because he doesn't know the whole story of her dispute with Kicaka. Disappointed, Draupadi goes back to Sudeshna and tells her what happened. Sudeshna is more sympathetic, saying she'll kill Kicaka if need be, but Draupadi says she believes someone else will kill Kicaka, perhaps another person he has wronged.

The Pandava brothers cooperate and share their resources, which is similar to the generosity that Yudhishtira showed when he was on the throne. This passage shows that, while generosity is important for kings, it's also important for people of all social classes.



In the wrestling tournament, Bhima's 100 spins recall an earlier story in which he used the same technique to kill a rival king. Despite trying to remain incognito, the Pandavas can't help showing hints of their true identity, perhaps in part due to their commitment to dharma.



Kicaka represents the fulfillment of Sudeshna's early fears for Draupadi's safety. While the poem positively portrays women who submit to the wishes of men, Kicaka's lust is clearly unreasonable, particularly since, if Draupadi gave in to him, she would be cheating on her five husbands. She tries to reject Kicaka's unreasonable requests gracefully, appealing to dharma.



Although Sudeshna wants to look out for Draupadi, her trust in Kicaka to respect her authority as queen suggests a level of naivety. The reference to liquor recalls the earlier story about intoxication, where lust, alcohol, and gambling were all revealed to have a common origin.



This passage portrays a serious test not just for Draupadi but also for Bhima and Yudhishtira, who are conflicted about what is the higher dharma—to keep incognito and remain true to their promise or to help defend their wife from an attacker.



Draupadi's speech hints at the low status that Sutas still hold in some parts of society (even though the narrator of this whole story, Ugrasravas, is a Suta himself.) The usually prudent Virata makes a rare error in doubting Draupadi, perhaps blinded by the fact that she is still in disguise as someone of a lower status. In this passage, Draupadi tries to set things up for one of her husbands to potentially kill Kicaka by spreading rumors that she has heard that people want to kill him.



That night, Draupadi wakes Bhima and tells him to kill Kicaka. She is frustrated with how Yudhishtira has not done enough to protect her from men who want to molest her. Bhima promises to do as she wishes.

Draupadi goes to Bhima for this task because she is fed up with the cautious attitudes of the other brothers and knows that Bhima prefers to take action. Once again, the personalities of Bhima and Yudhishtira balance each other out, with each being more suited to certain situations.



Later, Kicaka approaches Draupadi and begs her for another chance. She says she accepts, but on one condition: that no one else know about it. She makes plans to meet him alone at night at a dancehall, and then she tells Bhima about her plan. That night, Bhima surprises Kicaka in the dancehall, and the two get into a fight. Bhima manages to grab Kicaka like a hungry tiger, then squeezes him to death. Near the entrance to the dancehall, Draupadi starts talking about how her five Ghandarva husbands have slain Kicaka. His body is so mangled that the guards believe her.

Kicaka's lust prevents him from seeing the trap that Draupadi is laying for him. Bhima squeezes Kicaka to death both to show how personally angry he is at Kicaka as well as to deny him an honorable soldier's death by a weapon. Draupadi's lie about having five Ghandarva husbands is so close to the truth that it throws off the guards' suspicion, perhaps illustrating how false stories get some of their power from having elements of truth to them.



Virata hears news of Kicaka's death. Some of Kicaka's surviving relatives blame Draupadi and want her to be burned on his funeral pyre. They seize Draupadi to take her away, and she cries out for help. Bhima runs to her aid so quickly that trees fall around him. Kicaka's relatives mistake Bhima for an avenging Ghandarva and flee, but Bhima still kills 105 of them. People of the city marvel at the corpses, saying it's like a thunderbolt has split a mountaintop.

Bhima continues to demonstrate that he is uncompromising when it comes to protecting the things that he cares about. While the poem clearly presents Bhima's murder of Kicaka as justified or at least understandable, this additional murder of Kicaka's fleeing relatives raises the question of whether Bhima has perhaps let his temper get the better of him.



Virata orders a mass funeral pyre, then tells Sudeshna to dismiss Draupadi, out of fear that he himself might one day have to face her supposed Ghandarva husbands. Draupadi agrees to go but asks to be able to stay for just 13 more days.

Virata himself played a role in allowing the attempted rape of Draupadi (since he didn't trust her accusations against Kicaka enough to intervene), and this is perhaps why he himself fears getting caught up in the whole affair.



THE CATTLE RAID. News of Kicaka's death reaches Duryodhana. Another king believes that the death of the general Kicaka makes Virata vulnerable, and Duryodhana encourages this other king to start a war, which he does by raiding some of Virata's cattle. With the aid of the Pandavas, however, Virata wins the fight and captures the rival king. But while Virata is away trying to recover his livestock, Duryodhana attacks Virata's home city, where his son Uttara is now in charge (Uttara doesn't have a full army while Virata is away).

Duryodhana doesn't seem to know yet that the Pandavas are with Virata, and yet Duryodhana is so much of a bully that he attacks Virata anyway just because he sees weakness. Cattle are an important animal in Hinduism, and Duryodhana's raids on Virata's cattle display a total lack of respect for Virata's kingdom. Virata's ability to defend his cows (with help from the Pandavas) becomes a metaphor for his ability to protect his kingdom at large.



Uttara plans to try to stop the attack by Duryodhana and the other Kurus, but he needs a skilled charioteer. Still disguised as a eunuch, Arjuna agrees to drive his chariot to help Uttara take back the cattle, although Arjuna acts foolishly and pretends he doesn't know how to wear armor in order to keep up his disguise.

Uttara gets nervous as he rides in Arjuna's chariot, and they come to a Kuru army that includes Karna, Duryodhana, Kripa, Bhishma, and Drona. Uttara jumps off the chariot and tries to run away, but since Arjuna believes it would be more dharma to die in battle than to flee, he chases Uttara down. As bystanders watch Arjuna run, they ponder who he really is, and they come close to discovering his true identity. Arjuna catches Uttara and forces him back into the chariot to fight the Kuru.

The Kauravas are afraid as they watch Arjuna (disguised as a eunuch) force Uttara back into the chariot. Arjuna takes Uttara to the tree where he and the other Pandavas stashed their weapons. As Arjuna rides into battle, the sound of his conch and the appearance of his bow hint at his identity. Drona hears the conch and fears bad news. Duryodhana and the other Kauravas, who finally recognize Arjuna, argue about whether the Pandavas have completed their exile or whether this discovery means they have to do another 12 years.

Uttara and Arjuna ride into the Kaurava army and begin attacking. Meanwhile, gods like Indra come to watch the spectacle. Arjuna attacks Drona, who is unable to defeat Arjuna, although Drona's son Aśvatthaman is able to break Arjuna's bow, pleasing the gods. But eventually Arjuna restrings, and Aśvatthaman runs out of arrows.

Arjuna continues to fight the Kauravas, who eventually all attack him together. During one of the most intense moments, Arjuna faces off against Bhishma and manages to hit him with so many arrows that he passes out. Eventually, Arjuna blows his conch and knocks out all of his opponents. He then has Uttara take their clothes. He breaks Duryodhana's crown and collects Virata's herds of cattle to take back.

This passage humorously shows the great warrior Arjuna pretending he doesn't know how to wear armor in order to keep up a disguise. It's unclear how convincing his performance is, but what's more important is that Arjuna has managed to earn the sympathy of people like Uttara, even without being able to use his illustrious name to his advantage.



Arjuna faces a difficult question with his dharma—whether it's more important for him to remain incognito or whether it's more important to defend the innocent. True to his warrior nature, Arjuna chooses to fight, risking death and discovery, although perhaps he still shows more restraint than his brother Bhima might in the same situation.



When Arjuna goes back to reclaim his weapons from the tree, he also reclaims his former identity, suggesting how much of his identity is tied to his status as a warrior. His warrior identity is so strong that his own relatives, the Kauravas, recognize him at first not by his appearance, but by his bow and by the conch that he blows to signal the start of a battle.



This early battle provides just a sampling of the spectacles that will appear later in the poem. Descriptions of battles often catalog the actions of each combatant in great detail, describing, for example, each volley of arrows between two combatants. This high level of detail shows the significance of the battle while also conveying the scale and the ferocity of the fighting.



Many of the actions that warriors take on the battlefield also have symbolic significance that goes well beyond strategic value. Here, for example, Arjuna sends a very clear message when he breaks the crown on Duryodhana's head, showing how he intends to strip him of his leadership power.



THE WEDDING. Meanwhile, Virata has won his own battle. When he gets back, he is dismayed to hear that Uttara set off alone into battle in his chariot with a eunuch, not realizing that this eunuch is in fact the great warrior Arjuna. But his ministers soon reassure him that Uttara is safe. Virata gets angry, however, when Yudhishtira seems to give too much credit for the victory to the charioteer (Arjuna) instead of to Uttara.

Arjuna manages to essentially fight off a whole army by himself, showing the heightened tone of the battles in this poem and how great heroes like Arjuna exist on a plane far above regular soldiers. Virata's anger about his son's contributions to the battle being ignored stems from the fact that he still doesn't know Arjuna's identity. While Virata proved his virtue by offering his generosity to the Pandavas even when he didn't know who they were, he falters here by failing to recognize Arjuna's achievements in battle due to his seemingly low status.



When Uttara himself enters, however, he assures Virata that Yudhishtira is telling the truth and that he owes his victory to his eunuch charioteer (Arjuna). Virata asks to see this hero, but Uttara says he seems to have disappeared for the moment.

Uttara shows humility by not trying to take credit for Arjuna's accomplishments. While it can be dharma to recognize class distinctions, here Uttara does the right thing by ignoring Arjuna's seeming status as a eunuch and instead judging him based on his deeds.



Finally, Arjuna comes back. He and the other Pandavas finally reveal to Virata their true identities, and so does Draupadi. Virata is so overjoyed by this revelation that he makes a treaty and offers his entire kingdom to the Pandavas. Additionally, Virata has a daughter that he'd like to offer to Arjuna as a wife. Arjuna believes it would be more proper for her to marry Arjuna's son, Abhimanyu. Yudhishtira also approves of this marriage. Princes and distinguished guests, including Krishna, come from all over for the wedding.

This book ends with the Pandavas being restored to their old identities, completing this arc of their character development. This passage emphasizes how, in spite of the many difficulties, the Pandavas turned their exile into a moment of triumph, experiencing new situations but always proving their worth, even during this ultimate test when they had to give up their illustrious names and let their virtue speak for itself. Virata's approval of the brothers and the wedding of his daughter to Abhimanyu cement this as a joyous occasion.



CHAPTER 5. PERSEVERANCE

PERSEVERANCE. After the wedding of Abhimanyu, Krishna gives a speech to try to avoid a destructive war between the Pandavas and the Kauravas. Others, like Drupada, however, argue for a more forceful approach to Duryodhana, in order to take back Yudhishtira's kingdom. Krishna advises them to only to resort to this if Duryodhana refuses to make peace.

The battle at the end of the previous book foreshadows growing trouble between the Pandavas and the Kauravas, since it left many issues unresolved. While Krishna is powerful and capable of violence, here he advises Yudhishtira and the others to attempt peace first, suggesting that in spite of the potential glory of warfare, it should only be an option when peace doesn't work.



As both sides make preparations for war, Duryodhana travels with a small force to a city where he hears Krishna is staying. He asks Krishna to help him in the upcoming conflict. As it happens, Arjuna is also around. Krishna refuses to take a side, saying that, while Duryodhana asked him for help first, Krishna saw Arjuna first. Krishna offers a choice to Arjuna (because he's younger): he can either gain 100 million fighters known as Narayanas, or he can gain Krishna himself (although Krishna will not wield weapons or actually fight). Arjuna chooses Krishna himself, leaving the 100 million Narayanas to Duryodhana, which pleases him too.

After Duryodhana leaves, Krishna asks Arjuna why he chose him over the 100 million Narayanas. Arjuna says he did it because Krishna has fame and Arjuna also wants to be famous. Krishna is pleased to see that Arjuna is competitive, so he agrees to be Arjuna's charioteer in battle.

INDRA'S VICTORY. Yudhishtira hears about a time when Indra himself suffered a setback, and he asks to hear more about it. In the story, one of Indra's enemies creates a demon named Vritra that is too strong even for Indra. The other gods despair, and Vishnu decides he needs to intervene to make peace between Vritra and Indra. Vritra agrees to the peace terms, but then Indra finds a loophole and kills him. Afterwards, Indra feels guilty. Eventually Indra atones for what he did by offering a **horse** sacrifice and performing other deeds in penance.

SAMJAYA'S MISSION. Meanwhile at the Kauravas, Dhritarashtra gives instructions to his aide, Samjaya. Dhritarashtra disagrees with Duryodhana's warlike attitude, and so he wants Samjaya to go to the Pandavas and say whatever it takes to stop a war. Samjaya goes to present this message to the Pandavas, who agree they want peace but warn that their dharma allows a king to go to war against someone who seizes his land. Samjaya reports back to Dhritarashtra that he believes Duryodhana's aggression against the Pandavas will lead to the Kauravas' doom.

WAKEFULNESS. Dhritarashtra summons Vidura, saying he's been disturbed ever since Samjaya's visit to the Pandavas. Vidura tells Dhritarashtra that there are many different types of wisdom and foolishness and that the best advisor is one who can give good but unwanted advice.

The choice that Arjuna has to make—Krishna or 100 million extra soldiers—is symbolic. While the 100 million fighters might seem more practical from a military tactics perspective, the point of this passage is that Arjuna made the right choice and that the favor of Krishna is worth more than even 100 million soldiers. As an incarnation of Vishnu, Krishna's favor is like the favor of the gods, and so Arjuna affirms his belief that the gods are more powerful than even the largest quantity of mortals.



Arjuna's choice here has echoes of Karna's earlier choice to give up the armor that made him invulnerable for the sake of fame. Krishna's approval of this decision suggests that fame is one of the highest purposes of battle, perhaps even higher than winning itself.



This passage is a direct precursor to some of the events that will happen later in the Kurukshetra War between the Pandavas and Kauravas. The Pandavas will also face the choice of whether or not to use tricks to overcome their enemies. This passage does not necessarily offer an easy answer—while the actions of a great god like Indra might seem like a worthy example, Indra feels guilty about his choice afterwards, raising the question about whether even a supreme god like Indra makes mistakes sometimes.



Dhritarashtra, for all his weaknesses as a leader, still has a sense of the danger that the Kauravas will bring on themselves by antagonizing the Pandavas. While the Pandavas warn Samjaya about the possibility of violence, Krishna has advised them to try peace first, and so Dhritarashtra has a genuine opportunity to stop the impending war here. This passage emphasizes that Dhritarashtra has both the power to stop the war and knowledge of the consequences of failing to do so—and this means he must live with whatever decision he makes.



Dhritarashtra's unsettled state of mind shows that he understands the importance of the decision he's about to make. Vidura's comment about there being many different types of wisdom and foolishness relates yet again to the idea of dharma, where what is wise for one person might be foolish for another.



SANATSUJATA. Dhritarashtra speaks with an immortal seer named Sanatsujata and asks him why Sanatsujata believes there is no death. Sanatsujata doesn't quite answer the question, explaining instead that he believes distraction and passion are death and that asceticism is the best course of action.

Dhritarashtra's conversation with Sanatsujata shows that he is still concerned about the decision he has to make. Sanatsujata's condemnation of passion seems to be an indictment of the passionate jealousy that motivates all of Duryodhana's actions, whereas Sanatsujata's praise of asceticism recalls the more temperate attitude of Yudhishtira.



WAR AND PEACE. At dawn, the Kauravas all assemble in a hall. Samjaya enters with a message from Arjuna: if Duryodhana doesn't relinquish Yudhishtira's kingdom, the Pandavas are ready to go to war. At the hall, Bhishma also speaks up against Duryodhana. Dhritarashtra believes that it would be a disaster to fight the Pandavas, and yet Samjaya counters that Dhritarashtra nevertheless keeps listening to Duryodhana.

Dhritarashtra's first war meeting begins with just about everyone advising him that war would be a disastrous idea. Notably, even though Bhishma recently fought against the Pandavas during the cattle raid, he advises against continuing to fight them. Bhishma represents how complicated the various loyalties could become during war—although he has no personal grudge against the Pandavas and believes they are too strong to overcome, at the end of the day, he remains faithful to his leader, Dhritarashtra.



Duryodhana and Karna both speak up saying they want to fight anyway. After everyone leaves, Dhritarashtra privately asks for a prediction from Samjaya, who says that he believes the winner will be whoever has Krishna on their side, and right now that's the Pandavas.

Duryodhana and Karna's dislike of the Pandavas hinges on personal feelings rather than a reasoned assessment of the situation. They have succumbed to passion, as Sanatsujata warned in a previous passage, and their feelings threaten to bring the rest of the Kauravas into war with them.



THE MISSION OF THE BLESSED LORD. Yudhishtira asks Krishna for advice about how to proceed, and Krishna agrees to go to the Kauravas in person to try to bring about a peaceful solution. Uncharacteristically, Bhima also strongly calls for peace, causing Krishna to laugh at how unusual this is. Bhima gets angry at his laughter, saying that he's not afraid of war and simply advising what he thinks is best. They all discuss strategy in more detail, until finally Krishna leaves to see the Kauravas.

As this passage shows, even though Krishna isn't able to fight in battle, he still gives advice to the Pandavas. Coming right after the Kaurava war meeting, where Duryodhana and Karna try to recklessly lead their side into battle, this passage emphasizes the value of having a cooler head (like Krishna) to give advice—even the warlike Bhima begins to think more cautiously. All of this reaffirms that Arjuna made the right choice by choosing Krishna over the 100 million soldiers.



Dhritarashtra plans to receive Krishna lavishly, although Vidura warns him that no amount of opulence will sway Krishna away from the Pandavas. When Krishna arrives, he refuses to eat a meal until he's finished with his mission. In the morning, there's a great assembly where Krishna speaks in front of many of the Kauravas and their allies.

Although providing hospitality is usually an important duty for a king, here Dhritarashtra doesn't realize that his duty as a leader involves more than just providing hospitality—he needs to take this opportunity to make peace with the Pandavas. Once again, this illustrates how a person's dharma changes depending on the circumstances.



Krishna gives a speech about how Duryodhana has led them all away from dharma. He says the Kauravas are strong, but he asks them to imagine how much stronger they would be with the Pandavas on their side. Krishna talks about how Yudhishtira follows dharma and how his request to return his old kingdom is reasonable.

In his speech, Krishna connects dharma to the ever-important issues of lineage and legitimacy—Yudhishtira has a right to his throne, and it is against dharma for anyone to refuse to acknowledge that right.



DAMBHODBHAVA. Krishna's speech silences many in the audience. Rama Jamadagnya, however, tells a story about a mighty but boastful warrior king named Dambhodbhava. Dambhodbhava picked a fight with a great seer, however, and the seer defeated him by nullifying his arrows, then throwing reeds at his army. After finishing the story, Rama Jamadagnya warns that Arjuna and Krishna are like that great seer from the story.

Rama Jamadagnya's story continues on the same theme as Krishna's—while Dambhodbhava is strong, he makes the same mistake that the Kauravas are on the brink of making, trusting his own military prowess while ignoring spirituality. The great seer demonstrates how religion is more powerful than mere mortal strength by defeating a whole army with just reeds.



MATALI. The adoptive father of Śakuntala, who is a great seer, speaks up to tell a different story to Duryodhana. His is about Indra's charioteer Matali, who believes no god or mortal is good enough as a husband for his daughter, so he goes to the **snake** realm in the underworld. There, he finds a suitable serpent husband for his daughter. Indra confers long life on the new husband. A celestial bird named Garuda complains, so Vishnu intervenes to ask him to support the weight of his arm. Garuda can't deal with the weight, and this shows the arrogance of questioning the gods.

This story provides yet another example of a mortal who, while strong, overestimated his own strength compared to that of the gods. The moral of both these stories is that, because it's dharma for Yudhishtira to rule on his throne, the Pandavas have the gods on their side—and so it would be foolish to attempt to challenge them in war with mere mortal strength.



GALAVA. Now Narada has a story to tell in the hall of the Kauravas. He warns Duryodhana not to be stubborn by telling him about Galava, a student of the great seer Viśvamitra. Viśvamitra sends Galava out into the world, but Galava wants to bring him back a gift. Viśvamitra asks for 800 white **horses** with one black ear. With some help from Vishnu and from the king Yayati, Galava manages to fulfill this request.

Viśvamitra gives Galava a request that is supposed to be impossible, and yet by seeking out help from a god and a righteous king, Galava is able to do so anyway. This story is yet another morality tale about why the Kauravas should be cautious about the might of the Pandavas.



For his role in helping, Yayati regains his celestial form and goes to heaven. When he arrives, he asks Brahma why he fell back to earth in the first place. Brahma replies that he fell due to his pride. Ending the story, Narada believes that Duryodhana similarly risks being brought down by his pride.

This passage provides yet another example of the power of stories—the story conveys the danger of Duryodhana's pride more vividly than a simple argument would.



Hearing all this, Dhritarashtra says he definitely wants to make peace with the Pandavas. Krishna appeals to Duryodhana directly to try to convince him of the same. He reiterates that the Pandavas are powerful allies and that the Kauravas are likely to lose if they try to challenge them. Bhishma gives his own speech agreeing with Krishna, then Drona does the same. Vidura and even Dhritarashtra all tell Duryodhana that it is dharma to listen to Krishna.

This passage makes it clear that Duryodhana himself has heard all the good reasons for not going to war. The poem really emphasizes that whatever decision Duryodhana makes, he did so with full knowledge of the consequences—and the same applies just as much to Dhritarashtra, who has the power to stop Duryodhana. The idea that Duryodhana has the agency to make a choice is important—the most enlightened figures in the poem are the ones who are able to use introspection to reach the correction decision.



Angry at the advice, Duryodhana defends himself to the others at the assembly. He promises Krishna he won't surrender any land to the Pandavas, not even a piece of land as small as the tip of a spear. Krishna laughs angrily and tells the whole assembly the various ways Duryodhana has provoked the Pandavas and why they are justified to fight back. Eventually, Duryodhana gets so angry that he leaves the room.

Rather than considering the evidence or seeking self-knowledge, Duryodhana lashes out angrily, showing how he lacks the enlightened perspective of more introspective figures in the poem. Although the previous stories have all demonstrated the dangers of unearned confidence, Duryodhana nevertheless continues to make bold threats, having learned nothing.



Krishna suggests to the remaining people in the assembly that their best option is to bind Duryodhana and present him to the Pandavas. Dhritarashtra sends Vidura to fetch Gandhari for advice. She agrees that Duryodhana is acting foolishly and should be handed over to the Pandavas. They bring Duryodhana back so his mother can tell this to him directly.

In spite of Duryodhana's unreasonable response, Krishna remains committed to the idea of peace, suggesting that if Duryodhana is being unreasonable, then at least the other Kauravas could find a way to make peace. This passage is where Dhritarashtra shows his real weakness as a leader—just as he hesitated to kill Duryodhana as a baby for the greater good, he still hesitates to hand over Duryodhana as a prisoner, even after learning the consequences from Krishna and others of letting Duryodhana's pride drive the Kauravas into war.



Duryodhana refuses to accept their advice, and so he schemes with Śakuni about how to capture Krishna. But a wise warrior named Satyaki sees their conversation and figures out what they're planning, so he goes to Vidura with a warning. Krishna hears the news and tells Dhritarashtra that if anyone tries to restrain him, he won't fight back, even though he could destroy all his assailants. Dhritarashtra decides to make yet another attempt to get Duryodhana to see reason.

Duryodhana's decision to try to capture Krishna rather than listen to him shows a total lack of respect for the will of the gods. Krishna doesn't fight back due to his earlier promise not to fight in battle against them—while Krishna is extremely powerful, he is ultimately more interested in letting mortal affairs play out than in trying to single-handedly shape them.



Duryodhana still doesn't change his mind. But when he approaches Krishna to capture him, Krishna laughs and scolds him. All of a sudden, various gods seem to flow out of Krishna's body, like Brahma and Indra, and so do the five Pandavas. Many in attendance close their eyes in fear. Krishna returns to his normal form and then gets in his splendid chariot to leave and go back to Yudhishtira.

Krishna only demonstrates his true power on rare occasions. His display here frightens many in the audience but doesn't seem to move Duryodhana, showing the extent of Duryodhana's self-delusion—he is so convinced of his own strength as a mortal that he doesn't fear the gods even after witnessing direct proof of their power.



THE INSTRUCTION OF VIDURA'S SON. Krishna rides his chariot to Kunti to tell her of how Duryodhana has refused peace. She has her own messages to pass on to the Pandavas. Krishna travels onward with Karna and talks with him for a while.

Having failed to convince Duryodhana, Krishna moves on to Karna, who has been one of the most vocal advocates against the Pandavas but who nevertheless seems to have a more reasonable temperament than Duryodhana.



PERSUADING KARNA. Samjaya was riding with Krishna and Karna, and he reports back to Dhritarashtra what they discussed. Kunti (Karna's biological mother, as well as the biological mother of the three oldest Pandavas) tried to convince Karna to switch sides and join the Pandavas so that all her sons can be together. Karna refused, but he promised that the only Pandava he wants to kill is Arjuna.

Karna's attitude toward the Pandavas is much more reasonable than Duryodhana's, but his pride still leads him to make bad decisions. His special grudge against Arjuna goes back to their childhood, when Arjuna constantly received praise that Karna never got due to how his status as Kunti's child had to be hidden. Rather than accepting that he has a different dharma than Arjuna, Karna can't help craving what his half-brother has.



MARCHING TO WAR. Both the Pandavas and the Kauravas prepare their armies. **THE INSTALLATION OF BHISHMA.** Duryodhana puts Bhishma in charge of his forces. Dhritarashtra asks Samjaya to give him an update on Duryodhana's battle plans.

Now that Krishna has properly made the case for peace and the Kauravas have rejected it, both sides start preparing for war, which seems to be inevitable. Notably, even skeptics like Bhishma maintain their loyalty to Dhritarashtra when the time for battle actually draws near.



ULUKA'S MISSION. Samjaya begins telling Dhritarashtra about battle preparations. Uluka, son of Śakuni, delivers an inflammatory message to the Pandavas. They get predictably enraged, and so Duryodhana orders his troops to be ready for battle. **THE REVIEW OF THE MAJOR AND MINOR WARRIORS.** Samjaya continues his summary, describing how Duryodhana had Bhishma name all his major and minor warriors.

Uluka's speech emphasizes how the Kauravas are acting based on emotion rather than introspection or reasoning. Bhishma's list of all the names of people involved in the war is yet another example of part of the poem that serves little narrative or thematic purpose but ultimately helps the poem achieve its purpose as an encyclopedic reference.



AMBA. Duryodhana hears the story of how Bhishma will not kill Sikhandin, a mortal male warrior who used to be female and who is a reincarnation of the princess Amba (sister of Ambika and Ambalika). Bhishma initially kidnaps Amba, but although he returns her, this starts a rivalry between him and Rama Jamadagnya. Rama Jamadagnya and Bhishma fight an epic battle that lasts days and leaves both seriously wounded. At last, each man's ancestors help convince the two of them to put aside their disagreement.

This passage describes a rivalry that spans across reincarnations, with Bhishma kidnapping Amba in the past and then, later, having to deal with her new incarnation as the male warrior Sikhandin. One of the recurring themes in the poem is how a person's choices in one life affect what happens to them in the next life, and so Bhishma's abduction of Amba comes back to haunt him when Amba gets reincarnated.



Amba isn't happy with this outcome, wanting Bhishma dead, and so one day when Śiva offers her a boon, she asks to be reborn as a warrior who defeats Bhishma. To hasten this rebirth, she burns herself on a pyre. When Drupada requests a son from Śiva, Śiva gives him a daughter, Sikandini, whom they raise as a boy named Sikhandin. This causes a scandal when Drupada marries Sikhandin (formerly Sikhandini) to a princess, but a boon from a Yaksha transforms Sikhandin to have full "maleness." Nevertheless, Bhishma refuses to fight Sikhandin because he used to be a woman.

Depending on the perspective, sex and gender in the Mahabharata can feel either very modern or very dated by today's standards. On the one hand, Sikhandin becomes a noble warrior, and the figures who doubt his abilities (because he was born as the female Sikhandini) ultimately get proven wrong. At the same time, however, this transformation arguably reinforces gender roles by suggesting that women can't be warriors and that the only way for a woman to take on a male role is for a boon to biologically transform her.



CHAPTER 6. BHISHMA

THE CREATION OF THE CONTINENT OF JAMBU. Janamejaya asks Vaiśampayana to tell him more about how the great heroes of the Kauravas and the Pandavas fought, so Vaiśampayana begins the story. Each side masses its forces in preparation for conflict. Vyasa comes to speak with Dhritarashtra, offering to give the blind king sight so that he can see the battle. Dhritarashtra says he has no desire to see kin killing kin. Instead, Samjaya will tell him about it.

In this striking passage, Dhritarashtra deliberately chooses to stay blind rather than witness the consequences of his decisions. This decision embodies how Dhritarashtra deliberately turns away from knowledge and enlightenment, preferring to remain ignorant. His flaw as a leader is that he refuses to accept responsibility for his actions, and so any regrets that he later offers ring false.



THE EARTH. Dhritarashtra asks Samjaya to tell him more about the earth and the heavens. *THE SERMON OF THE BLESSED LORD.* After the first phase of battle, Samjaya tells Dhritarashtra that Bhishma has died. The death is a major blow to the Kaurava war effort. Samjaya begins the story in more detail.

This passage establishes the pattern that the next several books of the poem will follow. Samjaya narrates the events of each day's battle to the blind king Dhritarashtra (which is inside the frame story of Vaiśampayana talking to Janamejaya, which is itself inside the frame story of Ugrasravas talking to Śaunaka).



In Samjaya's recount of the battle, Bhishma urged all his followers that it was dharma to fight to the death. It soon becomes clear that the Pandava force is bigger and stronger, with the Kauravas facing west and the Pandavas facing east. Despite his advantage, Yudhishtira despairs at the size of the Kaurava army, although Arjuna reassures him.

Each day of the battle focuses on different heroes, and the first day, on which Bhishma dies, Bhishma nevertheless proves his worth by showing how, in accordance with the dharma of a warrior, he is willing to put his own life on the line, even against a stronger force like the Pandavas.



Here begins the *Bhagavadgita*, a sacred Hindu text that is both a self-contained scripture as well as a portion of the larger *Mahabharata* narrative. In it, Samjaya tells Dhritarashtra about the moment when the two armies finally clash. As battle begins, Arjuna despairs at how many members of his friends and family he may soon lose, and he temporarily puts down his weapons, but Krishna encourages him to fight by saying that life doesn't really begin or end, it just passes through different forms. He says it's Arjuna's dharma to fight, and so that's what he must do.

The *Bhagavadgita* (sometimes also called the *Bhagavad Gita* or just the *Gita*) is the most famous and the most frequently read portion of the *Mahabharata*. It takes the form of a conversation, although much of it is a monologue by Krishna, who provides Arjuna with the motivation and justification to take part in the current war. The *Bhagavadgita* is a guide for how to lead an enlightened life, and it condenses many of the ideas that run throughout the longer poem.



Arjuna is still confused, so Krishna explains in more detail. Krishna says there are two schools of thought: Samkhya philosophers who favor knowledge and yogis who favor action. He advises Arjuna that a distinguished person is one who has the discipline to perform all necessary actions with a sense of detachment. Those who become attached to their actions are deluded into thinking they have more agency than they actually do.

Krishna continues, saying that every creature has its own nature, and it's better to follow your own dharma than to try to achieve someone else's dharma. Arjuna asks why anyone would ever commit sin and go against his dharma.

Krishna then explains to Arjuna how he has been reincarnated on multiple occasions since the beginning of time. He says that, although it's difficult, wise seers through the ages have been able to see inaction in action and action in inaction. A person who is free of attachments will have their karma "dissolved." Sacrifice can be a way to find brahman.

Krishna explains more, saying that it's better to act than to renounce action, since brahman requires action. What's more, inaction doesn't create karma, and so it doesn't help an individual achieve brahman. Therefore, detached action is better than complete non-action. To escape the cycle of birth and rebirth, Krishna advises Arjuna to always think of him, since a person who dies thinking of Krishna will "attain" him and escape rebirth. Krishna explains that he is the seed of all living things, and a part of him supports the entire universe.

Arjuna asks if he can see Krishna's true highest form. He does so, showing a form with many mouths and eyes, shining like the light of a thousand suns. Krishna explains that he is "Time, the destroyer of worlds" and that whether Arjuna intervenes or not, all the soldiers he sees on the battlefield will one day be dead. This whole display impresses Arjuna, who trembles and says it's right for everyone to bow to Krishna. Krishna says that most men and even gods never see his supreme form and that Arjuna is lucky, and then he changes back to his normal mortal form.

"Detachment" is one of the most important concepts in the Bhagavadgita and in the poem at large. Broadly speaking, it refers to the kind of introspective, reasonable decision-making that Yudhishtira engages in as opposed to the rasher and emotion-driven decisions of Duryodhana. Krishna himself embodies this trait of detachment most of all, always suggesting the most reasonable course of action and refusing to let emotion control him.



Dharma has already been a major focus of the poem, but in the Bhagavadgita, Krishna explores the idea in even greater detail. He explains why dharma sometimes seems contradictory—since it differs depending on the person. He also adds that dharma applies to all creatures, not just humans.



Much of the poem deals with related but opposite concepts: action vs. inaction, dharma vs. adharma, Pandavas vs. Kauravas, etc. This passage begins a discussion on karma, one of the most famous concepts in Hinduism (as well as Buddhism, Jainism, and other religions). Put simply, karma is the result of deeds in one life, which then have a positive or negative effect on rebirth in the next life.



Krishna's distinction between detached action and non-action is important. He makes it clear that even ascetics don't fully stop taking action but instead decide to make sacrifice their action. Also important is the dichotomy in Krishna himself: while he is a mortal man who walks the earth just like Arjuna, he is also much more—the origin of all life as he explains in this passage. A person can achieve a better next life just by thinking of Krishna, emphasizing the role that introspection and knowledge play in Krishna's philosophies.



This portion of the poem is most famous today for its association with J. Robert Oppenheimer, who quoted it after the detonation of the first nuclear bomb (although in the translation he cites, it is "Death" that destroys worlds, not "Time"). Arjuna himself witnesses something extraordinary in this passage when he sees Krishna's true form. Krishna's display shows his trust in Arjuna, although at the same time, Krishna's reluctance to show his true form suggests that he would prefer to have people reach the truth on their own instead of attempting to show it to them himself.



Krishna explains many more topics to Arjuna, including how brahman is the womb into which he places his seed. He says all of worldly existence is like a tree. He once again describes renunciation and how a person shouldn't renounce sacrifice but rather perform sacrifice with detachment. He ends the conversation by reminding Arjuna to fix his mind on Krishna alone. This ends the *Bhagavadgita*.

Enlightenment, according to Krishna, is all about balance. Detachment means acting without passion, but it also means avoiding the temptation not to act at all. Krishna asks Arjuna to think about Krishna alone not just because Krishna deserves respect as an incarnation of the god Vishnu but also since Krishna himself always strives to live according to the principles that he sets out in the Bhagavadgita—and the rest of the poem will prove this point.



THE KILLING OF BHISHMA. Samjaya continues narrating battle events to Dhritarashtra. In the story, Yudhishtira alarms his allies by leaving his chariot and walking right toward his enemies with no armor or weapons. Krishna understands, however: Yudhishtira needs to seek permission from his elders to fight, and Bhishma is his elder, even though he fights on the opposite side.

Coming right after the Bhagavadgita, Yudhishtira's actions provide a good example of acting with detachment—and that is why Krishna understands what Yudhishtira is doing, even as the other Pandavas get worried. As king, it's Yudhishtira's dharma to set a standard of conduct for his army, and he chooses to respect the authority and experience of Bhishma, even though they meet as enemies on the field of battle.



Bhishma praises Yudhishtira for coming to see him before the battle. Yudhishtira asks if Bhishma has any advice for how to defeat him. Bhishma says he doesn't know of how any man can beat him, since he has a boon that he can choose the time of his death and that time hasn't arrived yet. Yudhishtira then goes on to speak with Drona and other elders on the enemy side, and they all praise him, despite their differences. Having done his duty, Yudhishtira heads back, put on his shining armor again, and gets back into his chariot.

Yudhishtira puts so much faith in Bhishma's honor that he asks Bhishma how to defeat him, expecting an honest answer. Perhaps even more surprisingly, Bhishma gives an honest answer, letting Yudhishtira know about the boon Bhishma received to be able to choose the time of his own death. When Yudhishtira puts his armor back on, it symbolizes that he has addressed Bhishma and the others for the last time as family members—from this point onward, they will only approach each other as enemies.



On the first day of fighting, the battles begin in an orderly fashion before turning into chaos, with everyone on the field of battle. Uttara dies in battle, killed by an elephant, and the first day ends with the Kauravas forcing the Pandavas to retreat. Bhishma and his arrows cause particular damage. The second day is less conclusive, but Bhishma continues to be a powerful force on the battlefield. On the third day, the Pandava army once again experiences major losses, and Krishna decides to kill Bhishma himself, but Arjuna stops him, saying that he will carry out the deed himself.

The death of Uttara, combined with the fierce attacks of Bhishma, both suggest that the war will not be as easy for the Pandavas as some predicted. Krishna, who believes the Pandavas will ultimately win, is almost tempted to break his promise not to fight and kill Bhishma, perhaps believing that keeping his promise is less important than the ultimate goal of securing a Pandava victory. While this might seem to be against dharma, as the incarnation of a god, Krishna's motivations can be mysterious, and in the end, Arjuna convinces Krishna not to kill Bhishma.



Arjuna goes on the attack, filling the whole horizon with arrows from his mighty bow. His attacks cause a river of blood and marrow to flow. That evening, the Kauravas lament how many Arjuna has killed.

The apocalyptic imagery in this passage, which goes well beyond what any mortal today could ever accomplish, shows the epic and heroic scale of this battle, particularly for the great warrior Arjuna.



On the fourth day of battle, Bhishma leads the attack against Arjuna. Meanwhile, Bhima slays so many elephants with his deadly club that he's covered in blood and fat. Duryodhana responds by sending all his troops toward Bhima. The day once again ends with an advantage to the Pandavas. Dhritarashtra interrupts the story to ask Samjaya why things are going so poorly, and Samjaya simply says it was unwise for Dhritarashtra to start this war in the first place.

On the fifth day of battle, the fighting resumes, even more noisy and violent than before. Both sides experience massive bloodshed, with Arjuna killing 25,000 charioteers near the end of the day. The sixth day is similarly destructive. Dhritarashtra wonders why his strong, capable army is failing to make better progress. Samjaya says yet again that it's Dhritarashtra's fault for starting the war and that it all goes back to Duryodhana's gambling scheme with Yudhishtira.

Samjaya describes to Dhritarashtra what happened on the battlefield, including the fierce rivalry between Drona and Drupada. Drupada gets injured and has to leave, and Drona continues to terrorize all of the Pandavas. Meanwhile, Bhima and Duryodhana clash in battle.

The seventh day begins with more violence. Bhishma and Yudhishtira lead formations against each other. Arjuna uses the special **celestial weapon** he got from Indra to slay many foes. Meanwhile, Virata and Drona fight each other. Drona fires a poison arrow that hits Virata's son Śankha, killing him. After the death of Uttara earlier, Virata has no sons left. Drona's son Aśvatthaman fights with Sikhandin.

The fighting continues throughout the seventh day. In the afternoon, Arjuna kills many of Bhishma's supporters and heads for Bhishma himself. Bhishma responds later in the day by killing Yudhishtira's **horses**.

Bhima's club suits his personality—as the most violent brother, he likes to fight close and personal, unlike Arjuna, who prefers to rain destruction from a distance. Dhritarashtra's confusion about the poor state of the battle draws little sympathy and is perhaps humorous, given how many times he received warnings about what would happen if he went to war with the Pandavas.



The casualty numbers in the war are catastrophic—Arjuna supposedly kills 25,000 enemies on his own in a single day with a bow and arrow. While the Pandava brothers all have flaws that remind the audience that they're human, on the battlefield, great heroes become something more than regular humans, perhaps aided by gods and celestial weapons, or perhaps simply because they come from a bygone, glorious age.



The battle goes back and forth, with just about every hero on each side having a chance to do something impressive. Despite the fact that the battle is a result of Duryodhana's pride, the actual combatants on both sides behave well, showing that they understand that the purpose of battle is to win fame through great deeds.



Virata's willingness to give up both sons to the Pandava cause shows his commitment, reaffirming that, despite his occasional hesitations while the Pandavas were in his city in disguise, he is ultimately an honorable man willing to sacrifice everything.



In this war, killing horses is often the first step to weakening an opponent before going in to attack the opponent himself. The constant presence of horses in battle is a sign of man's dependence on nature.



As the eighth day begins, the battle continues to be a stalemate, with each side killing many from the other side, but neither gaining a decisive advantage. A Rakshasa who is still mad about Bhima killing Baka sends illusory **horses** into battle to confuse the Pandavas. Meanwhile, on the opposite side, Bhima's Rakshasa son, Ghatotkaca, fights against the Kauravas and Duryodhana, but the day again ends in a stalemate.

The early days of the battle pass the quickest, with only a handful of casualties of named heroes. Samjaya narrates the first several days all together as one chunk—he mentioned Bhishma dying at the beginning of this book, and he hasn't reached that point in the story yet. The eighth day sees Rakshasha forcing an attack on behalf of each side, providing a sense of balance and showing how the two sides are evenly matched (which is fitting, given that this day ends in a stalemate).



On the ninth day of battle, the fighting remains intense, with Bhishma and Arjuna being two of the deadliest on the battlefield. Bhishma manages to shower Arjuna's chariot with arrows, but both Arjuna and his charioteer, Krishna, survive the onslaught. Both Bhishma and Arjuna are seriously injured. But while Arjuna fights with restraint, Bhishma is wildly going all out. At last, Krishna gets tired of waiting and jumps out of the chariot to fight Bhishma bare-handed. Arjuna chases after Krishna and tries to restrain him so that Krishna doesn't break his promise not to fight. Reluctantly, Krishna goes back into their chariot. Night falls again.

Krishna once again nearly breaks his promise not to join the fight, perhaps suggesting that he is frustrated at how the Pandavas have struggled to win an advantage despite their stronger army. His decision to fight bare-handed seems to show a recklessness that goes against Krishna's own advice to act with detachment, although, ultimately, Arjuna is again able to persuade Krishna to keep his promise not to join the fighting directly.



The Pandavas debate how to defeat the formidable Bhishma. At last, Yudhishtira suggests that they should approach Bhishma himself and ask him how he can be killed. The Pandavas visit Bhishma, paying him honor, and he greets them respectfully in return. They tell him he seems to have no weak spot, and they ask him how he can possibly be defeated. Bhishma tells the Pandavas that they'll never win the war while he's alive, and so they must strike at him quickly—he gives them permission to kill him.

Yudhishtira has already asked Bhishma how to defeat him, but he tries his luck again and gets a slightly different answer, with Bhishma granting permission for his own death. This strange conversation actually makes perfect sense for Bhishma's character—he is an honorable man more concerned with fulfilling his duty than with winning, and he has a lot of affection for the Pandavas. For Bhishma, who can see the long term and who values fame, dying in battle is a noble outcome and perhaps even a more desirable outcome than winning on behalf of the rash Duryodhana.



Bhishma adds that he can't be defeated in battle but can be defeated after he lays down his weapons. Another option would be for Arjuna to place someone else between him and Bhishma—that way, when Arjuna slays the other person, he can also hit Bhishma.

Bhishma is surprisingly frank about the tactics that the Pandavas can use to kill him. While he is being honorable, there is perhaps also a bit of bravado in his words—the heroic figures in this poem like giving their opponents a fair chance because it increases the potential for their own fame.



The tenth day of battle begins. Bhishma and Sikhandin fight—Arjuna urges Sikhandin to slay Bhishma, but he isn't able to. Bhishma strikes back and kills hundreds of thousands of Pandava allies. Drona senses that Arjuna is going to use Sikhandin to kill Bhishma.

Earlier, Bhishma refused to attack Sikhandin because even though Sikhandin is currently a man, he was born female before he received his boon. In this passage, Arjuna seems to be planning to use this fact to bring Bhishma down.



After ten days of slaughtering Pandava forces, Bhishma becomes tired of living. He calls to Yudhishtira and tells him to place Arjuna in front of him so that Arjuna can try to kill him. But as Sikhandin and Arjuna attack Bhishma, he continues to stay strong and even slays a brother of Virata. Eventually, Arjuna manages to sever Bhishma's bow, angering him. He then severs Bhishma's spear. Arjuna and the rest of his army continue to pierce Bhishma with arrows until they fill his entire body. At last, Bhishma falls from his chariot, although he doesn't allow himself to die yet because it's an unlucky time of year.

The Pandavas celebrate and the Kauravas mourn the downfall of mighty Bhishma. That evening, both sides gather to pay respects to Bhishma, who is still alive and welcomes all of them. He says he has no need for doctors and sends them away. Eventually, both armies go back to their camps for the evening, then come back the next morning, putting aside their weapons to pay Bhishma respect. To honor Bhishma, Arjuna offers him water, splitting the ground with an arrow and giving him water from the purest spring.

On his deathbed, but still not quite dead, Bhishma laments how Duryodhana's foolishness will be the downfall of the Kauravas. Later, however, Karna (who promised not to fight while Bhishma was alive) asks permission of Bhishma to fight on behalf of Duryodhana, and Bhishma grants it to him.

In this extraordinary passage, the great warrior Bhishma seems to just give up, perhaps partly because he doesn't want to attack Sikhandin. Crucially, Bhishma does not just stop fighting—this would be cowardice and against dharma. Instead, he continues to fight, knowing full well that he can't defeat the mighty Arjuna and accepting his death regardless. While in one sense, Bhishma “dies” in this passage, in fact, he plays a big role later in the poem because his boon allows him to hang on to life for quite a bit longer, long after the war itself ends.



At the beginning of the war, Yudhishtira took off his armor to pay respect to Bhishma, so it is fitting that Bhishma's downfall causes a similar ceasefire, where each army acknowledges the nobility of the other. While this scene is harmonious, it also represents a turning point, and the removal of Bhishma from the battlefield makes the grudges between the Pandavas and the Kauravas more personal.



One reason why the battle becomes more vicious after the defeat of Bhishma is that Karna personally resents the Pandavas, particularly Arjuna, whom he has long been planning to kill. Karna brings his passion onto the battlefield—the opposite of the detachment that Krishna recommended and that Bhishma embodied.



CHAPTER 7. DRONA

THE INSTALLATION OF DRONA. Samjaya narrates to Dhritarashtra how, without Bhishma, the Kauravas struggled against the Pandavas in battle on the eleventh day of fighting. But the first appearance of Karna on the battlefield raises their spirits. Duryodhana asks Karna who should replace Bhishma's position as commander, and Karna recommends Drona. Drona accepts but warns that he can't defeat Dhristadyumna, the man who is destined to kill him. Drona fights fiercely, like a man much younger, but Yudhishtira orders his own army to focus on stopping Drona, and after taking many casualties, they finally manage to kill him.

After hearing of Drona's death, Dhritarashtra is full of grief. He asks Samjaya to go back and tell him the story of Drona's death in more detail, which Samjaya does. He begins narrating.

Drona and Bhishma are both much older than typical soldiers. Their unusually advanced ages—like the high casualty counts in battle—help convey how extraordinary this battle is and how it isn't like battles fought in the narrative present, which takes place in a fallen age. Like Bhishma, Drona is also a noble person who nevertheless feels it's his duty to stick with Duryodhana. Drona's willingness to go into battle despite knowing that he'll die to Dhristadyumna shows that he is a righteous man who has made peace with his inevitable death.



Like the previous book, this story starts near the end of the day—Drona's death—then goes back to the beginning in more detail. This is yet another cycle in the poem that mirrors the cycle of death and rebirth.



THE KILLING OF THE SWORN WARRIORS. In Samjaya's recounting of the battle, Drona makes plans with Duryodhana to separate the invincible Arjuna from the rest of the army so that Drona can capture Yudhishtira. They arrange a challenge that Arjuna can't refuse, with their allies from the kingdom of Trigarta drawing Arjuna to the far southern part of the field of battle. Arjuna rains devastation down on the Trigartas.

Meanwhile, while Arjuna is away, Yudhishtira warns his ally Dhrishtadyumna not to let Drona capture him. Drona manages to devastate the Pandavas while Arjuna is gone, but he fails to capture Yudhishtira. Duryodhana attacks Bhima fiercely, and a false rumor springs up that Bhima is dead. All sides fight fiercely, with the Pandavas regrouping and Arjuna slaying three of Karna's brothers before the armies withdraw to their camps for the evening.

THE KILLING OF ABHIMANYU. After a long night, on the 13th day of battle, Duryodhana gets angry with Drona for failing to capture Yudhishtira on the previous day. Drona argues that Arjuna, with Krishna as his charioteer, is just too powerful. Drona promises that if Duryodhana can keep Arjuna occupied, he will kill one Pandava chief. By the end of the day, Drona manages to slay Arjuna's son, Abhimanyu. Dhritarashtra interrupts the story to ask Samjaya to tell this part in more detail, which he does.

In Samjaya's more detailed recounting of events, all the leaders of both armies clash on the field of battle that 13th day. No one can get at Drona because of how many arrows he keeps firing out. Yudhishtira sees how strong Drona is and puts Abhimanyu in charge of stopping him, since Arjuna himself is occupied with Duryodhana.

Abhimanyu rides toward Drona to attack, and all the Kauravas in the area focus their attacks on him. Abhimanyu fights valiantly, almost as strong as Arjuna himself as he repels the enemy army. Angry at the heavy losses, Duryodhana himself turns to fight Abhimanyu. But Abhimanyu continues to fight fiercely, slaying the younger brother of Karna. A son of Duryodhana also fights Abhimanyu, and Abhimanyu shoots his head off.

Yudhishtira is perhaps the single biggest threat to the Kauravas. He tries to use Arjuna's noble nature against him, taking advantage of the fact that Arjuna can't turn down a challenge in order to lure him away from the other fighters.



The Pandavas manage to survive a potentially devastating attack by working together, demonstrating the power of cooperation. Even though Yudhishtira gets separated from Arjuna, he knows that Dhrishtadyumna will protect him, since Dhrishtadyumna is fated to defeat Drona. Meanwhile, Arjuna's killing of Karna's three brothers continues to stoke one of the most heated rivalries on the battlefield.



The story begins to jump around in time even more—Samjaya hasn't yet reached the death of Drona, which he mentioned in the beginning of the book, and now he mentions the death of Abhimanyu, only before going back in time again to describe the events that lead up to Abhimanyu's death. Abhimanyu is perhaps the most important Pandava ally to die so far, and so his death marks a crucial turning point, as the outmatched Kauravas nevertheless find ways to make gains against the Pandavas.



The battle between Drona and Abhimanyu represents a clash of opposites, with Drona being an elderly experienced fighter while Abhimanyu is barely more than a boy, and each one fights better than expected for their age. The comparative youth of the Pandavas shows how they are the new generation.



Abhimanyu proves himself in battle, angering some of the most passionate Kauravas: namely, Karna and Duryodhana. By doing so, he perhaps puts a target on himself, but he gladly accepts this responsibility because he realizes even at his young age how important it is to try to win fame in battle.



Abhimanyu continues to slay great heroes, even after taking many arrows to his own body. Drona and Karna discuss how to slay Abhimanyu, with Drona suggesting that Karna and others try to ride Abhimanyu out of his chariot. Eventually, the Kauravas succeed in unseating Abhimanyu from his chariot, all while Jayadratha's forces keep the other Pandavas from intervening. Abhimanyu grabs a club and keeps fighting. A son of Duhśasana manages to hit Abhimanyu over the head, and several other chariot-fighters led by Drona and Karna attack him, killing him. Celestial beings seem to cry out that this death is not dharma, but the combatants continue to fight skillfully for the rest of the day.

Previously, when the Kauravas targeted Yudhishthira, he coordinated with his allies to fend them off. The Kauravas seem to have learned from that attack, and so now when they target Abhimanyu, Jayadratha specifically cuts him off from the other Pandavas so that the remaining Kauravas can all overwhelm Abhimanyu. Abhimanyu's determination to keep fighting against overwhelming odds even after losing his chariot shows what a noble warrior he is. Perhaps the celestial beings mourn Abhimanyu's death because the Kauravas defeated Abhimanyu with sheer numbers rather than finding a warrior equal to challenge him in battle.



Yudhishthira gives a speech to his army about Abhimanyu's bravery. He regrets sending the young Abhimanyu to his death. When Arjuna returns that evening and learns of the death of his son, he mourns and vows that he will either kill Jayadratha by the end of the next day or will walk into fire.

Although the Pandavas have suffered some losses, Abhimanyu's death hits closest to home for the five Pandava brothers. While Arjuna grieves for his dead son, he also moves immediately to thoughts of revenge, showing that, as a great warrior, he won't let his grief slow him down.



THE PROMISE. When Jayadratha hears the noise from the Pandavas' camp, he fears what Arjuna will do to him and asks to leave the battle. But Duryodhana and Drona promise to protect him, saying that even if he dies in battle, that is the highest honor for a Kshatriya. Meanwhile, in his dreams, Arjuna receives a visit from Krishna who advises him to go praise Śiva. He does so in the dream, then wakes up the next day ready to seek out Jayadratha.

Jayadratha's desire to leave battle shows weak character, at least for a Kshatriya, who is supposed to be willing to die in battle according to his dharma (as Duryodhana and Drona remind him). Meanwhile, Śiva is the god of destruction, and so by seeking him out, Arjuna indicates how much he wants to destroy his enemies to avenge the death of Abhimanyu.



THE KILLING OF JAYADRATHA. On the morning of the 14th day of battle, both sides make preparations for the upcoming fighting—especially the expected attack of Arjuna against Jayadratha. Arjuna fights fiercely that day, killing both elephants and warriors. Worried about Arjuna's attacks, Duryodhana comes to Drona, and Drona recites mantras to make Duryodhana invincible with his armor.

The beginning of the 14th day of battle goes as planned, with Arjuna predictably attacking Jayadratha and Duryodhana and Drona coming to his defense. Drona's use of mantras reinforces how, in spite of fighting on the Kauravas side, he is still a spiritual man with respect for the gods, which gives him and his side more power.



The battle splits off in many directions, but eventually, Arjuna, with Krishna as his charioteer, starts to make his way toward Jayadratha, killing whoever stands in his way. Just as all the Kauravas fear that Arjuna will surely kill Jayadratha, Duryodhana comes to stop him in his invincible armor. Fierce battles continue everywhere, as Satyaki tries to make his way through the fray to help Arjuna, killing everyone in his path. Meanwhile, although Drona is in his 80s, he continues to fight like a young man.

Acting as Arjuna's charioteer, Krishna represents the favor of the gods, making it all but certain that Arjuna will eventually make his way to Jayadratha despite the formidable obstacles he faces, which include Duryodhana's invincible armor. Drona's surprising strength, even at his advanced age, is also a symbol of how he has pleased the gods.



Bhima manages to get Karna off the battlefield by killing his charioteer. Duryodhana and Drona regroup, devoting all the Kaurava resources to protecting Jayadratha. Dhritarashtra interrupts Samjaya's story to ask more about Bhima and Karna's battle, so Samjaya tells it in more detail.

Both sides have learned the dangers of letting one of their own get split off from the main group, and so they fight closely together. The various interruptions to the story by figures like Dhritarashtra help open up the perspective, making it a dialogue instead of a monologue and helping to give it a more conversational feel.



In Samjaya's retelling, Bhima goes after Karna and manages to kill five of Dhritarashtra's 100 sons. Karna manages to knock Bhima out of his chariot, but he refuses to kill Bhima while he's unarmed. Satyaki welcomes Bhima into his own chariot. A warrior named Buriśravas challenges Satyaki, managing to destroy his weapons, strike him down to the ground, and drag him around the battlefield by his hair. Arjuna takes offense at this and severs Buriśravas's sword arm with an arrow. Buriśravas gets angry, accusing Arjuna of ignoring dharma by striking him by surprise.

Dhritarashtra was warned that if he didn't kill Duryodhana in infancy, he would face problems later, and now, because Dhritarashtra refused to kill one son, he has lost five sons, and the war is still far from over. The fight between Buriśravas and Arjuna is interesting because it raises the question of what dharma is in battle. After the death of Abhimanyu, which many celestial spirits deemed against dharma, things have become more muddled, in contrast to the early days of battle when the two armies generally respected each other.



Arjuna gets angry at Buriśravas, saying that he struck Buriśravas fairly while he was fighting Satyaki, and that it was even worse that the Kauravas killed Abhimanyu while he was out of his chariot. Buriśravas prepares to die as he bleeds out. Satyaki wants to kill Buriśravas himself, and although his whole army advises him against it, Satyaki decapitates Buriśravas. While some scold Satyaki, others believe he was only following fate.

Arjuna brings up an interesting idea—that dharma in battle involves not just the actions of the moment but also how both armies have acted previously. The poem doesn't always provide a definitive answer to what is and isn't dharma, and Satyaki's decapitation of Buriśravas further blurs the line between excessive violence and justified revenge.



After this, Arjuna urges Krishna to take him toward Jayadratha. Karna is the last defense, but Arjuna manages to slay his **horses**. Aśvatthaman takes Karna into his chariot, and the fighting continues. Krishna informs Arjuna that it is finally the right time to kill Jayadratha. Arjuna fires an arrow that decapitates Jayadratha, carrying his head as if it were a hawk and dropping it in the lap of Jayadratha's father. Cheered by this victory, the Pandavas try to press their advantage.

When Arjuna finally kills Jayadratha, it's almost anticlimactic. He simply decides—on Krishna's advice—that it's time, and then he fires his bow. The fact that Arjuna sends Jayadratha's decapitated head flying to his father is meant to send a message: that Arjuna is getting revenge for Jayadratha's role in killing his own son Abhimanyu.



THE KILLING OF GHATOTKACA. Fighting continues, with Arjuna continuing to seem invincible. Duryodhana blames Drona for going too easy on Arjuna, but his advisors continue to blame Duryodhana's own pride for starting a feud with the Pandavas in the first place.

Despite Samjaya's promise to tell the story of Drona's death at the beginning of the book, the plot keeps weaving off in different directions and following different tangents of battle. Time in the poem slows down in the last days of battle compared to the first few, emphasizing how particularly important these days of the war are.



As the battle continues into the night, all of the Pandavas rush toward Drona. Despite fierce resistance, Bhima kills many great warriors. That night, everyone in the Pandava army honors Bhima for his strong fighting. The fighting doesn't stop, however, as both sides continue in bloody battle, with Ghatotkaca getting hit with an arrow and dragged off the field of battle unconscious. Bhima manages to kill 10 more of Dhritarashtra's 100 sons, as well as one of Karna's brothers.

The Pandavas continue to chip away at the Kauravas, not yet killing their most important fighters but nevertheless killing valuable soldiers. This section becomes a chance for Ghatotkaca to shine, although, as the subheading hints, it will also be when he dies. In many ways, Ghatotkaca's story resembles Abhimanyu's, which is fitting because Abhimanyu was Arjuna's son and Ghatotkaca is Bhima's son.



Fighting goes late, and Duryodhana instructs his men to light lamps. Eventually, the Pandavas have a clear advantage, and many Kauravas have to retreat. Arjuna wants to battle to the death against Karna, but Krishna says it's not time and that Ghatotkaca, now revived, should go instead. Ghatotkaca goes on a rampage. Duryodhana sends a Rakshasa warrior named Alamabala to fight him, but Ghatotkaca defeats him and throws Alamabala's head back to Duryodhana, saying that he and Karna are next.

Krishna's advice that Ghatotkaca should attack Karna before Arjuna does so ends up being prudent, and it provides an example of how Krishna's wisdom is more valuable than the 100 million soldiers Arjuna could have had instead. Ghatotkaca's half-Rakshasa nature makes him a particularly wild and unpredictable fighter.



Ghatotkaca and Karna fight fiercely, with Ghatotkaca using illusions to distract his opponent, but Karna dispels these illusions by catching a thunderbolt that Ghatotkaca throws and hurling it back. Ghatotkaca vanishes, but he soon rejoins the battle elsewhere and continues killing, which worries Duryodhana.

The battle between Ghatotkaca and Karna takes on epic proportions, with Ghatotkaca wielding the power of thunder, but Karna catching a thunderbolt to throw back. This exchange establishes that the two of them are evenly matched opponents.



Karna doesn't back down, however, and he destroys a shower of arrows headed at him. Ghatotkaca gets angry and is eager to strike Karna down. The two fight directly with each other. All of a sudden, Ghatotkaca vanishes, and everyone fears he will kill Karna while invisible. Hundreds of illusory weapons start coming at Karna from every angle. The other Kaurava fighters see this carnage and retreat in fear. Karna stands firm, but Ghatotkaca kills his **horses**, unseating him from his chariot.

Ghatotkaca's illusions, which bolster his raw strength by adding an element of trickery, help him get an advantage over Karna. He manages to unseat Karna from his chariot, which is exactly what happened to Abhimanyu before his death on a previous day. Nevertheless, Karna's refusal to retreat, even as his allies run away around him, shows that he isn't out of the fight yet.



The destruction around Karna seems so great that many encourage him to use his special **celestial weapon** Spear from Indra. Although Karna has been saving the Spear for Arjuna, at last he agrees to use it on Ghatotkaca. The Spear immediately turns all of Ghatotkaca's illusions to ashes and rips through his heart. As Ghatotkaca dies, his giant form falls down and smashes a section of the Kaurava army.

Karna's decision to use the spear is an acknowledgement that if he had stuck with normal weapons, Ghatotkaca would have beaten him. Although he wins this battle, he loses his ability to use his powerful single-use Spear against Arjuna, potentially sealing his fate later. This is why Krishna advised Arjuna to let Ghatotkaca attack Karna first.



THE KILLING OF DRONA. All of the Pandavas grieve the fall of Ghatotkaca except Krishna, who rejoices. While Arjuna feels Krishna's behavior is inappropriate, Krishna explains that now that Karna is without his Spear, Arjuna can finally defeat him. Additionally, if Ghatotkaca had not died in battle just then, Krishna himself would have had to kill him for the sake of dharma.

As the incarnation of the god Vishnu, Krishna's focus is on the long term, and so he struggles to see the negative side of Ghatotkaca's death, since it ultimately will help the Pandavas win the war. Krishna's greater knowledge of dharma tells him that this was Ghatotkaca's time to die, and so he rejoices that Ghatotkaca died a heroic death that will advance the Pandava cause.



When battle starts up on the 14th day, Yudhishtira fears what the loss of Ghatotkaca will do to his army and says they must take out the mighty enemy warriors like Drona and Karna. Many of the fighters are weary, but after a short break, the battle continues through the night and goes into the 15th day. Dhrishtadyumna leads an attack toward Drona, causing Duryodhana to rush to Drona's reinforcement. As Duryodhana comes forward, Satyaki attacks him.

More and more high-ranking fighters have begun to fall in battle as the war begins to build toward a climax. Dhrishtadyumna is fated to kill Drona, but as this passage shows, the Kauravas are prepared for him, and he finds it difficult to get a clear opening.



Satyaki and Duryodhana exchange both sharp words and many volleys of arrows with each other. Yudhishtira commands Arjuna to try to drive away all the Kauravas fighting near Drona. Krishna advises Arjuna to temporarily put aside dharma and to use whatever trick it takes to get rid of Drona—specifically, he tells Arjuna to falsely tell Drona that his son Aśvatthaman has died. Although he's reluctant, Arjuna agrees to this.

Krishna's advice to ignore dharma for the sake of tactics is shocking but not entirely unprecedented, given that Krishna himself almost ignored dharma when he wanted to personally kill Bhishma. This passage complicates the morality poem, hinting at the paradoxical idea that, while dharma is often the most important thing, sometimes other concerns are even more important than dharma.



Bhima kills an elephant from his own army named Aśvatthaman, then tells Drona that "Aśvatthaman" is dead. Drona is heartbroken, believing his son is dead, although a part of him wonders if it's a lie, since he believes no enemy could overcome Aśvatthaman. Drona continues to rain down destruction on the battlefield, killing tens of thousands of opponents. The Pandavas move in to attack Drona. Still unsure if his son is alive, Drona asks Yudhishtira if it's true that Aśvatthaman has been slain. Reluctantly, Yudhishtira lies and says Aśvatthaman is dead. Drona believes the noble Yudhishtira and loses his will to live.

Bhima's choice to kill an elephant named Aśvatthaman seems like an attempt to make their attack more dharma by adding an element of truth to their trick. In a way, the death of the elephant Aśvatthaman is in the same vein as other animal sacrifices from the poem, like the snake sacrifices or the horse sacrifice. Drona's despair at hearing about the death of Aśvatthaman is understandable and also may have specific significance, since Aśvatthaman is Drona's heir, and without him he doesn't have anything to fight for.



Drona can't fight like he used to. Dhrishtadyumna, who is destined to kill Drona, rushes forward to attack. The two of them engage in fierce battle, firing arrows back and forth. Drona manages to kill Dhrishtadyumna's **horses**, forcing him out of his chariot. In turn, Dhrishtadyumna takes his sword and goes to slay Drona on foot. Drona readies an arrow to kill Dhrishtadyumna, but Satyaki intervenes to cut it off.

Even in his weakened, depressed state, Drona represents a formidable opponent, and it takes multiple Pandava allies to keep him under control even after he loses his chariot. Like many of the great figures in the poem, he does some of his best fighting in the moments before his death, adding to the overall depiction of warfare in this time period as a glorious spectacle.



Yudhishtira readies all his soldiers to charge at Drona. But Drona's weapons blaze, and he keeps his many enemies at bay. He uses his Brahmin power to kill 100,000 Kshatriyas. Dhrishtadyumna advances toward Drona undeterred. Drona hits him with several arrows. Just then, Bhima comes up behind Drona and scolds him for supposedly being a Brahmin but neglecting dharma and non-violence. Ashamed, Drona puts down his weapons.

Seeing Drona vulnerable as he is absorbed in Yoga, Dhrishtadyumna takes the opportunity to attack. Dhrishtadyumna is shocked as he sees Drona take on his final state, but only a few other mortals see this change. For everyone else, it just appears that Drona's body bleeds out, pierced by arrows. Dhrishtadyumna approaches the corpse and severs Drona's head. He throws the head into the Kaurava army, and many of them lose their will to fight. Meanwhile, the Pandavas celebrate. When the still-alive Aśvatthaman hears of his father's death, he is full of anger.

THE WEAPON OF NARAYANA. Dhritarashtra asks Samjaya to tell more about when Aśvatthaman heard about Drona's death, and so Samjaya tells the story. After hearing of his father's death, Aśvatthaman wants to use the **celestial weapon** that Drona received as a boon from Narayana (a form of Vishnu). He uses the weapon, and a mighty storm gathers. Aśvatthaman kills many of the battlefield but doesn't succeed in killing Arjuna or Krishna. Meanwhile, the Pandavas argue among themselves about whether Drona's killing was justified.

CHAPTER 8. KARNA

THE KILLING OF KARNA. After the Kauravas finish mourning the death of Drona, Karna gets appointed as his successor in command. But two days later, Karna dies at the hand of Arjuna. Dhritarashtra faints in dismay at this news, then asks Samjaya to tell him the story in more detail, which he does.

Samjaya begins his new retelling of the events. After the death of Drona, Duryodhana rallies the troops to hold on until nightfall before withdrawing back to their camp. Back at camp, Aśvatthaman recommends that Karna be the new commander, and Duryodhana agrees with him. Karna accepts and receives praise from all the Kauravas.

The casualty numbers for the unnamed soldiers continue to rise to show how the named heroes are fighting even more intensely. This scene is surprising, not just because a few words convince the mighty Drona to lay down his weapons, but specifically because those words come from Bhima, who has very little room to speak when it comes to practicing nonviolence.



This passage provides yet another example of the power of dharma, which causes Drona to stop fighting right in the middle of battle and perform Yoga. Although Dhrishtadyumna manages to defeat the mighty Drona—a feat that even warriors greater than himself couldn't accomplish—his victory has an air of anticlimax to it. By taking on his final state before death, Drona arguably came out ahead in terms of dharma, since he died in such an enlightened state. Dhrishtadyumna, on the other hand, comes out of the encounter having made a powerful enemy in Aśvatthaman.



Aśvatthaman's celestial weapon, which takes the form of a storm, acts as an embodiment of all the rage and frustration he feels after the death of his father. Despite the power of this rage, Aśvatthaman ultimately fails to kill either Arjuna or Krishna with his celestial weapon, suggesting that perhaps his rage caused him to act too rashly.



Karna's death seems to be the inevitable outcome of the fact that he used his special spear against Ghatotkaca, leaving him with no means of defeating the nearly invincible Arjuna. Dhritarashtra continues to be surprised by each new development in battle, despite the many warnings he received beforehand.



Unlike the previous commanders of the Kaurava army, Karna has a real grudge against the Pandavas and specifically wants to kill Arjuna. With him in command, as well as with the prominent losses of the previous few days, the battle between the Kauravas and the Pandavas becomes even more personal.



On the 16th day of fighting, Karna leads the Kauravas into battle. Yudhishtira urges Arjuna to focus on killing Karna, the greatest remaining warrior on the Kaurava side. Karna begins the day inflicting heavy casualties and fending off the attacks of the Pandavas. Arjuna faces off against Aśvatthaman, but the latter retreats after realizing Arjuna is seemingly invincible. Meanwhile, Karna fights Nakula and almost kills him, but he decides to spare his life (due the promise Karna made to Kunti a while back about only killing Arjuna out of all the Pandavas).

As with the previous days of fighting, the morning generally lacks decisive fights but instead sets the stage for what will come later in the day. Karna's decision to spare Nakula's life is striking, indicating how despite all the rage and jealousy he feels toward Arjuna, he is nevertheless even more loyal to their shared mother Kunti. With the possible exception of Duryodhana, all of the "villains" of the Mahabharata have complex motivations, living their dharma in many ways even as they fight on the wrong side, and Karna is a perfect example of this.



Yudhishtira battles Duryodhana, and both of their armies gather around them to expand the fighting. As the sun sets, the two armies head back to their camps. They keep fighting the next morning—the 17th day of battle. Karna tells Duryodhana that this is the decisive day when either Karna kills Arjuna or Arjuna kills Karna. Duryodhana then asks a great warrior named Salya to drive Karna's chariot, and though Salya is reluctant to take a position that he considers lowly, he accepts after Duryodhana flatters him.

As named figures begin to die on both sides, particularly among the Kauravas, the battle moves toward a climax. Given that Karna used his special weapon on Ghatotkaca, it seems more likely that Arjuna will kill him rather than him killing Arjuna, but the fact that Karna remains determined to do battle anyway suggests that he has accepted his death and is acting according to dharma.



Karna begins offering money to anyone who can point him toward Arjuna. Salya argues with him, believing this is inappropriate. He says that Karna isn't strong enough to take on someone of Arjuna's stature. Salya continues to question Karna's expertise, but Karna says he has considered the upcoming battle well. While he acknowledges Arjuna's prowess, he isn't afraid to face him.

While Salya may seem to be the more pragmatic fighter, this passage ultimately paints Karna in a more positive light. While Duryodhana is evil for letting his pride get the better of him and believing he can win fights that he can't, Karna is noble because he seeks fame by accepting fights even when he knows he likely won't win.



The battle rages on, with Karna and Arjuna each killing many of their respective opponents on different parts of the battlefield. Karna approaches Yudhishtira and forces him to retreat. Angry at this, Bhima knocks Karna unconscious with an arrow, and Salya carries him off. Karna soon recovers, however, and gets back up to fight Bhima again. The battle continues, with many heroes narrowly escaping death.

As with other days of battle, these early knockouts and near-death experiences help to raise the stakes and build anticipation for the more decisive fighting to come later in the day. By returning to the fight shortly after getting injured, Karna continues to show determination on his final day.



At one point, Yudhishtira thinks Arjuna has slain Karna, then he gets angry when he finds out Karna is still alive. Arjuna is so angry in response that he almost kills Yudhishtira, but Krishna calms him. Arjuna promises to kill Karna that day. One of Karna's sons dies in battle. Bhima kills 10 more of Dhritarashtra's 100 sons. Then Arjuna kills another son of Karna.

The false rumors described in this passage help capture the chaos of a large battlefield. Whereas earlier, Arjuna had to calm Krishna down (to prevent him from breaking his promise and attacking), now Krishna returns the favor by calming Arjuna, showing how they balance each other in their relationship.



Karna and Arjuna finally face off with their armies. Karna gets first blood, hitting Arjuna with 10 arrows, but the fight rages on, and soon Arjuna pierces Karna and Salya. Onlookers see the fight and feel they are witnessing gods. Eventually, Arjuna attacks so fiercely that the other Kauravas abandon Karna, yet he still fights bravely alone.

In order to convey how glorious the combatants are, each major fight is more epic than the last. While Arjuna is the more heroic figure, this passage also builds up the nobility of Karna by emphasizing his bravery in fighting after his allies run away. This emphasis on Karna's bravery is partly so that Arjuna has a worthy foe to defeat—what's more, though, this portion of the poem once again shows that the line between "heroes" and "villains" isn't always straightforward.



At one point, Karna nearly hits Arjuna's head, but Krishna maneuvers the chariot, and instead it just knocks off Arjuna's diadem (a type of crown). Angry, Arjuna fires back an arrow like a venomous **snake** that cuts through Karna's shield. Karna fires back, hitting both Arjuna and Krishna, but then Arjuna finally pierces Karna's vital organs. Karna's crown and armor all fall off. His chariot collapses and Karna curses his dharma for not protecting him. Still, despite Arjuna's continued attacks, Karna keeps warding off the fatal blow.

A diadem is a symbol of authority. By knocking off Arjuna's diadem, Karna expresses his long-simmering jealousy toward Arjuna's higher status. This insult prompts Arjuna to respond with an even stronger attack, proving that, for all Karna's prowess in battle, he can't compete with Arjuna, particularly not when he has the power of Krishna on his side. In this passage, Krishna literally steers Arjuna to safety, and this guidance is symbolic of how Krishna steers Arjuna to make choices according to dharma.



Arjuna manages to tear apart Karna's standard with a gold-shafted arrow. Arjuna asks the gods to bless his next arrow, then lets it fly, killing Karna. Salya carries back the broken standard and Karna's corpse. He tells Duryodhana of what he just witnessed. Meanwhile Krishna and Yudhishtira congratulate Arjuna.

The breaking of a standard is as symbolic as destroying a diadem—perhaps even more so. Standards are important objects in battle that raise morale and that stand for what each side is fighting for. By destroying Karna's standard before killing him, Arjuna shows that he wants to destroy not just Karna but also everything he stands for.



CHAPTER 9. SALYA

After Karna's death, Duryodhana appoints Salya as the next commander, but soon after, Yudhishtira kills him. Not long after, Bhima slays Duryodhana. Some surviving Kauravas surprise the Pandavas at night, and there are heavy casualties. By the end, seven Pandavas survive (the five brothers plus Satyaki and Krishna) and three Kauravas survive (Kripa, Kritarvarma and Aśvatthaman). Dhritarashtra is devastated by this report and asks Samjaya to tell him the whole story.

With the death of Duryodhana, the war ends, but as this passage hints, the war isn't a complete triumph for the Pandavas, with only a handful of survivors left on each side. Despite how glorious the fighting has been throughout the war, the ultimate outcome is death and destruction. Aśvatthaman's night raid further disrupts the narrative of a glorious war, providing an example of a sneaky, successful attack that differs significantly from the honorable battlefield heroics in the previous books.



Samjaya starts narrating again. Some of Duryodhana's allies believe it is dharma for him to keep fighting, while others believe the only rational option is to surrender to the Pandavas. Aśvatthaman recommends Salya as a replacement for Karna. Salya leads the Kauravas into battle on the 18th day, but the Pandavas force them to retreat.

After regrouping, the Kauravas attack again, and this time Salya kills many Pandavas, angering Yudhishtira. He vows that either he'll kill Salya on the battlefield or vice versa. The two of them do battle against each other, sending arrows flying back and forth. Meanwhile, Bhima fights Duryodhana.

Salya manages to pierce Yudhishtira with an arrow, but despite his serious injury, Yudhishtira fires back. Salya presses his attack, killing Yudhishtira's **horses**, so Bhima intervenes, firing enough arrows to make Salya almost faint and lose his armor. Salya comes down from his chariot to fight with his sword, but Bhima cuts his sword off at the hilt with an arrow.

Yudhishtira now focuses again on killing Salya. He throws a special spear originally designed for Śiva, and it pierces Salya's vital organs. The earth itself seems to rise up to greet Salya as he falls, and he dies bleeding on the ground. The death of Salya frightens many of the Kauravas, who flee the battlefield. Duryodhana fights alone, even as he sees the rest of his army retreating. All the Pandavas praise Yudhishtira.

DURYODHANA ENTERS THE LAKE. The surviving Kauravas debate strategy as the Pandavas keep destroying them. Bhima slays 21,000 followers of Duryodhana with just a club. Still, some Kauravas manage to continue killing Pandava warriors. Bhima then slays what remains of Dhritarashtra's sons (aside from Duryodhana). Sahadeva manages to decapitate Śakuni. Seeing no allies around, Duryodhana goes to a nearby lake to reflect on how Vidura's predictions of a grievous loss came true. Eventually, the last surviving Kauravas (Aśvatthaman, Kritarvarma, Kripa, and Sanjaya) meet up with Duryodhana, then they all head back to camp.

Now that Samjaya has already revealed the ending of the battle to Dhritarashtra, a doomed air of inevitability hangs over his narration of the events. Without the suspense of what happens next, the story becomes more about how each combatant decides to accept their fate.



As the battle comes toward a conclusion, each of the two main leaders—Yudhishtira and Duryodhana—get the spotlight. The last major day of battle follows a similar pattern to the earlier ones, with the events in the morning resulting in a stalemate but foreshadowing more consequential fights later on, like the eventual duel between Bhima and Duryodhana.



By killing Yudhishtira's horses, Salya gets rid of his mobility and makes him more vulnerable to attack. But just as on the previous day Arjuna responded to Karna's attack with an even harder attack, Bhima now steps in to give Salya a taste of his own medicine, knocking him off his chariot and destroying his sword—both of which make him helpless.



Although Yudhishtira's battle with Salya ends with an appropriately earth-shaking conclusion, his victory was only possible due to Bhima's intervention. The heroic pageantry of the early days increasingly gets replaced by more pragmatic and at times even dirty tactics, reflecting how the true nature of war may not be as glorious as it once seemed.



Duryodhana's retreat to the lake seems unusually introspective of him, given how vocal he was previously about charging into battle, even when it wasn't wise. This passage shows how grief and loss can affect even the most stubborn people, including Duryodhana. Water has many spiritual connections in the poem, usually to purification and new life, and Duryodhana's trip to the lake seems to be a much-too-late attempt for him to reflect on his actions and perhaps even atone for them.



THE PILGRIMAGE. Balarama, the older brother of Krishna, wanders the world on a pilgrimage visiting many sacred bathing places. He stayed neutral during the war, due to connections to both sides, but he comes to the field of battle to witness the battle between Bhima and Duryodhana.

Balarama's pilgrimage to the bathing places parallels Duryodhana's recent trip to the lake (as well as Yudhishtira's earlier trip to the bathing places during the exile of the Pandavas). Balarama's neutrality is yet another detail that calls attention to the morally ambiguous nature of the war, since Balarama is honorable and he has friends on both sides.



THE DUEL WITH CLUBS. As Bhima and Duryodhana prepare to fight, Balarama proposes a duel with clubs. The two men fight each other violently, with Duryodhana knocking Bhima down, though Bhima gets right back up. From the sidelines, Arjuna asks Krishna who's stronger, and Krishna says that while they're similarly powerful, Bhima is stronger, though Duryodhana is more practiced. Krishna concludes that Bhima will only win if he abandons dharma and uses trickery, which he should, since gods often use deceit to kill demons.

The brothers Balarama and Krishna provide an interesting counterpoint to each other in this scene. As the neutral observer, Balarama proposes a duel of clubs that seems fair to all. But in an unusual moment, Krishna contradicts his brother and dharma itself, suggesting that it's so important for the Pandavas to win that it's best for Bhima to cheat. There is no simple way to explain Krishna's seeming contradictions: he is one of the most moral figures in the story and yet he also frequently advocates for underhanded tactics.



Krishna advises Arjuna that Bhima should strike Duryodhana's thigh, as he promised to do long ago during the gambling competition. Arjuna slaps his own thigh, and Bhima understands the signal. Bhima and Duryodhana both maneuver around each other to try to gain an advantage. Each gets weary, and due to blood loss, Bhima comes close to passing out. But Bhima stays on his feet, and suddenly he brings his club down like a thunderbolt on Duryodhana's thighs.

Although Bhima's attack on Duryodhana's thigh may not be honorable, this passage nevertheless provides some justification for it by presenting it as the inevitable result of a promise Bhima made long ago. Bhima's strike may not be justified in isolation, but Duryodhana's unjust gambling competition, which started the whole war in the first place, has created a moral situation in which Bhima can do whatever it takes to help the Pandavas reclaim their lost kingdom.



Duryodhana falls, and the whole earth trembles. Bhima puts his foot on Duryodhana's head and says that this is all punishment for how he treated Draupadi like a slave after the gambling competition. Yudhishtira scolds Bhima, telling him not to disrespect Duryodhana by trampling him. Balarama too curses Bhima for his actions. He says that Bhima should not have breached dharma as Krishna advised him.

While Bhima may have been justified with his trick of attacking Duryodhana's thigh, in this passage, he clearly goes too far, insulting Duryodhana and getting caught up on past grudges rather than giving Duryodhana an honorable death. The disagreement between Balarama and Krishna continues to illustrate the difficulty of living a moral life, since even two of the wisest figures in the poem can't agree on the same course of action.



Afterwards, the Pandavas go to Duryodhana's deserted camp. Krishna has to leave for important business in Hastinapura. There, he sees Gandhari and urges her not to be angry about the death of her sons, and she understands, agreeing the Kauravas brought the tragedy on themselves. Meanwhile, Duryodhana says that Aśvatthaman should be the new commander of the few remaining Kauravas.

It would seem that the war is winding down, with Duryodhana not quite dead but soundly defeated in battle and not many allies remaining. However, the next book deals with one of the most consequential attacks in the whole book, as the war continues to break down from a grand spectacle to something more pragmatic and less glamorous.



CHAPTER 10. THE NIGHT-RAID

THE NIGHT-RAID. Samjaya continues telling the story of the war to Dhritarashtra. That night, after Duryodhana's defeat, Aśvatthaman witnesses an owl hunting, and he gets the idea of a night-time attack. Some of his allies want to consult Dhritarashtra or Vidura first, but eventually, Aśvatthaman convinces them to go along with his plan. He, Kripa, and Kritavarma approach the enemy camp, where Aśvatthaman prays for protection from Śiva.

Aśvatthaman stations Kripa and Kritavarma by the gate of the camp, while he goes in himself. He sneaks into the quarters of Dhrishtadyumna, wakes him up, then refuses to give him a warrior's death by the sword, instead stomping him to death. He then goes out and kills all of Dhrishtadyumna's followers. He goes on to kill many more sleeping soldiers. With his sharp sword, he kills the sons of all the Pandavas: Prativindhya, Sutasoma, Śatanika, Śrutakirti, and Śrutasena.

Next, Sikhandin challenges Aśvatthaman, attacking him from all sides with all the weapons he has, but Aśvatthaman slices him in half down the middle. He continues slaying every Pandava ally he sees with his sword, then he gets in his chariot and starts firing off arrows. He causes chaos across the camp, and some warriors get trampled by their allies or elephants. Those that try to flee get slain by Kripa and Kritavarma by the gate. They then set the camp on fire.

Aśvatthaman walks with his sword around the burning camp, cutting off all sorts of body parts. Warriors begin killing each other so that they don't have to die by fire or by Aśvatthaman's hand. By midnight, the Pandava army is gone. Rakshasas and other demons come to feed on the corpses, bringing their wives and children. At dawn, Aśvatthaman finally leaves the camp, his sword-hilt glued to his hand by blood.

Aśvatthaman's night-raid raises some of the biggest moral questions in the poem. On the one hand, Aśvatthaman ignores the advice of his elders and decides to attack his enemies when they aren't ready, suggesting something dishonorable about the raid. On the other hand, Aśvatthaman takes inspiration for the raid from nature (by watching an owl) and prays to Śiva before going through with it, suggesting that, despite its brutality, there may be something natural and justified about Aśvatthaman's attack.



Although Aśvatthaman's treatment of Dhrishtadyumna is dishonorable, it has clear parallels to the way that Bhima trampled Duryodhana. Similarly, Aśvatthaman's killing of the five Pandava sons that they had with Draupadi parallels how the elder Pandavas killed the sons of Karna and other Kauravas. The night raid brutally balances the scale for much of the Pandavas earlier success.



When Aśvatthaman splits Sikhandin down the middle, it symbolizes that Sikhandin was born female but became a man through a boon. Although Aśvatthaman kills Sikhandin with a sword, he does so in battle, unlike his killing of Dhrishtadyumna, whom he killed by stomping. And so, while Sikhandin loses the sword fight, Aśvatthaman nevertheless acknowledges Sikhandin's status as a warrior by dueling him fairly, something that Bhishma and others were unwilling to do.



Even in a war in which heroes regularly kill tens of thousands of nameless enemies, the scale of Aśvatthaman's destruction is shocking for just one person. The purpose of the night-raid is not, however, to suggest that Aśvatthaman is the most powerful fighter of all but instead to suggest how powerful Śiva's aid is, as well as portraying a restoration of balance, with the Pandavas suffering after inflicting so many casualties on the Kauravas in battle.



Dhritarashtra asks Samjaya why Aśvatthaman didn't just do this earlier. Samjaya explains that the timing was important, and it was only possible because the five Pandava brothers, Krishna, and Satyaki were away. Samjaya continues the narrative, explaining how Aśvatthaman went back to find Duryodhana still barely alive. Duryodhana bids him farewell, hoping to meet him again in heaven, and then he dies. Samjaya then says he's finished—he has lost the gift of divine sight that allowed him to observe the whole battle.

THE REED WEAPON. With Samjaya no longer the narrator of the story, Vaiśampayana continues telling the story of the war to Janamejaya. Yudhishtira hears what happened from Dhrishtadyumna's charioteer and faints with grief. He dreads telling Draupadi that she lost her sons, her brother, and her father. Draupadi also faints at the news. She tells Yudhishtira that if he doesn't kill Aśvatthaman immediately, she'll fast to death. She says Aśvatthaman was born with a jewel in his head, and if she sees that jewel, she'll stop fasting.

Bhima, with Nakula driving his chariot, goes out to find Aśvatthaman. Yudhishtira fears for Bhima's life, so he, Krishna, and Arjuna hop in a chariot to follow him. Aśvatthaman has a special **celestial weapon** called Brahma's Head, which can take many shapes but always has four heads, like Brahma. Aśvatthaman isn't supposed to use Brahma's head against humans because it's so powerful it could destroy gods or even the whole universe. Arjuna has a similar celestial weapon, and when he and Aśvatthaman meet up, each draws their weapon and threatens to use it, putting the whole world in danger. Narada and Vyasa each appear to condemn both of them for their recklessness.

Arjuna withdraws his **celestial weapon**, but Aśvatthaman's weapon is so powerful that he physically can't withdraw it, so he tries to defend why he drew it. Vyasa says Arjuna's drawing of his weapon was more justified, since he was just defending himself from Aśvatthaman. He advises Aśvatthaman that if he just gives Arjuna the jewel from his head, the Pandavas will spare his life. Although the jewel is more precious to Aśvatthaman than any other possession, he gives it up. Since he can't withdraw his Brahma's Head celestial weapon without using it, he releases it into the wombs of the Pandava women.

As Samjaya's answer to Dhritarashtra's question shows, everything in the Kurukshetra War must happen at its appointed time. While Samjaya gives a practical answer for why Aśvatthaman didn't strike earlier, perhaps the larger reason for why Aśvatthaman's attack only came at the end is because the night raid is an act of revenge and of re-balancing the scales—had Aśvatthaman attempted the same thing earlier, he might not have received the support of Śiva, which was so crucial to his operation's success.



Although the Pandavas have won the war, they have done so at great cost, despite their valiant fighting in the previous days. Many figures in the poem bring about their downfall by acting too rashly, but in this case, Draupadi's swift desire for revenge is actually a positive character trait—because it shows that unlike her husbands, she is determined not to be paralyzed by grief and instead to take action.



With each confrontation, the stakes get higher, and so it's only natural that this climactic face-off between Arjuna and Aśvatthaman threatens to destroy the entire universe. Although the passage involves the weapons of the gods, it is arguably more about humanity's own potential for self-destruction and how rash actions in the heat of the moment have the potential to have catastrophic outcomes. By showing the dangers of passionate action, this passage shows why it's necessary to act with detachment, as Krishna advised in the Bhagavadgita.



Although Arjuna is tempted to unleash his powerful weapon, he has internalized enough of Krishna's messages about detachment to prevent himself from acting rashly. By contrast, the passionate Aśvatthaman can't control the power he yields. He tries and mostly succeeds in directing that weapon toward his enemies, trying to obliterate the Pandava lineage as revenge for what the Pandavas did to the Kauravas.



Krishna says that Aśvatthaman's release of his **celestial weapon** into the Pandava wombs fulfills a prophecy—when the Kuru lineage fails, Virata's daughter (and the late Abhimanyu's wife) will bear a son named Parikshit. Aśvatthaman says the weapon will make the child stillborn, but Krishna says the child will live anyway. Krishna curses Aśvatthaman to wander remote wastelands for 3,000 years without speaking to anyone. Aśvatthaman hands over his jewel and says he'll be glad to stay in the mortal world for a long time.

Krishna, whose motives are often mysterious, always looks at the big picture, focusing not on the suffering among all the Pandava women suffering miscarriages but instead on how this suffering leads to the fulfillment of a prophecy. And so, while the end of the war emphasizes the brutality of all-out violence, the aftermath of the war begins to explore how violence can lead to renewal. While it might seem unfair that Aśvatthaman escapes death after killing so many Pandavas, in fact, the punishment Aśvatthaman receives is arguably worse than death, since a glorious death in battle is actually a good thing in this poem, and Aśvatthaman's anonymity means he can't earn fame like a warrior should.



The Pandavas hurry back with the jewel to Draupadi to stop her fast. They explain that they've defeated Aśvatthaman, even though his body technically still lives. Draupadi is satisfied with this. Yudhishtira wears Aśvatthaman's jewel as his own. Krishna explains to Yudhishtira that Aśvatthaman's rage was only possible due to the help of Śiva, whose moods can affect the whole earth.

The final passage of this book gets at the idea that a person is more than their mortal form—an idea that's particularly relevant in Hinduism, where an individual's current mortal form is just one incarnation in a line of many. By banishing Aśvatthaman, the Pandavas prevent him from reincarnating for at least 3,000 years, arguably doing more to stop his influence than simply killing him would do.



CHAPTER 11. THE WOMEN

THE END OF GRIEF. Vaiśampayana tells Janamejaya what the Kauravas did after the death of Duryodhana. Dhritarashtra is full of grief, but Vidura tells him that the wise don't grieve for too long because life is short and death is inevitable. Although it's difficult for him, at last Dhritarashtra promises not to grieve anymore.

Vidura serves a similar role to Dhritarashtra that Krishna does to the Pandavas. Both Krishna and Vidura give the advice that a person shouldn't grieve because death is inevitable, insisting that it's better to try to make the most of life instead of regretting the past. And so, while the poem conveys the horrors of war in great detail, in the end, the wisest figures in the poem accept these horrors and move on rather than dwelling on them.



THE WOMEN. Dhritarashtra has Gandhari and the other women come to him. He tells them about the massacre of the Pandavas. Yudhishtira with some of the other surviving Pandavas comes to see Dhritarashtra, and the women wail at him, demanding to know why, if he's such a lord of dharma, he ordered the deaths of so many of his relatives.

The end of the war recalls the beginning, although now that Bhishma is dead, Yudhishtira instead crosses the battle lines to see Dhritarashtra. Although the image of the shouting mourning women is striking, Vidura's advice in the previous passage makes it clear that these women would be wiser to put aside their grief than to yell at Yudhishtira.



When Dhritarashtra sees the Pandavas, he greets Yudhishtira with a hug, but Krishna anticipates that Dhritarashtra is scheming against Bhima. Krishna sends an iron effigy of Bhima to him. As predicted, Dhritarashtra crushes the fake Bhima in his hands, then regrets it—Krishna tells him it was a trick, because Dhritarashtra was not in his right mind due to grief. At last, Dhritarashtra embraces the other Pandava brothers.

Dhritarashtra's killing of the Bhima effigy allows him to act out his grief and consider the consequences, all before learning that the whole thing was a ruse by Krishna. This passage provides further evidence of the illogical nature of grief, showing how it causes Dhritarashtra to do something he'll later regret, and so once again the poem argues for overcoming grief instead of indulging it.



The Pandava brothers then go to Gandhari. Yudhishtira apologizes to Gandhari for all the destruction, but she says everything happened according to fate. They all go down to the battlefield with the grieving women and see the bodies being eaten by scavenging animals and demons. Gandhari gives a speech about how many of the dead, while noble, were too wrapped up in pride and anger and were ultimately misled by Duryodhana. After the shock of seeing her son Duryodhana's corpse, Gandhari describes her grief to Krishna, getting angry and cursing him.

Gandhari is able to follow the advice of Vidura and Krishna, rising above grief, when she sees the many dead on the battlefield that she has little connection to. But when she actually sees her son Duryodhana lying dead, her grief overcomes her. This passage captures the personal nature of grief, acknowledging how grief can be natural and how a particularly close death like that of a child can affect even someone as wise as Gandhari.



THE OFFERINGS TO THE DEAD. Krishna advises Gandhari not to give in to grief. Dhritarashtra asks Yudhishtira to calculate the casualties, and Yudhishtira reports there are 1,660,020,000 dead and 24,165 missing. Yudhishtira promises to perform all the necessary burial rites on the bodies. They burn them all in order of seniority.

Yudhishtira's tally of the dead is almost unimaginably large—several orders of magnitude larger than the entire population of the earth today. It confirms the poem's epic scale, once again evoking a past time that was more glorious than the narrative present—although perhaps also more deadly and more brutal.



THE WATER OFFERINGS. Dhritarashtra, Yudhishtira, and the others go to the banks of the Ganga. There, the many grieving women perform water rites for the dead men. The Pandavas learn that Karna was in fact Kunti's biological son all along. Yudhishtira makes a water offering to his dead brother Karna, including Karna's mourning female relatives in the ritual.

Water once again plays a spiritual role in the poem, offering a symbolic cleanse after all the death and destruction of the Kurukshetra War. When the Pandavas learn that Karna was their brother, it makes the victory even more bittersweet, emphasizing the necessity of showing honor to strangers in battle—because you never know who that stranger might really be.



CHAPTER 12. TRANQUILITY

THE DHARMA OF KINGS. The Pandavas remain by the city near the Ganga for a month to purify themselves. Yudhishtira, saddened to learn that the dead Karna was his elder half-brother, asks the seer Narada why Karna had to die in battle. Narada explains it was fate and that Karna had the choice to side with the Pandavas but decided against it.

The poem continues to explore how war can be tragic but also necessary at the same time. Narada emphasizes that Karna's death wasn't arbitrary but a result specifically of his decision to side with the Kauravas, suggesting that while Karna's death may seem unnecessary, there actually was justice to it.



Yudhishtira tells Arjuna that he'd like to retire to the forest and perform austerities, but Arjuna rebukes him, saying that it's the dharma of a king to rule. Bhima agrees with Arjuna, and then Nakula and Sahadeva say something similar. Draupadi encourages Yudhishtira to say something, but he doesn't, so his brothers continue to give him reasons to continue acting as king. Vyasa, then Krishna, also try to help Yudhishtira overcome his grief. Vyasa recommends Yudhishtira preform a **horse** sacrifice.

Yudhishtira finally agrees to put aside his grief. He and the other Pandavas enter Hastinapura, where crowds greet them enthusiastically. Yudhishtira offers up sacrifices for all his slain relatives, and then he appoints his brothers to various positions in his kingdom. Finally, he tells his subjects they can go home.

One day, Yudhishtira comes upon Krishna and asks what he's meditating on. Krishna recommends that Yudhishtira go visit Bhishma, who, despite being defeated in battle and barely alive as he lies on a bed of arrows, knows many things about past, present, and future. Yudhishtira goes to see him with his brothers and a few others. Yudhishtira offers praise to Bhishma, mentioning that Krishna sent him, and in turn, Bhishma offers praise to Krishna. Bhishma is in too much pain from his arrows to talk, so Yudhishtira says they'll come back later.

Krishna helps ease some of Bhishma's pain and confusion, so when Yudhishtira and the others come back to see him, he can now talk at length. Yudhishtira asks Bhishma about the dharma of kings. He asks many questions like how kings should act and why kings have authority to rule. Bhishma responds, saying that kings should be vigorous and fierce but also merciful when the occasion calls for it. Kings weren't necessary back in the Krita Age, but greed, desire, and passion made leaders necessary.

Bhishma talks about dharma in the four stages of life (celibate student, householder, forest-dweller, renouncer). He says that going through these four classes is particularly important for Brahmins but can also be important for Sudras, Vaiśyas, and Kshatriyas. Because a king has so many subjects, he must understand all classes in society.

Yudhishtira is known for his devotion to dharma, and so the fact that even he considers abandoning his duties shows how deeply grief can affect a person. Under different circumstances, Yudhishtira's desire to go perform austerities might be praiseworthy, but Vyasa and Krishna remind Yudhishtira that he must follow the dharma of a king, and this means continuing to act as a leader.



When Yudhishtira and the other Pandavas return to Hastinapura, it represents a return to order, as the rightful leaders reclaim their kingdom. Yudhishtira honors his dead enemies while at the same time undoing what they did, proving that, as the lord of dharma, he knows how to maintain a careful balance.



Yudhishtira deferred to Bhishma's wisdom at the beginning of the war, and now he comes to see him again afterwards without animosity. Bhishma's bed of arrows represents the torment he must endure as a result of his defeat in battle, and yet he endures it, showing his commitment to fulfilling his purpose before he dies, passing on the wisdom he's acquired with age to help Yudhishtira reign effectively as king.



This conversation between Yudhishtira and Bhishma, which is mostly a monologue by Bhishma, is one of the longest parts of the whole poem, spanning not just the rest of this book, but the next book as well. In many ways, it is a sequel to the Bhagavadgita, focusing less on plot and more on explaining specific moral and religious questions.



Bhishma's speech deals with abstract topics like dharma, but it also provides context for the plot events that have happened so far in the poem. This explanation about different dharma in different stages of life helps explain why, for example, it was at one point dharma for Yudhishtira to disappear into the woods for 12 years, but why it was against dharma for him to do the same after the end of the Kurukshetra war (because he had to stay and fulfill his duties as king).



Bhishma gives more advice about kingship. He says a king should be liberal and generous but also unafraid to punish those who deserve it. He gives advice on how to pick trusted aides and courtiers as well as practical advice about where in the kingdom to live and how to raise revenue.

Yudhishtira asks questions about the Kshatriya dharma, which seems evil to him due to the violence it requires, but Bhishma explains that war is necessary and is a chance for bravery. Yudhishtira asks more questions about how a king should behave, and Bhishma stresses that a king's highest responsibility is to protect all creatures. The only area where Bhishma can't help Yudhishtira is to explain how a king should act when his kingdom is in ruin—for that, Bhishma says, Yudhishtira would just have to trust his instincts.

DHARMA IN TIMES OF TROUBLE. Yudhishtira asks Bhishma about how to rule a kingdom when it's in trouble due to an enemy at hand. Bhishma emphasizes good judgement and keeping the treasury full. When dealing with enemies, a king should be naturally distrustful. However, Bhishma praises kings who take in refugees.

Yudhishtira asks Bhishma about how to avoid unintentionally committing sin and where evil originates from. Bhishma says that greed is the origin of sin, and so it's possible to avoid sin by exercising self-control. They discuss dharma again, which Bhishma says is how you discover the truth, and Yudhishtira opens the discussion to include his brothers and Vidura.

Yudhishtira goes back to questioning Bhishma, asking what type of people make good friends. Bhishma advises him to avoid ungrateful people and adds that anyone who harms his friends deserves to be shunned.

THE DHARMA OF FINAL RELEASE. Bhishma advises Yudhishtira that a wise person should follow dharma in order to be released from the current, imperfect world. He advises that wisdom is the most important quality a person should have, even above wealth.

Despite fighting on the opposite side of the war from Yudhishtira, Bhishma is wise, and so the implication is that Yudhishtira—and by extension, readers of the Mahabharata—should take his advice.



Bhishma's advice in this section connects back to the recent Kurukshetra War. Although Yudhishtira has had to face the tragic consequences of war and the grief it can bring, Bhishma is yet another figure in the poem who attempts to justify war despite its cost. Interestingly, although Bhishma himself is in a desperate situation, he can't advise Yudhishtira what to do if he himself ever faces trouble in his kingdom. This suggests that struggle provides the ultimate test by showing how good or bad a leader's instincts are.



While many parts of the poem praise the benefits of austerity, Bhishma specifically advises Yudhishtira to focus on keeping a full treasury, emphasizing how Yudhishtira's dharma as a king is very different from the dharma of an ascetic.



"Sin" in the context of Hinduism means acting against dharma. Bhishma's advice against greed may seem surprising, given how he praised keeping a large treasury in the previous section, but Bhishma seems to be drawing a distinction between prudent financial decisions and more fanatical greed, like the kind that led Duryodhana into the Kurukshetra War.



Friendship runs throughout the poem, perhaps most notably in the relationship between Arjuna and Krishna. Bhishma's advice to shun ungrateful friends connects back to how the dharma of a leader involves providing good hospitality—and so an ungrateful person fails to show proper hospitality for what they receive.



Bhishma's advice in this passage has strong parallels to Krishna's advice about acting with detachment in the Bhagavadgita, showing how this idea of attaining enlightenment and leaving behind the current world reverberates through the whole poem.



Yudhishtira asks about the creation of the universe, and Bhishma tells him that the god Brahma first created the Brahmins. All humans were originally Brahmins, but then new classes arose to fulfill new necessary functions needed to make human society work. Yudhishtira asks religious questions about Vishnu and Krishna, which Bhishma answers.

The fact that Brahmins are the original class helps explain why they are at the top of the hierarchy—particularly with how important elders are in the poem (and how figures who neglect their elders often engage in self-destruction). Still, despite the significance of Brahmins, Bhishma makes it clear that every class in society fulfills a role and that it's a person's duty to fulfill the duties of their own class.



Yudhishtira wants to know about the Yoga of final release. Bhishma says that a person who wants release must avoid impure actions. The highest virtue involves “shunning all sensory objects.” When facing trouble, a king should be steadfast and avoid grief.

Bhishma's advice about shunning impure actions, while applicable to many people, also applies directly to Yudhishtira's current situation, in which he's struggling to overcome his grief. Once again, the emphasis on detachment recalls Krishna's advice in the Bhagavadgita.



Bhishma tells a story he heard about Vyasa and his son Śuka. In the story, Vyasa tells his son how to obtain release, including how yogis maintain goodness and avoid passion even in their dreams. Bhishma says more about dharma, giving yet another definition of it: “conduct of the virtuous,” based on the Vedas and other traditional teachings. He emphasizes the importance of faith.

Although this section of the poem doesn't do much to advance the overall plot, it still follows the same general structure as the rest of the poem, with broad summaries at the beginning followed by more detailed descriptions later. Here, Bhishma expands on the concepts of detachment and dharma, giving more specific examples of how to live a better life.



As he talks more about dharma, Bhishma notes that sacrifice is an important part of dharma, and for a Brahmin, non-violence is a type of sacrifice. On the other hand, chasing sensual pleasure is the opposite of dharma.

Bhishma's advice about non-violence is complicated, particularly given how he praised the necessity of war in an earlier passage and how the poem has introduced some “warrior Brahmin” characters who fulfill their dharma through fighting. Nevertheless, this passage still conveys the value of nonviolence by framing it not as inaction (which is bad) but as a kind of sacrifice (which is good).



Yudhishtira asks why he had to kill so many friends and family members as well as what role sorrow plays for humans. Bhishma cites old writings and stories about how pleasure can lead to desire and sin, noting that sometimes unpleasurable experiences are necessary. Yudhishtira then asks about the best ways that he, as a king, can prepare for his next life. Once again, the answer is dharma.

Following dharma means doing one's duty, and in this passage, Bhishma makes it clear that fulfilling one's duty may involve unpleasant experiences. Once again, Bhishma indirectly justifies the Kurukshetra War while at the same time acknowledging the immense devastation that the war caused.



Yudhishtira asks about Samkhya and Yoga, two major schools of thought. Bhishma says that followers of Yoga don't believe a nonbeliever can ever find release, whereas followers of Samkhya believe even those who don't believe in the gods can free themselves with the right knowledge. Both schools are valid, with Samkhya putting more focus on texts and Yoga putting more focus on other evidence.

Yudhishtira and Bhishma get more detailed as they discuss specific theological issues. Although Hinduism has foundational sacred texts like the Vedas and the Mahabharata, Bhishma advises against focusing on only one type of knowledge, showing how both texts and lived experience can ultimately help a person acquire knowledge and lead a richer spiritual life.



Yudhishtira asks if it's possible to escape old age and death. Bhishma replies that nothing can stop the passage of time, which inevitably takes away human lives. He adds that sometimes life can be unpredictable, with the foolish succeeding and the wise failing.

This passage is yet another one from Bhishma's speech that describes the Kurukshetra War in brief. It provides yet another description of the destruction and suggests that death is inevitable anyway. The section also notes that it's occasionally possible for foolish figures to succeed in war—at least temporarily.



Bhishma then tells Yudhishtira more about various gods, including how Brahma creates a new universe every cycle, and how Narayana, a form of Vishnu, is the "universal Self." Janamejaya interrupts the story to praise the parts about Narayana in particular. He asks to hear more about him. Vaiśampayana agrees and tells more about the relationship between Narayana and the seer Narada. Janamejaya comments that Narayana seems to be the religious figure who offers the most benefit in exchange for devotion, since, as the universal Self, Narayana is present in everything.

The universal Self is one of the most important concepts in the poem, connecting introspection and the individual self to something more universal. Some versions of the text translate universal Self as "soul" because it's the part of an individual that exists beyond their mortal body. This passage emphasizes that contemplation can also be a way to learn more about the world and perhaps even the nature of existence itself.



Vaiśampayana believes that people have many selves but that they all connect back to the universal Self. He resumes the narrative as Bhishma and Yudhishtira again discuss dharma at different stages of life. Bhishma tells a story about a Brahmin trying to connect with the universal Self and meeting a **snake**. The snake told the Brahmin about his experiences serving the Sun. In his journeys with the Sun, the snake saw a being who radiated like the Sun, and the Sun told him that this being was someone who had taken a vow to live like a beggar. This inspires the Brahmin to take a similar vow.

According to this passage, the universal Self remains constant despite cycles of death and rebirth that an individual undergoes. Bhishma's story of the Brahmin and the snake is a little mysterious, perhaps to capture the difficult nature of trying to describe something as complex as the mortal self. Interestingly, this passage praises asceticism, even though much of Bhishma's earlier advice specifically involved convincing Yudhishtira not to become an ascetic, suggesting that while Bhishma's speech is partly a reaction to Yudhishtira's current situation, it also has much broader applications.



CHAPTER 13. INSTRUCTION

THE DHARMA OF GIVING. Yudhishtira says he has a hard time staying tranquil when he sees the violent things he's done to Bhishma, who lies dying on a bed of arrows. Bhishma suggests, however, that the real forces behind this violence are bigger than Yudhishtira himself. However, Bhishma adds that destiny is nothing without human effort. Human deeds never perish, and so both good and bad deeds have consequences in future lives.

Yudhishtira continues to ask Bhishma a variety of questions, including whether men or women enjoy sex more. Bhishma tells the story of a king who got turned into a woman as a punishment by Indra but who eventually chose to stay a woman because of the greater pleasure during sex.

Yudhishtira asks about the many names for Śiva. Bhishma says there are a thousand of them, listing them in a hymn, and he emphasizes how seers have benefitted from winning Śiva's favor.

Yudhishtira asks more about Brahmins. Bhishma explains how Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, and Sudras can become Brahmins only through rebirth, and it is always difficult.

Returning to the topic of relationships, Yudhishtira asks questions about the nature of women. He believes they are fickle and that they are good at deceiving men. Bhishma agrees and says that Brahma created women at the request of the other gods in order to stop men from getting into heaven.

Bhishma's advice began in the previous book and now continues for most of the current book, emphasizing just how much wisdom he has accrued over his long life. Bhishma's bed of arrows symbolizes all the violence and suffering of the Kurukshetra War, and so Yudhishtira's conversation with Bhishma is also a way for him to confront the horrors of war. While destiny plays a pivotal role in the poem, Bhishma makes an important distinction in this moment, noting that destiny doesn't merely control people like puppets: it requires human effort to come to fruition.



The Mahabharata was compiled within the same several hundred years as the Kama Sutra, another Sanskrit text that is one of the most famous writings about sexual pleasure in history. This passage seems to be an attempt to justify the role of women in the Mahabharata's society, suggesting that it might seem like a punishment to be born a woman but that it actually has hidden benefits—like greater pleasure from sex.



The existence of so many names for Śiva suggests his importance while also getting at the idea of reincarnation by showing how the same being can have a multitude of different names.



This passage once again explores the different social classes, emphasizing the importance of each but also implying that one should ultimately strive to be reborn as a Brahmin.



Despite being fiercely protective of certain women (like his wife Draupadi), Yudhishtira ultimately has a negative view of women overall, which Bhishma agrees with. Although the poem features virtuous female figures, this passage strongly centers men, reflecting an attitude toward sex and gender in which women are a distraction to men's journey to enlightenment.



Yudhishtira asks more about how dharma relates to families and home life. Bhishma explains how it varies by class and how, for example, a Brahmin can have three wives but a Kshatriya only two. He also explains that only men can inherit wealth and how wealth inheritance also depends on social class and status. Bhishma also gives a hierarchy of “mixed” children who come from parents of different classes.

While the previous passage has a negative view of women, this passage somewhat offsets that negative view by suggesting that a man’s duty involves devotion to his wife and family. Nevertheless, Bhishma’s explanation of inheritance law—that only men can inherit wealth—makes it clear that these figures live in a patriarchal society where men hold more power.



Yudhishtira changes the subject to all the kings he killed and how he regrets it, suggesting that perhaps he should turn to a life of asceticism. But while Bhishma explains the benefits of an ascetic life, he also talks about the glory of a hero, which convinces Yudhishtira not to give up his kingship, pleasing the other Pandavas and Draupadi.

Even after hearing all of Bhishma’s earlier advice, Yudhishtira can’t let go of his ambition of becoming an ascetic. Bhishma once again shows Yudhishtira how he’s misguided: while it’s right to admire an ascetic life, ultimately, that is not the dharma of a leader like Yudhishtira, who has an obligation to his allies and his subjects.



Yudhishtira asks about gift-giving and how he should be generous as a king. Bhishma advises him on different gifts for different occasions, saying that food and drink are always good because they sustain life. Other honorable gifts are cattle, land, and the gift of intelligent conversation. Cattle gifts in particular have a long history and come with many rules and traditions—even the gods Indra and Brahma have a famous dialogue about cattle.

Earlier sections of the poem highlight the importance of hospitality, and in this section, Yudhishtira and Bhishma explore different types of hospitality in greater detail. The ranking of food and drink as the highest gifts is significant because it demonstrates how the purpose of a gift is to nourish the recipient—while food and drink do that in a literal way, other gifts like conversation do it more metaphorically.



Yudhishtira asks about performing śraddha (a ceremony for dead ancestors). Bhishma says all living things should honor their ancestors. He lists certain offerings and certain times of year that are best for performing śraddha.

While Bhishma advises against excessive mourning, he also praises holding śraddha ceremonies, showing that, while it’s best to avoid grief, it’s still important to show proper respect to the memory of the dead.



Yudhishtira asks Bhishma many more questions about virtue and sin. Bhishma gives several thoughts on dharma and adharma (the opposite of dharma). He believes that for a Brahmin nonviolence is the highest dharma and that they should not eat meat; however, a Kshatriya might rightfully eat the meat obtained from hunting a wild animal.

This passage seems to recommend vegetarianism, treating it as a natural consequence of supporting nonviolence, and yet it also allows that meat-eating might be dharma in certain conditions. Given how important food is in the poem (because it’s the most effective way to show hospitality), it makes sense that diet would be an important concern.



Yudhishtira asks who the one god is, and Bhishma cites Vishnu, giving 1,000 names for him. Bhishma adds that a wise person doesn't only focus on direct perception—the only way to reach the truth is long yogic meditation. After advising Yudhishtira to say the names of several gods and seers every morning and evening, Bhishma at last falls silent. He tells Yudhishtira to come back for the winter solstice, when he has chosen to die.

BHISMA'S ASCENT TO HEAVEN. Yudhishtira goes about performing his duties as king for 50 days until it's time to return to Bhishma with materials for a funeral pyre. There, Vyasa, Narada, and other distinguished figures attend to Bhishma. Bhishma announces that it's finally his time to die. His life breath comes out of him and flies up to heaven. The Pandavas cremate his body and then make an offering to him by the banks of the Ganga, where the goddess Ganga herself (Bhishma's mother) comes to mourn him.

The 1,000 names of Vishnu parallel the 1,000 names of Śiva and suggest that Vishnu is equally important and multi-faceted. Bhishma's final advice to Yudhishtira mirrors the eventual ending of the Mahabharata itself, which also provides some words for people to say every morning. The cycle of morning and evening represents a miniature version of the larger cycle of rebirth and death.



Bhishma witnesses the events of the Kurukshetra War from the very beginning to the ending, and so his death marks a crucial turning point, as the Pandavas complete the transition from grieving what they lost in the war to getting down to the business of running their kingdom. Bhishma's death starts with fire (his cremation) and ends with water (The Pandavas' offering by the Ganga), showing how the wise Bhishma was at one with nature in all its forms.



CHAPTER 14. THE HORSE SACRIFICE

THE HORSE SACRIFICE. Still at the banks of the Ganga, Yudhishtira grieves, but Dhritarashtra tells him not to grieve since he himself has been even more foolish and suffered more loss. Krishna similarly advises Yudhishtira to put aside his grief, since he will soon have to fight a new battle—with himself—but Yudhishtira finds this hard to do. At last, Yudhishtira agrees to put aside his grief and rule as king, and Dhritarashtra performs last rites on all of the fallen warriors.

Later, Krishna spends some time with Arjuna discussing matters of dharma. Krishna tells Arjuna stories about Brahmins who lived wisely, acting nonviolently and showing reverence to the gods. He then goes on to explain the teachings of Brahma. According to Brahma, to be free of sin, a person must free themselves from the concept of "I." A person who removes all doubts can reach a state of brahman.

Krishna and Arjuna go to Hastinapura in Krishna's chariot. They make it there, and then Krishna asks to go off to Dvaraka see his father (Vasudeva)—Yudhishtira grants this request but makes Krishna promise to come back for the upcoming **horse sacrifice**.

The fact that Dhritarashtra offers the same advice as the wise Krishna—to avoid grieving too much—suggests how much Dhritarashtra has learned over the course of the poem after witnessing the outcome of his bad decisions. Ultimately, this passage represents the culmination of everything Yudhishtira learned from his conversation with Bhishma, showing how he puts philosophy into practice—in this case, the philosophy that a king's dharma involves ignoring grief to focus on leadership.



In this discussion of dharma, Krishna explains how introspection nevertheless involves getting away from the concept of "I." "I" represents something different from the "Self" introduced earlier—"I" constitutes an exaggerated focus on a person's current mortal condition, and this is why it stops people from understanding the broader, more universal concept of brahman.



Without the Kurukshetra War to bind them together, the major figures in the poem begin to split up, as their dharma begins to take them in different directions.



Krishna goes off on his journey accompanied by Satyaki. They meet a seer named Uttanka in the desert. Krishna offers Uttanka a boon and then leaves. Since it's dry in the desert, Uttanka decides to use his boon to wish for drinking water. He soon sees a dirty naked man urinating, and the naked man offers him the urine to drink, which Uttanka refuses. Uttanka gets mad at Krishna when he sees him again, but Krishna reveals that the dirty man was Indra in disguise and his urine was the nectar of immortality. As a consolation, Krishna gives Uttanka rain clouds, and now rain in the desert is called Clouds of Uttanka.

Krishna and Satyaki make it to Dvaraka. He meets up with Vasudeva and tells him the story of the war between the Kauravas and the Pandavas. Initially, he leaves out the part about Abhimanyu dying (since he is Vasudeva's grandson), but eventually Vasudeva finds out and asks to hear this part in detail. They perform śraddha for Abhimanyu.

Meanwhile, the Pandavas are grieving in Hastinapura. Yudhishtira and some of the others decide to travel to find a treasure that Vyasa told them about. When they reach their destination, they make offerings to Śiva, then they come back with cartloads full of riches. Krishna comes back for the **horse** sacrifice. The wife of the late Abhimanyu gives birth to a son called Parikshit who dies right away (due to Aśvatthaman's use of the **celestial weapon** Brahma's Head). But to everyone's delight, Krishna offers to revive Parikshit.

Krishna gives a short speech, and Parikshit begins to stir. Parikshit goes on to become the father of Janamejaya (who is still listening to Vaiśampayana tell this story). Eventually, it comes to be time for the **horse** ceremony.

On the day of the **horse** ceremony, even Krishna pays homage to Yudhishtira, who oversees the ceremony. He will release a horse into the wild, where it will be Arjuna's responsibility to protect it with his bow. Yudhishtira lets the horse free, and it roams the entire earth. Sometimes the remaining enemies of the Pandavas try to attack the horse, but Arjuna bravely fends them off. During a fight with the king Babhruvahana, Arjuna briefly dies but gets revived by a special jewel. This helps him atone for the breach of dharma he committed by killing Bhishma.

This passage illustrates the dangers of failing to see beyond the surface level as well as perhaps the benefits of showing gratitude. Although Uttanka's decision not to drink the dirty man's urine may seem reasonable, in fact, Uttanka shows ingratitude by not accepting Krishna's boon. Perhaps the greater issue is that Uttanka didn't trust the wisdom and generosity of Krishna. Krishna's consolation gift to Uttanka at the end of this story shows how he can be merciful even to those who fail to pass his tests.



This section is yet another one that looks at the impact of storytelling, showing how Krishna tries to lessen Vasudeva's grief about Abhimanyu's death by telling the story in a certain way. The śraddha ceremony shows that Vasudeva accepts the death, honoring the dead Abhimanyu but not getting consumed by grief.



The horse sacrifice serves a similar purpose to the consecration ceremony that Yudhishtira held long ago, well before the Kurukshetra War. Like that ceremony, the purpose is to legitimize Yudhishtira's rule, showing how ritual plays a role in acquiring and maintaining power. While Krishna lets many noble characters die, choosing not to offer a boon of resurrection, he revives Parikshit because it fulfills a prophecy and because Aśvatthaman acted foolishly in passion when he drew Brahma's Head in battle, and so Krishna wants to partially counteract this rash choice.



Parikshit's birth, death, and resurrection allow the Pandava line to continue, with Krishna himself giving approval to the lineage by ensuring Parikshit's survival.



Like a standard in battle, the horse draws the potential attention of enemies, even though it is more important for its symbolic value than for any practical value. The horse symbolizes Yudhishtira's influence—if the horse is able to walk the Yudhishtira's kingdom freely, it will prove that Yudhishtira has total control within his domain. This is why Arjuna must fight so valiantly to protect the horse, even (temporarily) giving up his own life to defend it.



Arjuna fights off more enemies until finally the **horse** heads back toward Hastinapura. Yudhishtira gets word of him coming and orders the other brothers to prepare. Bhima summons all the other kings in the area. Yudhishtira begins praising Arjuna for his many successful battles. Not long after, Arjuna himself arrives with the horse in the city. Many others who have gathered in the city give Arjuna praise as he enters. A couple days later, Krishna advises Yudhishtira that the time for the ceremony is at hand.

Yudhishtira and the sacrificial priests carry out the **horse** ceremony exactly as the Vedas prescribe. They tie many animals to stakes to be sacrificed. Eventually, they kill the horse and cook its intestines according to ritual, then split its limbs into 16 parts to throw in a fire. At the ceremony's conclusion, Yudhishtira offers vast amounts of wealth to the priests who participated, then offers the earth to Vyasa. Vyasa thanks Yudhishtira but tells him to keep the earth and just pay him money. Yudhishtira says he's going into the forest, and so instead he'll divide the earth up among the four highest-ranking sacrificial priests.

Vyasa insists that Yudhishtira keep the earth, and Krishna advises him that Vyasa is correct. Eventually, they agree to have Yudhishtira's gold divided up among the four sacrificial priests, who distribute it to the rest of the kingdom. He showers all his subjects in wealth and nourishment.

When the **horse** sacrifice is over, a huge mongoose appears. Its body is half gold. The mongoose proclaims angrily that the sacrifice was not correct, because if it had been correct, he would now be all gold instead of just half gold. Janamejaya interrupts the story, since he is surprised—he thought the sacrifice sounded sufficient. Vaiśampayana explains that the mongoose was actually Anger, who was imprisoned in the form of a mongoose and who could only become free by judging the dharma of others, as he did at the horse sacrifice.

CHAPTER 15. THE HERMITAGE

THE HERMITAGE. The Pandavas rule over the earth for 15 years. Yudhishtira tries to make sure that Dhritarashtra doesn't suffer any more grief than he already has. Bhima, however, remains defiant, and Dhritarashtra, Vidura, and Gandhari all dislike Bhima's manner.

The successful journey of the horse proves once and for all that no one in Yudhishtira's kingdom has the power to take down Arjuna, and so this means that Yudhishtira has the ability to enforce his own rule. But the horse's journey is only the first part of the ceremony. The next section's ceremony gathers the public in one place, in order to have many witnesses and maximize the event's impact.



Yudhishtira's conduct during the sacrifice demonstrates how he has accepted his role as king and begun to fulfill it honorably. He pays close attention to the many steps of the ritual, showing a respect for tradition. He also takes the occasion to show off his generosity, offering large sums of money as a way of showing hospitality to the priests who help legitimize Yudhishtira's reign by participating in his ceremony.



Vyasa and Yudhishtira show their mutual respect for each other by both offering hospitality to each other and also by accepting the other's hospitality with gratitude. They ultimately arrive at a solution that benefits Yudhishtira's subjects more than Yudhishtira himself, showing his selflessness and why he deserves to be a leader.



This strange ending to the 14th book shows how even the most fitting sacrifice might nevertheless draw criticism. Rather than condemning this criticism, Vaiśampayana notes that Anger in the form of a mongoose was merely following its own dharma. And so, the final passage of the section moves beyond Yudhishtira's own dharma as a king and shows once again how different individuals must act according to their own dharma.



Although Yudhishtira's respect for his former enemies seems to be more honorable than Bhima's lingering grudge, this passage again hints at how individuals have different dharma, perhaps suggesting that Bhima is only living up to his role to have the most violent personality of his brothers.



After 15 years, Dhritarashtra asks Yudhishtira if he and Gandhari can go retire into the woods and lead a life of asceticism (with Vidura, Samjaya, and a couple others). Yudhishtira is upset, believing Dhritarashtra is unhappy about something. He tries to talk Dhritarashtra out of the idea but is unable to. Eventually, Vyasa comes and persuades Yudhishtira to grant Dhritarashtra's wish.

Although Vidura advised Yudhishtira against living an ascetic life earlier, now Vidura joins Dhritarashtra to go retire in the forest. This may seem hypocritical, but in fact, it's perfectly consistent with the idea that dharma differs depending on a person's stage of life. With the Kaurava lineage mostly exterminated, all that's left for Dhritarashtra to do is to reflect on the mistakes that led him to his current situation, and so by turning to an ascetic lifestyle, he actually does act according to his dharma (even though he used to have the dharma of a king in an earlier phase of his life).



Before he goes, Dhritarashtra gives Yudhishtira advice on running a kingdom, with the biggest piece of advice being to trust wise and educated advisors. Dhritarashtra then offers gifts to Yudhishtira's subjects in honor of Dhritarashtra's many dead sons. Dhritarashtra takes responsibility for the destructive war in a speech, but a wise Brahmin interrupts him and says that the real cause to blame for the war is fate.

Dhritarashtra may not seem like the best person to be giving advice about wise leadership, but as this book shows, the 15 years since his failure to restrain Duryodhana and stop the Kurukshetra War have given Dhritarashtra ample time to reflect on his previous leadership failures and grow. He demonstrates this newfound maturity by finally taking responsibility for the destruction of the war rather than simply lamenting it as bad luck. While the Brahmin blames fate instead of Dhritarashtra's actions, ultimately, the poem has already established that fate requires human action in order to come to fruition.



Dhritarashtra sets a date to go live in the forest. Before he goes, he asks the Pandavas to perform a śraddha for his many family members and allies who died in the war. While Yudhishtira, Arjuna, and some of the others are willing to do so, Bhima refuses. Yudhishtira apologizes for his brother, and they go ahead with the śraddha anyway. Dhritarashtra gives away so much wealth that it seems to flood the whole world.

Despite Bhima's refusal to accept it, Dhritarashtra seems to have undergone a remarkable personal transformation, with his lavish gifts seemingly attempting to compensate for his earlier failures as a leader as well as signifying how he'll no longer need his wealth after he begins living an ascetic life in the forest. Dhritarashtra's willingness to give up his material possessions shows that he is sincere about his new commitment to austerity.



At last, the time comes for Dhritarashtra and Gandhari to leave for the woods, and many residents of Hastinapura come out of their homes to grieve their departure. Kunti insists on going into the forest with them. They thus part ways with the Pandavas at last and go to a hermitage in the forest, where they learn a new way of life. The Pandavas are so sad to see them all go that they neglect some of their daily tasks.

The departure of their mother Kunti symbolizes how the Pandavas have finally learned to stand on their own, with no remaining parental figures or elders around to offer them advice. Although Kunti and the others aren't dead, the Pandavas mourn them anyway, suggesting how an isolated, ascetic lifestyle can be its own sort of death.



Eventually, the Pandavas decide to go into the forest for a visit. They happily reunite with Kunti, then they pay respects to Dhritarashtra and Gandhari. There, they also meet up with Vidura, who is very thin and who has been taking asceticism to the extreme, eating nothing but air. Vidura uses his yogic power to enter the body of Yudhishtira, leaving his own body behind as a corpse. A voice tells Yudhishtira not to cremate Vidura's body, since Vidura's body is now linked with his own body. Everyone else is astonished when Yudhishtira tells them this.

THE VISION OF THE SONS. Vyasa comes to the hermitage and tells Dhritarashtra he knows the grief he must be suffering still. Dhritarashtra and Gandhari say that what really pains them is not knowing about the brave men who died due to Duryodhana's foolishness. Vyasa tells them not to worry, that what happened was fate and that those who died were mortal incarnations of heavenly or demonic beings, and after a brief time on earth, now they have returned to their rightful realm.

That night, Vyasa plunges into the Ganga and comes back with all the dead warriors from the war, who are now living together in harmony. Although they appear lifelike, Vyasa makes them all disappear again in an instant. Vyasa says that any women who want to be reunited with their dead husbands should plunge into the Ganga, and many of them do so, taking on heavenly forms. Vaiśampayana interrupts the story to say that whoever hears this part of the story will prosper in this world and the next.

Vaiśampayana continues the story. Although Dhritarashtra remains blind, Vyasa gives him sight of his dead sons' true forms. Now Ugrasravas, who has been narrating the story of Vaiśampayana and Janamejaya this whole time, tells about how king Parikshit came down from heaven to see Vaiśampayana and Janamejaya at this point in the story. Janamejaya is in the middle of his last ritual bath as part of the **snake** ceremony. Astika, who is there to stop the snake ceremony, also comes and praises Janamejaya.

Honored by Astika's words, Janamejaya now asks to hear more from Vaiśampayana about Dhritarashtra's life in the forest. Back at the hermitage, Dhritarashtra sends the Pandavas away. Yudhishtira doesn't want to go, particularly not without Kunti, but Dhritarashtra insists that he has to get back to his people. The Pandavas head back to Hastinapura.

The visit in this passage confirms that Dhritarashtra and the others were wise to devote themselves to asceticism. Vidura's decision to leave his own mortal body and inhabit Yudhishtira's provides a literal example of how the wisdom of an older generation can continue to live on in the minds of the new generation.



For all his achievements in asceticism, Dhritarashtra can't escape his guilt for his actions from long ago. Vyasa gives advice that has already appeared in many forms throughout the poem: that death is inevitable and serves a purpose. Like Yudhishtira, Dhritarashtra has to learn how to overcome his grief.



This passage features the striking imagery of grieving women throwing themselves into the Ganga in what resembles suicide but is ultimately more of a peaceful ascent to heaven. Vyasa provides a visual example of how death isn't as permanent as it seems, temporarily showing countless dead soldiers in a lifelike state, perhaps to suggest how they will all one day be reborn.



Parikshit is in heaven because he was killed by a snake (hence the reason for the snake ceremony in the first place). His appearance to his son Janamejaya resembles the previous passage about the dead soldiers reappearing in the Ganga to their wives, connecting the interior story of the aftermath of the horse sacrifice to the frame story of Vaiśampayana talking to Janamejaya. Parikshit's reappearance once again suggests how the dead are never truly gone, both figuratively (in terms of how they live on in the minds of their descendants) and literally through rebirth.



Yudhishtira once again hesitates to do his duty and leave behind his mother Kunti, but Dhritarashtra encourages him to get back to his role as king. The fact that Dhritarashtra has reached a place where he can offer advice on dharma to Yudhishtira shows how much Dhritarashtra has grown as a character, particularly since starting asceticism.



THE ARRIVAL OF NARADA. Two years later, Narada visits Yudhishtira. He reports on what he saw when he recently visited Dhritarashtra and the others in the forest. They increased their austerities, going without a proper home to live in. In the process they became so weak that, when a fire ripped through the forest, only Samjaya was strong enough to outrun it—the others perished in the fire. Narada tells Yudhishtira not to be sad, but he and the other Pandavas can't help grieving, particularly for their mother, Kunti, who is one of those that died. Yudhishtira sends someone to gather the bones and perform a purification ritual.

In a way, the Pandavas have already mourned the death of Kunti and Dhritarashtra, accepting that they would die out in the forest while performing austerities. While it's possible this passage is warning about the dangers of taking asceticism too far, it seems more likely that in fact it's a celebration of Kunti and Dhritarashtra's last days, showing how they gave up everything in their pursuit of asceticism, finally achieving total detachment from the world and accepting their inevitable deaths.



CHAPTER 16. THE CLUBS

THE CLUBS. Thirty-six years after the war at Kurukshetra, Yudhishtira sees unlucky portents. He learns that Krishna has died. Janamejaya interrupts to ask how it happened, and so Vaiśampayana goes back to tell the story in more detail.

The quick passage of 36 years suggests that nothing very eventful has happened, implying that the Pandavas have been successful in restoring their rule. Krishna's death, however, represents a significant change, given his role in helping guide their return to the throne.



A prophecy states that Krishna's son will give birth to a giant club that will wipe out all of his line, the Vrishnis, and a related group called the Andhakas, with the only survivors being Krishna himself and his brother Balarama. Furthermore, the prophecy states that Krishna himself will be killed by Jara (a hunter whose name means "old age" in Sanskrit). One day, as predicted, Krishna's son Samba gives birth to a mighty club. The appearance of the club coincides with growing discord, with spouses betraying each other and people disrespecting their elders.

The giant club that wipes out Krishna's line may be connected to the duel of clubs at the climax of the Kurukshetra war, where Krishna advised Bhima to put aside dharma and use tricky tactics against Duryodhana. Just as the duel of clubs represented one of the most acrimonious phases of the war, the birth of the new club here seems to suggest growing discord in Krishna's lineage. Perhaps the club is Krishna's punishment for advising Bhima to use dirty tactics, although, as usual, Krishna seems prepared to accept his fate.



Krishna senses bad portents. He and Balarama lead the Vrishnis and Andhakas on a pilgrimage to the ocean. Satyaki gets into a fight with another warrior and decapitates him. This turns the rest of the camp against Satyaki. One of Krishna's sons comes to Satyaki's aid, but the rest of the camp beats them both to death with dirty dishes, despite Krishna's attempts to stop them. This angers Krishna, who turns some grass into a club and starts killing anyone in his way.

Even the survivors of the deadly Kurukshetra War like Satyaki ultimately die at some point over the course of the poem. Like Duryodhana, who was trampled after losing the duel of clubs, Krishna's sons also suffer embarrassments, being hit by dirty dishes. Krishna, who has frequently advised others not to succumb to grief or passion, gets overcome with a violent desire for revenge. This could suggest that in his mortal form, even Krishna is fallible, or it could be a case of justified violence, in which Krishna correctly doesn't let his grief stop him from taking action.



Krishna leaves the carnage to go meet Balarama in the forest. When Krishna arrives, however, he sees a **snake** crawl out of Balarama's mouth, and Balarama leaves his human body behind. Krishna continues to go wandering in the forest. One day while Krishna is absorbed in Yoga, the hunter Jara mistakes him for a deer and shoots him with an arrow. Jara is frightened when he learns that he has mortally wounded a human, but Krishna reassures him that all is going according to fate. Soon, Krishna heads up to heaven, where Indra and a whole procession of heavenly figures greet him.

Snakes in the poem often lead to death or represent it, and so the snake coming out of Balarama's mouth suggests a type of death, even though Balarama's abandonment of his body might not be a death in the traditional sense. Krishna's death is both a random mistake and the will of fate, as one of the most powerful warriors gets taken down by a mere hunter. While Krishna's death may seem unfitting for someone so great, Krishna ultimately shows dignity in death by accepting it, and this is what leads him into heaven with Indra.



Arjuna hears about the recent slaughter and goes to investigate. When he gets there, Arjuna helps provide for the bereaved women and children. He warns them that the ocean will soon engulf their whole city. He then finds Krishna's body and arranges a funeral pyre, where Krishna's four living wives decide to join him, burning themselves alive. Arjuna leads the surviving Vrishni women to found a new settlement on fertile land.

As perhaps Krishna's most devoted friend, Arjuna takes responsibility for Krishna's funeral arrangements. While the suicide of Krishna's wives seems to suggest that a wife's life isn't worth living without her husband, the very next part of the poem contradicts this, showing how Arjuna leads the bereaved wives of the Vrishni men to start a new life on fertile land, suggesting the value of starting anew.



As Arjuna leads the Vrishnis, however, some robbers suddenly attack them. Despite Arjuna's fierce fighting, the bandits abduct many women. Arjuna despairs that he can't save them all. After the bandits are gone, he passes off kingship of the survivors in the new settlement to someone else and then goes to see Vyasa. Vyasa asks Arjuna why he looks so disappointed, and Arjuna explains recent events. Vyasa reassures him that everything happened as fate decreed and that Arjuna couldn't have changed anything.

While Arjuna was able to protect the horse from all attackers during the horse ceremony, his inability to protect the Vrishni women from robbers shows a decline in the influence and abilities of the Pandavas, perhaps as a natural result of old age. It's impossible to fully resist aging, which is perhaps why Vyasa consoles Arjuna with the knowledge that he was fated to lose some of the Vrishnis to robbers.



CHAPTER 17. THE GREAT JOURNEY

THE GREAT JOURNEY. After hearing of the slaughter with clubs, Yudhishtira decides to go on a great journey. Before leaving, he consecrates Parikshit as king. He also holds śraddha ceremonies for Krishna and Balarama. Then Yudhishtira leaves the city of Hastinapura, accompanied by his four brothers, Draupadi, and a dog.

By consecrating Parikshit as the new king, Yudhishtira seems to be finally getting his wish to become an ascetic in the forest, having finally reached the stage in his life where this is an appropriate choice rather than a refusal to do his duties as king.



The Pandavas live ascetic lives as they travel, performing Yoga and trying to act according to dharma. They meet the god Fire, and Arjuna offers up his formidable bow that he used in the war. They continue traveling north until Draupadi's Yoga fails, and she falls down. Bhima feels that her fall isn't dharma, but Yudhishtira says they must press on, and so they leave her behind.

Yoga in the Mahabharata is more about meditation and is not necessarily connected to physical exercise or poses in the way that the word "yoga" is often used today. Nevertheless, this passage illustrates a connection between mind and body, showing how Draupadi's physical deterioration comes after her spiritual meditation fails.



Soon after, Sahadeva falls. Then Nakula falls, Arjuna falls, and Bhima falls, leaving Yudhishtira to walk forward alone with the dog. Indra comes down to Yudhishtira and asks him to mount a chariot. Yudhishtira is apprehensive, saying he doesn't want to go to heaven without his brothers and Draupadi. Indra tells him to stop grieving and also that he must leave behind the dog. Yudhishtira refuses to leave the dog.

This scene was foreshadowed in a much earlier passage, in which the four youngest brothers all drank from a pool of water and dropped dead for a brief period of time, and Yudhishtira alone had the wisdom not to drink. Yudhishtira's refusal to leave his dog shows that he values loyalty so much that he'll refuse to go to heaven even for the sake of an animal in order to remain loyal.



When Yudhishtira keeps refusing to abandon the dog, it eventually reveals itself as the god Dharma in disguise. He praises Yudhishtira for his loyalty, even to a dog. Several other gods gather to watch as Yudhishtira mounts the chariot, becoming the first to reach Indra's heaven in his mortal body. But despite the splendor of the place, Yudhishtira says he would rather be wherever his brothers and Draupadi are.

Dogs are often associated with loyalty, and by returning the favor, Yudhishtira demonstrates harmony with nature—he honors Dharma, even when he doesn't realize that Dharma has disguised himself. Indra allows Yudhishtira to enter heaven in his mortal body, perhaps suggesting how Yudhishtira lived a life so full of dharma that he is already ready to go to heaven in his current form.



CHAPTER 18. THE ASCENT TO HEAVEN

THE ASCENT TO HEAVEN. When he first enters Indra's heaven, Yudhishtira sees Duryodhana seated on a royal throne. He immediately says he doesn't want to live in any realm where Duryodhana is a king. Narada advises him to put aside his anger because hostility has no place in this heaven. Yudhishtira protests that if this is truly Indra's heaven, he should see other dead heroes like Karna, Satyaki, and Dhrishtadyumna. He asks again to see his brothers and Draupadi.

While the end of the previous book might have seemed to suggest an end to all of the Pandavas' struggles, the final book begins with the surprising imagery of Duryodhana on a throne in heaven, with none of Yudhishtira's other dead friends and family around. This book suggests that death isn't the end of the journey, an idea that could tie in to the concept of rebirth.



The gods tell Yudhishtira that if he wishes to be back with his brothers, he may go. He follows an "agent" of the gods on a dangerous path out of heaven, passing places where he sees evil-doers being tortured. At last, the agent says Yudhishtira has to keep going on his own. Yudhishtira keeps going until he hears voices in pain. The voices cry out that they are his brothers, Draupadi, and the other famous warriors that died in the war. Yudhishtira is full of grief and wonders if he's gone mad to hear such distinguished voices in such a wretched place.

Yudhishtira finds that heaven is the opposite of what he expected. The voices that Yudhishtira hears and the scenes he witnesses seem to be tailored specifically to upset him. This jarring scene questions the whole premise of the poem, suggesting that Yudhishtira, the lord of dharma, might not have been following the correct life path after all.



After a while, Indra and the other gods come to see Yudhishtira, and all the torture and despair that he heard and witnessed goes away. A cool breeze blows, and Indra tells Yudhishtira that the gods are pleased with him. He explains that all kings must see hell at some point and that good kings must go to hell before going to heaven, while bad kings do the reverse. He shows Yudhishtira that Arjuna, Bhima, Nakula, Sahadeva, and Draupadi are all safe, along with the other warriors from the war.

After the fake-out in the previous passages, this passage once again confirms that Yudhishtira is a virtuous character who has found favor with the gods and reached a true heaven. The hell that Yudhishtira literally goes to is also the symbolic embodiment of how a king must figuratively be prepared to go to hell in order to ultimately reach a heavenly outcome in his kingdom.



Vaiśampayana interrupts the story to explain how a person has to leave heaven after exhausting their good deeds—eventually, then, all of the great heroes take on new incarnations. He then ends the story of the Kauravas and the Pandavas.

While the story of the Pandavas concludes with the Pandavas living happily in heaven, Vaiśampayana makes sure to mention that people don't stay in heaven forever, suggesting that whether in mortal life or in the afterlife, a person always has the responsibility to take action and try to achieve fame.



Now Ugrasravas the Suta, who has been narrating the entire events of the poem, begins to conclude his story. After Janamejaya heard the whole story from Vaiśampayana, he left the **snake** sacrifice and went back to Hastinapura. Vyasa, who first composed the Bharata tale that Vaiśampayana told, took three years to create it, and he did so for the sake of dharma. Vyasa also composed a hymn of a few short verses to go along with his tale. The hymn questions why everyone doesn't follow dharma, when dharma is eternal and flows through everything. Anyone who recites the hymn every morning will receive a reward, and anyone who recites the full *Mahabharata* itself will attain perfection.

The poem ends much like how it started—with the characters singing the praises of the power of storytelling. Vyasa promises that his hymn has the literal power to reward people who recite it often enough, just as several figures assert that reciting the Mahabharata itself helps people achieve victory in life. The final passage centers the concept of dharma, showing that, across its sprawling length, the Mahabharata continues to explore the ideal way for people to live.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Gahr, Tim. "Mahabharata." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 22 Jun 2023. Web. 23 Jun 2023.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Gahr, Tim. "Mahabharata." LitCharts LLC, June 22, 2023. Retrieved June 23, 2023. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/mahabharata>.

To cite any of the quotes from *Mahabharata* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Vyasa. *Mahabharata*. Penguin. 2009.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Vyasa. *Mahabharata*. New Delhi: Penguin. 2009.